

Phil 301 The Philosophy of Mind

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 301 • Dr. James Orr

Contents

Lecture 1. The Question of Mind

Lecture 2. Mind Before Modernity

Lecture 3. Mind as Mechanism

Lecture 4. Mind Meets Science

Lecture 5. Reducing the Mind

Lecture 6. Mind Beyond Matter

Lecture 7. Mind Reconsidered

Lecture 8. Mind in Machine?

Lecture 1: The Question of Mind

At a glance — Orr opens an eight-lecture introduction to the philosophy of mind and why it is among philosophy's hardest problems.

- 1.1** Welcome, everybody, to the first lecture in a series entitled Introduction to Philosophy of Mind. Philosophy of mind is one of the most difficult and intriguing areas in all of philosophy, because it deals with one of the most unfathomable mysteries that we know in modern philosophy, at least. That mystery is this strange feature of the world, that we are in it as conscious beings. We can think about the world. We can speak about the world. We are subjects. We've got an internal private theater of beliefs and experiences.
- 1.2** Just think about what's happening right now. As I'm speaking, there are patterns of activity in my brain which are firing away. And somehow— and this is the kind of mystery we're going to be exploring—all those firings in the brain are turning themselves into thoughts, beliefs, sentences, creating sounds, and those sounds are being conveyed over sound waves into your ears, and they're being translated, as if by magic, into beliefs, questions, objections, boredom, feelings, sensations.
- 1.3** This is an extraordinary thing, because what has thought and mind and consciousness and what's going on when we're feeling and thinking and experiencing got to do with physical science? Science is just science. Physics is just physics. It's just the world of the objective.
- 1.4** But what we're talking about is the world of the subjective, merging itself, coming from objective to subjective, my brain to my mind, my beliefs, which then gets translated into the objective, sound waves that any scientist can describe, into your ears and your brains that any scientist can describe; and then boom, magically, back into the subjective, your subjective. How can we understand this? How do we make sense of this?
- 1.5** Well, this is what we're going to be exploring over the next eight lectures. There are lots and lots of different aspects to this problem, lots of different versions of stating it. It's going to take us on a big historical roller coaster ride, starting from the very beginning of Western thought, back to Socrates, actually even back before Socrates, all the way up through the first millennium, late Antiquity, the medieval period, so 1100 to 1300, 1350, then into the early modern period, 1600 to 1800.
- 1.6** Then, finally, we'll be looking at the last three or four lectures at the contemporary debate. We'll see immediately, as we come through those historical hinterlands into the contemporary landscape of debates around the philosophy of mind, we'll see immediately why it is that objective-subjective, brain-mind, nonconscious-conscious pairing is such a difficult one for modern philosophers to cope with. I'll give you a sneak preview as to why.

- 1.7** That's because we live in an age in which science dominates our view of what counts as really real, of what counts as really true, really reliable. The dominance of science over the last 200, 250 years has, as it were, had a big impact on philosophy, so that a lot of philosophers take the view, particularly in the Anglo-American tradition, a lot of these philosophers take the view that philosophy has got to be a backseat passenger to the natural sciences. Really, the philosopher's only job is simply to describe or maybe arrange or organize what the scientists tell us is the case.
- 1.8** Such as these has been the success of science, scientific inquiry, and technological revolutions. The reason I want to start way, way back in with the pre-Socratics and with Plato in ancient Greek thought, and the reason I want to take us—and please be patient with me—the reason I want to take us through 1,500 years of the history of this problem before we get to the modern world is to help you understand how many options are actually on the table, and how unusual the modern obsession is with reducing everything down just to physics and just to science.
- 1.9** Before this approach, before this modern approach, it was just obvious to many ancient philosophers and ancient theologians, whatever their actual perspectives, it was simply obvious that the material world, the scientifically describable world, was just one aspect of reality, but not the only one. Very, very few believed it to be the only one. The scientific revolution has brought us, of course, many blessings, but also many confusions.
- 1.10** Nowhere are those confusions more acute than when it comes to studying what mind is, what intelligence is, what reason is. What is it we're doing when we're reasoning, when we're believing, when we're feeling? We'll be tackling a lot of these different questions. It'll help us understand history, the history of ideas. It'll help us understand — this question is so key that it's a very quick way of getting to grips with some key philosophers and understanding their larger world views.
- 1.11** It also helps us to understand what's going on, particularly in the West, over the last five, six hundred years, from the 15th, 16th century onwards, and how to understand what's going on behind the scientific revolution, behind the Enlightenment, and all the patterns and the complex patterns in the history of ideas. Again, tackling the problem of mind is a very, very effective way into understanding what's going on there.
- 1.12** Of course, this debate has huge implications today when we come to think about the issue of artificial intelligence. It always amuses me that it's called artificial intelligence, but of course, a lot of philosophers believe that all intelligence is artificial. That is to say, all intelligence is basically the firings of synapses in the brain. It's not really intelligence. It's just the synaptic fizz within our brains. We call it intelligence, as if it's something over and above cells communicating with each other, just through the laws of physics.

- 1.13** But it's something that's going to be more and more important in debates in public policy around AI. We'll be looking, just in the final lecture, at some of those developments and some of the confusions around what AI is and, in particular, whether so-called strong AI is ever possible. I'm going to argue that it isn't. Even if there are forms of weak AI where it does, an AI capability will be basically indistinguishable from a human being, that doesn't mean that AI machines have that interiority, that subjectivity, that capacity for consciousness, the capacity for belief, the capacity for feeling, and the capacity for freedom.
- 1.14** It's very plausibly, what is it that makes us free? It can't be our bodies, because bodies, by definition, are physical objects. So bodies are only physical objects. Therefore, objects that are only physical objects can only be shaped and determined by the laws of physics. Nothing else. If it's a physical body, it's the domain of physics. But we don't really believe that. We believe there's something else that affects our decision and how we act in the world.
- 1.15** Namely, us. There's an "I" within the bodies. But how is it related to the body? Does it inform the body? Does it sit in the pineal gland, as Descartes thought? How does that work? But it does seem to be—this idea that we can transcend physics seems to depend upon this idea that there's an activating principle that is not merely physical, that is over and above physics. Those who believe in the reality of mind and consciousness and soul, call it what you will, insist that that's the animating principle.
- 1.16** That's the reason that the body can do things that are not predictable by the physicist. In theory, the omniscient physicist, the physicist who knows all physical facts that there are to be known about me, in principle, if there's no such thing as mind, that physicist should be able to predict absolutely everything I do for the rest of my life. That's the claim of people who say that there's no mind, it's just matter, it's just brain.
- 1.17** Those who resist that view say no, the omniscient physicist, even if he knows every single physical fact about me and every single neurological fact about my brain, is still not going to be able to predict what I'm going to have for breakfast tomorrow morning. It's not going to be able to do it. Why? Because physics stops at the mind and at consciousness. It is a completely different domain. Only I have privileged private access into what I'm going to do or what I'm going to try to do.
- 1.18** Obviously, you can see, with questions of freedom, responsibility, determinism, this has a big impact on how we understand, for example, something like criminal justice. Do we think of something— do we think that, if it's our brain states that are accounting for our behavior, and not our will and our desire, our freedom, then obviously we're going to have a very different understanding of deterrence and the punitive rehabilitation functions of the criminal justice system.
- 1.19** Finally, personal meaning. Personal meaning. At the deepest level, these questions, the question of mind, the question of consciousness, goes right to the heart of: Who am I?

What am I? I'm not an object. I'm not just a body. I'm not just an object of scientific inquiry. What am I? Some philosophers will use the language of mind or subjectivity or maybe consciousness. Those are quite new words on the whole.

- 1.20 In the Greek philosophical tradition and in the theological tradition, the word that's most commonly used is soul. At various points in these lectures, I'll be using the word soul, particularly in the more historical chapters. Then, as we get more into the recent history of philosophy of mind, I'll be using the language of mind or consciousness. But I would suggest that there isn't a radical distinction between what these different words refer to.
- 1.21 I don't want to overstate that, but the crucial point is that there's some non-material anchor, there's some non-material locus, for what it is to be me, that the physical sciences will always be unable to fathom and determine. A quick preview of what we're going to be doing—we're going to be tracing human thoughts or Western thoughts, best attempts to answer these questions. We're going to start, as I said, from ancient Greece, and we're going to go right up to contemporary debates about modern AI.
- 1.22 It's not meant to be a history lesson. I believe that contrast is the mother of clarity, and that, as we look at these different chapters, we look at these different attempts to resolve these puzzles, we'll start to be able to develop a comparative spectrum of our own, and start to see how these different positions might contrast with each other, but also might overlap. You'll get a sense of, actually, how there's a pattern, there's a shared pattern, in many of the responses.
- 1.23 Really, it's three, I mean, if we come down to it crudely, it's mind; mind is the most important thing. No mind, just matter, and that doesn't matter; that's OK. Then, really, the third option is some combination of the two. That's really what would be all of the different options. It can really be classified into one of those three options. We'll see that, at different points in the history of the problem, the account of how mind and world, or mind and body, get on changes quite a great deal, often for reasons that are logically independent of the actual problem, but are as much external pressures on the issue from elsewhere.
- 1.24 For example, in the wake of the scientific revolution, well, we've just had a scientific revolution. You can't tell us that human beings driving the scientific revolution aren't completely scientific objects. I mean, that's a slightly silly way of putting it, but it's true. The scientific revolution changed the intellectual climate to the point where, beforehand, if you were rejecting the soul, you were rejecting the mind, then this was a problem. This was a very unusual, strange thing to do.
- 1.25 After the scientific revolution, if you're coming up with some nonscientific account of what human beings are, then the burden of proof is on your shoulders to discharge. So, we'll be looking in the first couple of lectures at the ancient and medieval foundations. We'll be looking at Anaxagoras, we'll be looking at Plato, we'll be looking at Aristotle,

we'll be looking at Plotinus, St. Augustine, and St. Thomas Aquinas, moving into the 13th century.

- 1.26 And then, a little bit, we'll have a glimpse at some late medieval thinkers, to set up lectures 3, to set up lecture 3, in particular, we'll be looking at the great figure of René Descartes, 1596 to 1650. In his *Meditations* of 1641, there we have this watershed moment in the history of the philosophy of mind. That's really where modern discussions of the problem begin.
- 1.27 Then, in the second half of the lecture series, moving into lectures 4, 5, 6, 7, all the way up to 8, we'll be looking at the contemporary scene in the postwar period. Then it will get less historical and more philosophical. We'll be looking at all the different attempts to model mind and to understand it, to grasp it in a way that is consistent with the scientific revolution, the scientific picture of the world.
- 1.28 These aren't just what we'll be looking at; these won't be disconnected philosophical positions. They'll be influenced by slightly different things. Some might have religious concerns and doctrinal concerns that will put particular pressure on a theory. Others will be purely secular. Some will be rationalistic, some will be materialistic—a rationalistic, that is to say, putting a stress on pure reason, and materialistic, just this idea that everything is matter and nothing else.
- 1.29 And so, this is the basic landscape. You'll see that, in the ancient period, older periods, it's just taken for granted that there is mind, there is soul. The question is really how it relates to the physical world; whereas today, the basic assumption is that everything is scientific, everything is physical, so are you, so is consciousness, so is thinking and feeling—all of that is to be explained in purely physical terms.
- 1.30 Let's begin. Let's begin with lecture 1 and start right, right back. This is really as far back as we get, as we can find serious thinking about the reality of mind in the Western tradition. I'm not going to start with Socrates or Plato. I'm going to go one behind them to this figure called Anaxagoras. Anaxagoras, born around about 500 BC, dies around about 428, 427, almost probably roughly the same year as Plato is born. Anaxagoras, rather unfairly, is classified in this basket of philosophers called the pre-Socratics, the pre-Socratics.
- 1.31 Twice in the history of philosophy, a thinker has come along who was so revolutionary that you can put the word, the prefix "pre" in front of their name and say, "Before them, philosophy was that way; after them, philosophy was this way." Those two philosophers are Socrates, roughly 470 BC to 399 BC, and the other was Immanuel Kant, 1724 to 1804. Those two philosophers represented these watershed moments.
- 1.32 But Anaxagoras is no mean thinker. We've got, most of what we have from him is in fragments. He was friends with the great leader of Athens, Pericles. In fact, this was a cause of great suspicion among the Athenians, that Pericles was hanging out with this strange philosopher with mad ideas. It's often tempting to think that people like

Anaxagoras and Socrates were held up as these glorious intellectual rockstars and celebrities in ancient Athens. They absolutely were not.

- 1.33** They were seen as subversive troublemakers, strange, refusing to conform, and Anaxagoras was no different. But he's the first philosopher who develops an account of what's called in Greek "nous." Sometimes we use the word nous in English, nous, N-O-U-S. We can just about translate it as mind, but it also means, it can mean understanding. It can mean intellect. It can mean all your cognitive capacities and functions. I'll translate it as mind, but just bear in mind that it is much richer and more expansive than that as a word in Greek.
- 1.34** Nous, for Anaxagoras, is what moves and drives and organizes the world. Anaxagoras thinks that mind, or nous, is separate from all things, that it's unmixed, uncontaminated; it's pure, and it's what pushes, keeps the world in motion, but it remains distinct from what it moves. You can see here, even in this quite crude early reflection on what mind is, this notion that, well, whatever it is, it can't be mixed with stuff.
- 1.35** It can't be mixed with technical philosophical jargon for all material things. Stuff, like concrete stuff, physical stuff, that you can see and touch and smell in here. Concrete objects, concrete physical objects. Now, it's not clear quite how he reaches this view, but he says it's got to be separate from material things. The mind is not material; it's not stuff, so it can't be connected, it can't be associated with it.
- 1.36** In particular, he thinks that what's going on with our own minds is that we participate—is the language he uses—we participate in, capital M, big-daddy Mind, but we're limited by our bodies. We can't get to the unmixed pure mind because, as it were, we're trapped. Our little fraction, our little participation in mind, is limited and constrained by our bodies, our embodiment. So we've got this notion of mind being fundamental. It's what organizes the world. It's what makes the world intelligible.
- 1.37** How is it that we can inspect the world? We can do science on the world. We can read the world. The world is legible to us. That's quite a surprising thing. It might so easily have been completely opaque, completely unintelligible, and yet we can do it. We can understand it. We can match our reason and our mind to the world, and extraordinary things come out of it. Would one have predicted that at the beginning of the world? Would one have predicted that at the Big Bang? It's not obvious at all.
- 1.38** Certainly, on naturalism, if all there is nothing mental, nothing to do with mind, nothing to do with intelligence, nothing to do with reason or ideas, it's just stuff, plus laws, plus chance, plus maybe some weird things going on in the quantum world, you wouldn't expect, necessarily, you wouldn't expect at all a world to emerge that was generating or had laid the enabling conditions for beings who could read the world, that it would bring about knowers of the world, and that there would be a world that could be known, that was open to being understood and open to being known.

- 1.39** The more one reflects on that—this is the old Einstein quote. I'm never quite sure if he said it. I've never tracked it down. But he has this wonderful line somewhere, "The only incomprehensible thing," unbegreiflich, "the only incomprehensible thing about the world is that it is comprehensible." It is begreiflich. Conceptually, it can be understood in conceptual terms. This is an extraordinary thing that we can grasp the world, we can understand it.
- 1.40** This, I think, is what is driving Anaxagoras. He sees that there's some cosmic principle that is rendering the world legible to us. Because we're not imposing what we think is true of the world; scientists aren't imposing pictures on the world. At least that's not all they're doing. We don't just invent scientific truths. We discover them. We discover them, and the reason we know that we're discovering them, rather than inventing them, is that we can do experiments on the world. We can manipulate the world for our own ends.
- 1.41** And it works. Technology works. If it was just us making it up as we went along, why would the world be so responsive to the knowledge that we then distill into technology, that can then manipulate the world successfully for us? That suggests that there really is—the way we're understanding the world, really is true. It's not just us imposing ideas on it. If it seems odd for me to press that point, believe me, there are many, many philosophers—probably, I'm in a minority on this point.
- 1.42** The majority of philosophers would probably say, would sign up to something like scientific anti-realism. The idea that we're not actually—what we're doing in science is not actually coming up with a framework of truths about reality. We're coming up with a framework, which is useful to us, which makes sense to us. But it's basically, one day we'll ditch it and pick up another one, and the world just carries on as it was.
- 1.43** Anaxagoras rejects this. He says, "There is something intelligible that is something that must explain why the world is intelligible, even though it's just stuff." That explanation can't be an explanation that just studies stuff. It can't be a physical explanation; it's got to be something else. It's got to be something that makes things intelligible. Rocks don't make things intelligible. Atoms on their own don't make things intelligible. There must be something else. Intelligent, that is to say, conscious beings make things intelligible.
- 1.44** That's Anaxagoras, and that's really to set the stage for a thinker, a philosopher, who has had more influence, probably, on the question of philosophy of mind than any philosopher all the way up to Descartes, and possibly even more so than Descartes, in terms of all the different schools that he has influenced, and that is Plato.
- 1.45** Plato is born round about 429, 428 BC. He's an aristocrat. He's an Athenian from a noble family, very embedded in the messy world of Athens in the 420s and 410s, and all the way up to the end of the fifth century BC, when Athens is in a struggle for survival against Sparta in the Peloponnesian War, 431 to 404. Plato, it's not clear that he

wanted to be a philosopher. He didn't really; he wasn't particularly interested in it. But he meets Socrates, meets his great teacher, probably when Socrates is in his 60s.

- 1.46** He's just a teenager. He decides, pretty much then and there, that this man has so much charisma, so much understanding of the world, so much knowledge, is so fascinating and absorbing, that he would devote the rest of his life to becoming this man's scribe and finest student. This is what he does. He writes around about 35 documents, dialogues, in effect. You read them, and it's like reading a conversation in a bar. Sometimes there actually was a bar, like a drinking party, or at a dinner, or maybe Socrates on a walk outside the city.
- 1.47** It's not long speeches, it's not long tracts, it's just conversation. A number of those, the most important of these dialogues, touches on the question of mind and of nous. I want to look at two of these dialogues in particular from the middle period, Plato's middle period. We're talking probably around about the 380s BC. We'll look at three dialogues altogether. We'll look at, the first one is the so-called, the Phaedrus, and then we'll move on to the Phaedo and to The Republic.
- 1.48** The names of the dialogue are normally the names of the leading interlocutors. So Phaedrus is a wonderful dialogue in which Socrates develops a famous allegory. It's the allegory of the charioteer. And what he says is, he says, look, the soul, and the Greek word for soul is psyche, P-S-U or Y-C-H-E, psyche. We have, obviously, that word in psychology today, psychiatry, and confusingly, because psychology offers itself up as a science of the psyche.
- 1.49** But of course, if the psyche is not a material object, how can you have a science of it? How could psychology be possible unless they've cracked the mind-body problem? They haven't told me about that. But we'll come on to the confusions that modern psychology and psychoanalysis gets itself into by assuming that the mind is some mysterious physical object.
- 1.50** So Plato says, this charioteer, and the soul is the charioteer; or you might say, I should say, the upper part of the soul, the highest part of the soul, for Plato, which is "tò logistikon," reason, the logisticking bit of the soul of the person. And what this charioteer is trying to do is to steer a chariot that is being pulled by two horses.
- 1.51** And the first horse is the noble horse, and this is supposed to represent what the Greeks call "thumos" T-H-U-M-O-S. This is the domain of spirit, of courage. It's a white horse, white in color with black eyes, loves honor with temperance and modesty, doesn't need a whip. You can just tell the white horse what to do, and the white horse will do it.
- 1.52** And then the second horse is the ignoble horse, the horse that represents appetite, base desires, or in the Greek, "epithumia" E-P-I-T-H-U-M-I-A. This horse is crooked, old, short neck, gray eyes, shaggy around the ears, doesn't listen to what the charioteer

says; the charioteer has to use his whip. Here we've got this picture of the soul. This is Plato's picture of the soul, with this image of the charioteer.

- 1.53** Plato's idea is that the charioteer charges around the upper heavens and tries to keep these horses in check. But occasionally, souls fall out of this huge chariot race up in the heavens. The soul falls down. The soul that falls down has to then navigate his way through the messy world of time and change and physics.
- 1.54** What do we make of this allegory? Well, we shouldn't read too much into it, but it gives us a very good sense of how fast Plato's moved discussions on from Anaxagoras. The allegory, the picture, is supposed to help us think in terms of both the unity of the soul, the unity of ourselves as persons. We are unified. It's I who want to have bacon and eggs for breakfast. It's I who then decide and try to work out what to do in order to get my bacon and eggs for breakfast. It's I who will show courage if somebody tries to take my bacon and eggs from me, and I'll confront them.
- 1.55** And yet, also, these are different aspects of how I engage in the world. One is to do with my appetites: I want breakfast. Another is to do with my reason: I'm going to decide how to go about finding somewhere to have breakfast. Another, this sense of courage that comes to the fore, maybe when I'm threatened or when my breakfast is being threatened, is a distinct aspect, Plato thinks.
- 1.56** We may agree or disagree with him about how to allocate or understand these different aspects, but they are distinct ways of engaging the world. When I want something, when I desire something, what I'm doing is I'm trying to conform the world to how I would like it to be. I'm trying to make sure that that plate of bacon and eggs is on the table when I want it. My desire is driving the world to be a particular way that I want it to be.
- 1.57** When I have beliefs about the world, it's the opposite. When I'm trying to form correct, accurate beliefs about the world, I'm not trying to conform the world to me. I'm trying to conform myself to the world. My mind—I'm trying to make sure my mind is correctly mapping out the world, so that I can form true beliefs about it. So, to desire something and to believe something are completely different kinds of things. The traffic, can you see the traffic is going in two different directions?
- 1.58** This is the distinction, by the way, of Elizabeth Anscombe, a great 20th-century philosopher from Cambridge. And yet, it is I who am doing the desiring, and it's I who am doing the believing. It's all unified in me. Nobody else is having the desire that I'm having, because otherwise, it wouldn't be my desire. And nobody else is forming the beliefs that I'm forming. It's I who am doing both. So already here we see the sense that the "I" is unified. It's not like there are lots of mini-me's. The I is both unified; the soul is unified; the mind is unified. Call it what you want.
- 1.59** But also, there's a diversity of function here that Plato is trying to make sense of. This picture is one that he develops in his most famous dialogue, *The Republic*, particularly

in Book 4. We don't need to go into too much detail on that, because what I want to focus on is this beautiful dialogue called the *Phaedo*, P-H-A-E-D-O. What's so moving about this dialogue is that it's one of the tiny handful of dialogues that were written, really, in the last few hours and days of Socrates's life.

- 1.60 The *Phaedo* isn't just a wonderful work of philosophy. It's actually a very moving work, one of the most moving works of Western literature. Socrates is lying on his couch in his prison cell. He's refused the opportunity to escape. He's refused the opportunity to have a milder punishment because of his refusal to compromise with what the court had asked for. His friends are gathered around him, and the discussion turns to what's going to happen, what happens when people die? What happens when Socrates dies in the next few hours?
- 1.61 The setting is a very moving one, and it's the context for one of the most interesting and penetrating and influential discussions of the relationship between mind and body, between soul and self, that have ever been written. Socrates is arguing throughout as a way, not just because he believes it's true, but also as a way of trying to reassure his friends, who are begging him to escape, who are very upset.
- 1.62 The whole dialogue develops, really, as a way of Socrates reassuring his friends that, though his body is going to die, he's about to experience biological death, because he is not himself a biological organism, but rather a soul contained within a biological organism, the biological death of Socrates is not the death of Socrates. The biological death is not death.
- 1.63 Why? Because if you believe that the soul is immaterial, then you believe that it's not biological, it's not physical. Therefore, no biological or physical processes, drinking hemlock or whatever, is going to put an end to non-biological, non-physical beings. So, Socrates advances three arguments, and they're not all great arguments. I mean, one of them is quite—one of them is OK, but it's not so much, we don't have to get lost in the weeds of the argument. It's important to note this as a document where the arguments really start getting going in the history of Western philosophy.
- 1.64 The first argument is what's called the cyclical argument. The basic idea here is a little bit strange to us, maybe, but the way you understand the world, particularly at its fundamental levels, in terms of opposites. There's hot, and then there's cold. In fact, we know that something is hot because we've got a notion of what it is to be cold. Light and dark, large and small, just, unjust.
- 1.65 We think in these contrastive pairs, says Socrates. It's the same with life and death. We can only think of death in relation to life; we can only think of life in relation to death. If there wasn't this relationship between them, between the two, this move from life to death, back to death—from life to death and death to life, then everything eventually, says Socrates, would be dead.

- 1.66 There must be some cyclical process where souls return from death to life. There must be some survival of bodily death. All sorts of things wrong with that argument, but the basic impulse is that the world operates in terms of patterns, and that those patterns would effectively be extinguished if there wasn't some animating principle driving them. In Socrates's view, one of these animating principles is this contrastive principle driving the cycles forward.
- 1.67 Another argument that he pushes forward is the recollection argument. This is something that bothered him a great deal in another dialogue called the Meno, M-E-N-O, where he picks on this poor slave boy and starts giving him mathematical geometric puzzles by getting him to do a square in the ground, and then doubling the sides of the square, and then asking what the mathematical relationship is between the small square and the big square.
- 1.68 It turns out that this poor slave boy, who's never been to school, never been taught anything, gets it right. He works it out. He needs a bit of help from Socrates, but he basically gets there. The conversation turns to this problem. How is it that a slave boy, who's come into the world with no education, but he's got this capacity to work out quite a complicated mathematical problem? How is that knowledge, that access to truth, that access to mathematics, how can we just be born with it? How's it in there, without having been taught?
- 1.69 This is a problem that really exercises Plato, so much so that he thinks that the only way of solving this puzzle is to believe that we are souls, that the slave boy has a soul, before the slave boy was born, he had a soul, he was a soul, and that soul was somehow in contact with mathematical knowledge, a lot of which he lost on the way down into the world, into his body, but some of which, vague memories of it, which he still held on to, and those are the memories that Socrates is teasing out with his problem, with drawing the square in the sand.
- 1.70 This is an argument that Socrates also brings forward in the Phaedo, in this other argument, this other dialogue. And learning, particularly of mathematics and of abstract concepts and philosophy, thinking about justice, thinking about goodness, thinking about beauty, thinking about truth, is a process of recollection, or in the Greek, "anamnesis", anamnesis, A-N-A-M-N-E-S-I-S, anamnesis.
- 1.71 "Mnesis" is simply memory, and "ana" means again or repetition. So this is remembering again, anamnesis or recollection. That's what's going on when we are thinking through these deep puzzles in mathematics and in philosophy. We're recovering this preexisting soul that preexists our embodiment, the moment of our embodiment.
- 1.72 Third, and finally, there's this affinity argument, where Socrates says that the soul has this special attunement to what's eternal, to what's unchanging. There are these invisible realities that are called the forms, which the mind is attuned to, is connected

to; whereas the body is attuned and connected to physical things, things that are in time, and so on and so forth. Whereas the soul is indivisible, it's simple, it's much closer to the things that Plato thinks are up there, are eternal, timeless realities.

1.73 The thing about those eternal, timeless realities is—let's think, I don't know, like the number two. The great thing about the number two, assuming it exists, and Plato did think it existed, it doesn't die. Nothing happens to it. Nothing can happen to the number two. The number two just exists timelessly, necessarily. Nothing brought it into existence. Nothing can make it go out of existence. Nothing can affect it. It can't affect anything.

1.74 Socrates says that, when we're thinking about math, the reason that we're able to do mathematics is because there's something in us that belongs in that kind of world, belongs in that mathematical, spaceless, timeless world that can't be corrupted, can't be affected in any way. This is why, by the way, Plato insists that you've got to do years and years of mathematics and geometry before you're allowed to move on to philosophy in his academy. You have to do the mathematics; you have to do the geometry.

1.75 Why? Because that's what trains the soul, trains the mind to adjust itself to the eternal truth that philosophy, that is the business of philosophy, in Plato's view. The business of philosophy is the business of politics. Because in Plato's world, in the world of *The Republic*, certainly, you can't rule the city until you've completed the academy. You want to be the philosopher ruler, you want to be the ruler, you have to be a philosopher. If you want to be a philosopher, you have to have trained as a mathematician.

1.76 It seems like a strange idea to us. But that's why. He thinks that the eternal truths are ones that are similar to mathematics. Mathematics is a good place to start because $2 + 2 = 4$. We get that idea. It's a truth. It's not just any truth; it's lots of interesting things about the truth, that $2 + 2 = 4$. First of all, it's not a scientific truth. Science can't tell us. Science is silent on whether or not $2 + 2 = 4$, because science has got to assume it's true. Otherwise, there would be no science.

1.77 It's not a truth in the world. We can demonstrate it in the world, but the truth is that it's true no matter what. Suppose the space-time continuum that we are in right now, suppose we experience a Big Crunch tomorrow morning, and the whole of space-time just vanishes, boom, like that. Would it still be the case that $E=mc^2$? Would scientific truth still be true if there was no longer a reality in which they could be true? Well, plausibly, those truths cease to exist, along with everything else. They're not true about anything.

1.78 You could say, supposing another world like that came along, it would be true that $E=mc^2$ again. And then, suppose that space-time is wiped out tomorrow morning, and we asked ourselves the question, OK, there's no more space-time. That was a shame.

Nice while it lasted, 14.9 billion years, not too bad. Is it still the case that $2 + 2 = 4$? Probably, yeah. I mean, a lot of people would say, probably, yes. A lot of philosophers, a lot of philosophers and mathematicians, would say yes, absolutely, $2 + 2 = 4$.

- 1.79** What Plato is arguing is that our soul, our mind, is able to attune itself to those eternally persistent, incredibly resilient truths. And that's really where the mind belongs. It belongs outside the world of change, of decomposition, of rust, and so on and so forth, and of hemlock, I might add, the poison that Socrates decides to use to kill himself.
- 1.80** That gives you a little sense of the Platonic picture and of the soul, a tripartite picture, a three-tiered picture, three layers, which, by the way, he then thought could be mapped onto the way we build up a political community, a political society. That's for another lecture series. You have to go and listen to my lectures on Plato at the Peterson Academy for more detail on that.
- 1.81** One of the extraordinary things about Plato is not just his capacity as a philosopher, but his capacity as a teacher. He'd learned how to be a good pupil, and I guess he'd seen a master at work in working with Socrates. But probably around about the 350s, 360s, right till the wars, the end of Plato's life, a young hillbilly from Macedonia called Aristotle turns up in Athens. He's got a terrible accent, not even sure he's Greek.
- 1.82** There's this big dispute as to whether the Macedonians were really Greeks. They weren't allowed to come to the Olympic Games, because they were just, really, not quite one of us. But it turned out that Aristotle's student, Alexander the Great, soon-to-be Alexander the Great, was making some noises up in Macedon. It sounded like he was a guy you probably did not want to get on the wrong side of. They did get on the wrong side of him, eventually.
- 1.83** But anyway, Aristotle turns up, and he goes straight to Plato's Academy, the grove of olive trees outside Athens, where Plato is setting up his informal school. Aristotle clearly absorbs a great deal from Plato, but then moves—we're not quite sure whether it's before Plato's death in 347 or after—sets up his own place, his own school, in the Wolf Grove, which is the Lykeion, or the Lyceum. The Lyceum, he founds Lyceum some distance from the Academy. You can still go and see it in Athens today. I was there just a few weeks ago, actually.
- 1.84** He starts an entirely different approach to understanding these questions. In some ways—we'll go into more detail on that in the next lecture—but in many ways, we'll see that the approaches of Plato and Aristotle to the problem of mind really set out the dominant options for the way ahead. We'll start to see, all the way through the first millennium in the Middle Ages, and then early modern philosophy, and then contemporary philosophy, we'll start to see that the pull of Plato and the pull of Aristotle. We'll start to see how they move, take us in two distinct directions.

1.85 So, over the course of the next lecture, we'll be looking at Aristotle. We'll work through Aristotle and his very unusual way of coming up with an account of the relationship between mind and body that is immune to some of the objections we might have against Plato's. We'll move to, then, to think about the Greek legacy before discussing figures from late Antiquity and the Middle Ages. Thanks for listening.

Lecture 2: Mind Before Modernity

At a glance — Mind before modernity — pre-modern conceptions of soul and mind.

- 2.1 Welcome to the second lecture in our series, Introduction to Philosophy of Mind. In the first lecture, we set out some of the reasons why we should be thinking deeply about the question of mind, of consciousness, of intelligence, of reasoning, of what it is to be a self, what it is to be a subject. We started right back at the beginning with this mysterious figure, Anaxagoras, stressing the importance of the mind as the animating principle of the cosmos, of reality, of what makes reality legible to finite minds like our own.
- 2.2 And then we moved into Plato. We looked at the allegory of the charioteer in his dialogue, the *Phaedrus*. We looked at the tripartite soul in Book 4 of *The Republic*. And then we reflected on the *Phaedo*, that moving dialogue, the deathbed scene, where Socrates urges his grieving friends that he will persist beyond biological death, that the soul is not subject to hemlock, to poison, to physical processes.
- 2.3 We turn now to his great successor and teacher, Aristotle. Aristotle from Macedonia. He's not an Athenian. He's not seen or treated as a citizen. He's not allowed to vote in the Athenian democracy. He is a metic; he is an immigrant, and he's an immigrant to the day he dies. And indeed, he ends his life, we think, in exile, some kind of exile. He was close to— the tutor to Alexander the Great. It's an incredible lineage, if you think about that, in terms of teaching Socrates to Plato, Plato to Aristotle, Aristotle to Alexander the Great.
- 2.4 Aristotle was born in 384 BC, probably moves to Athens in his 20s, and Plato dies in 347. So when Aristotle is in his mid-30s, Aristotle himself dies one year after Alexander the Great, Aristotle dies in 322 BC. We're moving now into the fourth century. Aristotle is an extraordinary thinker, an extraordinary polymath. Not only does he contribute to areas of human thought as broad as psychology, biology, politics, literary theory, physics and metaphysics, meteorology, and so on and so forth, he invented most of those disciplines. He invented them.
- 2.5 Nobody before Aristotle had really been writing in a systematic way about any of those. He says, "We need to study this." So he'd go, "I'm going to write a book on oratory, on rhetoric and speech-making. I'm going to write a book on physics. I'm going to write a book on how animals die and how they come into existence. I'm going to write a book on logic, different kinds of logic." Nobody had done that before, organizing the kind of logical principles behind thought and language and argument and so on and so forth.
- 2.6 To learn more about Aristotle, I urge you to watch the Peterson Academy lectures, *Introduction to Aristotle: From Logic to Life*, delivered by yours truly. But we're going to focus for now just on one short text, a short but extremely influential text that Aristotle

wrote, and it's called, simply, *On the Soul*, *Peri Psychēs*, or as it's probably better known by its Latin title, the *De Anima*, about anima, about mind.

- 2.7** What's interesting about Aristotle's arguments about the mind is that he both rejects Plato's split between soul and body. For Plato, you've got this idea of the soul as somehow inhabiting a kind of meat machine, but it's distinct from it. With Aristotle, we have this idea that, well, the form— Plato is onto something when he's talking about form and shape and eternity and persistence and the reality of the soul.
- 2.8** But he's wrong to see them as completely separate. He's wrong to see just the body as this add-on, or just something that the soul is randomly connected to. This is very important. Aristotle wants to try to fuse soul and body much more tightly than Plato was willing to do. The way he tries to think of this is to say, well, human beings, and indeed all existing things, all artifacts, all naturally occurring things and all artifacts, are made of stuff.
- 2.9** But it's not just stuff. There's form to it. There's not just "hylē" in Greek; it's not just matter, not just stuff. There's also "morphē;" there's form, shape. Morphē is Greek for shape. Metamorphosis— it's to do with shape and changing, changing shape, in that case. And these two are completely connected. If you took one from the other, it would cease to be that thing.
- 2.10** One standard way of thinking about this might be in terms of a bronze statue. Think of one of the Riace bronzes in Italy, one of those amazing bronzes that was discovered back in the 1970s off the coast of Italy. It's a huge figure of Poseidon made out of bronze. And what Aristotle encourages us to think is to say that what makes that statue that statue is not just the bronze. It's not just a lump of bronze. It has a shape.
- 2.11** What makes that statue that statue, and not any other statue, what makes it a statue of Poseidon and not a statue of Zeus is its form, its morphē. You can no more separate out the bronze from the form that the statue-maker had in mind when he was shaping the bronze than you can just take the bronze away. If you take the bronze away, you've got nothing. You've just got an idea in the sculptor's mind. That's not nothing. It's something. In fact, it's that without which there would be no statue.
- 2.12** But similarly, also, if you just got a pile of bronze, it's just the pile of bronze. It's not the statue. It needs the form. It needs the actuating principle of the sculptor's blueprint or maybe the sketch in his workshop. And so, what Aristotle then goes on to say is that, when we look at living things, as opposed to dead things—either things that were living and are now dead, or things that could not possibly be living— the key difference for Aristotle between what is living and what is not is that living things have souls or are ensouled in some way.
- 2.13** See, Aristotle thinks that all living things have some kind of soul. Now, not a soul in the way that we've been led to think by Plato, in the way we might think to ourselves what

a soul might be like, but there are three layers to it, says Aristotle. He says there's the first soul, the most basic, primitive soul, is the nutritive soul, or the "threptikon."

- 2.14** The idea here is that all living things require growth, nutrition, reproduction. We see this in plants, we see this in animals, we see this in humans. There's a soul, says Aristotle, that makes us capable of absorbing nutrients, of metabolic processes, generating offspring. All of this, the mechanisms of life, is a form of soul. It's a vegetative, nutritive soul. Everybody, the plant kingdom's got it, animal kingdom's got it, human beings have got it, obviously being within the animal kingdom.
- 2.15** Then there's a second layer, which Aristotle says is that only the animal kingdom has. That is the sensitive soul or the sensory soul, the "aesthetikon." This is that principle that allows certain living things to perceive the world, to move around in the world, to have appetites, even to have emotions. This belongs to the animal kingdom. So all animals have this soul, including humans, but no plants. So it's this second layer up.
- 2.16** Then finally, says Aristotle, the highest form of soul is the "logistikon," the rational soul, reason, thinking, understanding, deliberating. And this is something which only human beings have. It's distinctive to what it is to be human. Human beings, all human beings, says Aristotle, have by nature the desire to know, the desire to understand the world. It's a unique feature that we have in the world.
- 2.17** If you think about it, it's a very strange behavior in an animal kingdom to turn up to a lecture on the philosophy of mind. This is odd behavior. Why do we do it? Well, we do it, says Aristotle, not because we're some strange animal that's taken a strange route through the evolutionary jungle. No, he says, it's part of what we are. It's part of our essence. And we have this capacity to understand, which is an extraordinary feature that we have as organisms, as living things, but it is part of what we are as a living thing. It emerges, as it were, from the ground up.
- 2.18** You can already see how different this is from Plato's view, where he literally thinks—remember the charioteer who's going around up in Plato's heavens, and the soul falls down? And so, for Plato, this capacity we have to think and to understand and to reason, that seems to transcend all of physics and all of nature, doesn't seem to be the thing that is a feature of one admittedly very unusual animal. It's not like the dolphin can swim; human beings can think.
- 2.19** For the Platonist, this just seems to be such radically different capacities that there must be some explanation beyond the physical world, beyond the biological world, to account for it. But Aristotle wants to start from what you can see, what you can touch, what you can explore and understand of the world. It's more suspicious of claims about which we can't really have much evidence. Certainly, charioteers doing big hand-brake turns up in Plato's heavens is probably not what Aristotle wants to appeal to.
- 2.20** And so, this picture, this three-layered picture that Aristotle develops when accounting for what it is for human beings to be ensouled, proves to be extremely influential. Our

soul is unified. It's got these different capacities: capacities for nutrition and reproduction, capacities for perception at the second level, and then capacities for reasoning and understanding at the highest level.

- 2.21** And these two, the soul is the form of the body, just as the blueprint in the sculptor's workshop is the form of the bronze statue, of the statue of Poseidon. You can't separate them out. And so the mind, the soul, is what animates, is what makes me a living thing, and makes me this particular living thing, with all the capacities that I've got—the cognitive capacities, the perceptual capacities, and the nutritive reproductive capacities.
- 2.22** Here, we have, in this attempt, as we'll often see in the history of the philosophy of mind, the attempt to bring soul and body back together, fuse it into a single thing. This generates all sorts of worries and puzzles, because as we saw with Anaxagoras and with Plato, there's this insistence that the two are still very radically different things. How do we make sense of it as just unified? If the soul is the form of the body, for example, how is it that we're capable of thinking about complete universal immaterial concepts?
- 2.23** Remember that argument, the affinity argument that Socrates advances in the *Phaedo*? There, there's something quite attractive about the thought that, well, sense perception deals with the physical world, but pure mathematics, truths that we can reach by shutting our eyes and sitting quietly in an armchair without inspecting the world at all, without engaging with the physical world at all, that seems to be almost a different capacity. That seems to be something that the mind is uniquely able to do.
- 2.24** Whereas on Aristotle's picture, it's more like, thinking is more like digestion or sweating. It's just this thing that we do as living organisms. It's not a radically different thing, but it does seem to be a radically different kind of thing. Thinking is not swimming. Understanding is not sweating. And so, there is this tension here, and Aristotle trying to ground things in the best science—and he was basically coming up with the best science of his day—but he was suspicious of trying to appeal to something otherworldly in the way that Plato, the dualist Plato, the dualist to matter plus mind, was so keen on doing.
- 2.25** So that's Aristotle. And we'll see, as I said in the previous lecture, we'll see that much of the rest of this course you can see as a pendulum swing between the Platonic intuitions and the Aristotelian intuitions. They lay a lot of the ground out that we'll be exploring in subsequent lectures.
- 2.26** Galloping on now through the centuries, it's, I think, fair to say that nothing really philosophically substantial emerges on this problem until, probably, we get to the end of the fourth century AD. So, we're talking 800 years later.
- 2.27** A lot is happening in the world other than that. But really, in terms of new departures, new chapters in the problem, it's not until we get the emergence of a sophisticated theological, monotheistic, and particularly Christian, though to some extent also

Islamic, philosophical framework, that we start to see some departures and some new ideas.

- 2.28** There's the great Plotinus, who's seen as the founder of Neoplatonism, so a new way of thinking about Plato, or rather, a new way of using Plato's insights. And Plotinus stresses the importance of mind, like Anaxagoras, as being absolutely fundamental to reality. He has this three-layered metaphysical universe. He has the One at the top, "to hen." Then you have the "nous," the intellect, the second level. And finally, the soul at the third level, which is what mediates between the eternal intellect and the world of time and change.
- 2.29** That proves to be extremely influential. In some ways, it shows how—well, certainly late antique philosophy, the most dominant position did not think that matter was the most fundamental thing in reality, but that mind and oneness, the oneness that the mind exhibits in its unity and in its simplicity, is what is fundamental to the nature of reality.
- 2.30** One figure who was much influenced in his teenage years by Plotinus was, arguably, the greatest theologian of the Latin West, Augustine of Hippo, St. Augustine, born in 354 AD, dies in 430, in North Africa, and he lives through the final collapse of Rome, of the Roman Empire, or at least the collapse of that phase in Rome's history, whose center of gravity is around Rome. It moves in many ways to eastwards, or had moved eastwards with Constantine shifting the capital of the Empire from Rome to Constantinople, the city of Constantine.
- 2.31** So, Augustine's writing at a period of great geopolitical flux and confusion, chaos, nervousness, but develops, despite that, the most extraordinary approach to how to understand interiority, the sense of the inner life, the sense of the radical dependence upon human beings, of human beings on the divine.
- 2.32** In the Confessions, certainly his most famous work, we have the first example of an autobiography, that is to say, a work about somebody's life, written from that person's perspective, which, in certainly the first eight to nine books of that work, give you a fascinating glimpse into the way in which Augustine thinks about self, thinks about the inner life, the interiority, and his conviction that interiority, that subjectivity, the inner life, can't in the end depend upon merely physical processes, can't in the end just depend upon objects, but depends upon God, "that which is nearer to me than myself," says Augustine, more intimate, more interior to me than I am to myself.
- 2.33** It's an extraordinary idea, that. In fact, the whole of the Confessions is— what's so remarkable about it is not only that it's the first autobiography, all written about his inner life from the first person point of view, it's also written in the second person singular. It's an address. It's a prayer. The whole book is a prayer to God. It's an address to God. It's like a diary, but it's like a diary written to God—an extraordinary thing to digest and make sense of.

- 2.34 When Marcus Aurelius is writing his *Meditations* in, what, the 170s, 180s AD, you don't really know anything about him. I mean, if you gave somebody, someone Marcus Aurelius's *Meditations*, and you didn't tell them it was by Marcus Aurelius and you didn't tell them who Marcus Aurelius was, and you asked them at the end of reading it, "Who do you think wrote that? What kind of a person do you think wrote that?"
- 2.35 First of all, they'd say, "Probably some Greek philosopher," because it's all written in Greek. "He probably worked in Plato's Academy or somewhere like that. Maybe he was a private tutor, maybe he gave lectures." But no, you would not have thought that the person who wrote this is the most powerful man in the history of the world when he wrote it. He was writing it, probably most of it in a tent somewhere in modern-day Croatia, directing vast armies on campaign to defend the borders and expand the borders of the Roman Empire. You wouldn't have a clue. Marcus Aurelius says nothing about himself. He drops no clues at all.
- 2.36 Whereas in Augustine, the *Confessions*, you can read it and you feel, even though there's 1,700 years separating us from this man, you feel you know him. You feel you know him as well as any friend. Great transparency there and an openness to the reality of mind and of the self, one's own mind, one's own inner life. He develops, in other works, for example, the *De Trinitate*, it's a very famous work on the Trinity. He has these fascinating analogies, which allows him to explore psychology and mind.
- 2.37 For example, he says that one way to understand the Trinity— we're worrying about the Trinity. What's the problem with the Trinity? Is God somehow three persons, but one being? How is that possible? How can one being be three, also be three? And one of the analogies that Augustine draws on and develops and focuses on is a little bit like—a little bit earlier, we were talking about Plato, how he insists that the soul is unified, but also you've got the charioteer and you've got the two horses.
- 2.38 Or think about Aristotle. You've got one soul, but also three layers: the nutritive, the sensory, and the rational. Augustine picks this up and he develops it. He says that we're comfortable with the idea that our mind, that we ourselves have multiple aspects. For example, the mind remembers. We have memories. That's different from our understanding. We are also able to understand things. That's distinct from remembering things. Sometimes, obviously, to understand something, it helps that we remember something, but the two are distinct.
- 2.39 And thirdly, we also have will. We have a will, we have desires which are channeled through our consciousnesses, if you like. And so he says that you've got these different aspects. You've got memory, understanding, will. He says, you can think, therefore, of the soul, of you. There's only one you. There's only one "I", unified. But also, there are different aspects to you that are distinct.
- 2.40 Your memory is distinct from your understanding. Your understanding is distinct from your will, from your desire. All three can work together. All three are united into a

single thing. Without your understanding, you wouldn't be you. Without your memory, you wouldn't be you. Without your will, you wouldn't be you. All three make you, you. And yet, you are not three. You are a unified self. You are one.

- 2.41** It's a fascinating discussion and one that helps us to, as it were, both illuminate the nature of mind and nature of psychology and self, but also in a way that helps to illuminate this notoriously difficult doctrine in Christian theology. One of the things he says is that Plato's right to be puzzled as to how memory works and how it is, for example, that that slave boy was able to solve the problem that Socrates posed for him by drawing a square in the sand.
- 2.42** Augustine is aware of this problem. He didn't read much Greek. He probably didn't read any Plato, but he's aware of what he calls the "libri Platonici", the books of the Platonists. He says, so yeah, there is this puzzle. How is it that we can reason about the world so effectively? How is it that we can teach a five-year-old arithmetic pretty easily? How is it that you have prodigies? You can have a chess prodigy at four or five. You can have a maths prodigy at six, seven, eight. Where does all that come from? Is it not knowledge?
- 2.43** Well, that's strange. I mean, maybe it's a power, maybe it's a capacity, but where does it come from? It's not a natural one. What's the evolutionary advantage of being born with a capacity to do pure mathematics, pure mathematics that you don't apply to anything? It's just pure. It's completely irrelevant to the actual world. Why is it that we can do that?
- 2.44** Augustine's solution is that this crazy idea about previous souls preexisting up in Plato's heavens; we don't need to believe that. What we can say is that, when God brings creatures into being, he endows them, he prints them with his image and gives human beings a capacity, certainly capacities that are distinct from everything else in creation. And included in that is a capacity to think at least some of God's thoughts, or to be attuned at least to some degree, to participate to some degree, in God's mind.
- 2.45** Augustine thinks that that's basically what we're doing when we're doing things like abstract reasoning, mathematical reasoning, logical reasoning, and so on and so forth. Because when you're trying to access these eternal truths, like $2 + 2 = 4$, you are, as it were, accessing the mind of God, and that makes sense, because God has a mind. There's no mind in Plato's heaven. But what else can hold truths, if not a mind?
- 2.46** Augustine says Plato can't be right. You can't just have a mindless Platonic heaven with just these infinitely many mathematical truths hanging around there. It doesn't make sense. These are much more like thoughts. But if they are thoughts, there needs to be a thinker. They must be grounded in something, in somebody's reflection, somebody's reflective processes, some person's reflective processes. Augustine says this is God.
- 2.47** It makes more sense to think of this as sitting within a supremely powerful mind than it does in just some empty Platonic heaven. And so, a little bit like Anaxagoras, Augustine

develops this idea that the mind participates in God's thoughts. The mind thinks God's thoughts after him. And indeed, you might say that, on the Augustinian view, what we're doing when we're doing science is, we're just mapping out the patterns of intelligence and structure and order that reflect the created blueprint that God had when bringing reality into being out of nothing.

- 2.48** That's the Augustinian picture. And indeed, it's a fairly standard monotheistic picture, applies to all creationist frameworks, all frameworks that are committed to the idea of an account of the world and of reality as coming out into being and being structured in such a way by a divine creative agency.
- 2.49** Another thing that Augustine points out is that the mind is completely transparent to itself. We know our mind, and we know the contents of our mind, directly and immediately. We don't need help working out what we think. We don't need tools; we don't need intermediaries. It's completely direct. Augustine says at one point, fascinatingly, "Even when I'm being skeptical, even when I'm trying to doubt something, or even when I'm being deceived, I am still in direct, immediate contact with myself."
- 2.50** Because "si fallor, sum." "If I am deceived, I am." If I am deceived, I am. What does he mean by that? What he means by that will become clearer when we turn to the thought of René Descartes, 1,300 or so years later. Augustine's insight here is that, even if I'm being systematically deceived about something, in order to be deceived, I need to have thoughts. You can't deceive a zombie, a mindless zombie. There's nothing to fool.
- 2.51** Augustine says, my mindedness, my thinking, my thinking capacity is so deep that I can't separate myself from it. Even if I were a brain in a vat, even if I were completely being deceived by everybody, I would still be me. I would still exist. There would still be an "I" that's being deceived. The "I" stays, the "I" persists. This is a fascinating glimpse into what comes later with Descartes. Descartes would have read Augustine a great deal, and it may well be where he gets the idea from.
- 2.52** We've now come to, roaring on our roller coaster ride through into late antiquity, into the fourth and fifth centuries. We're going to do another jump now to the 13th century, and in particular, the great St. Thomas Aquinas, 1224—round about 1224—to March 1274, dies round about the age of 50. Along with Augustine, he is the philosopher and theologian who has had, arguably, more impact, certainly, on Catholic theology than any other.
- 2.53** He writes nearly 10 million words over the course of his life. It's about 10,000 words a day, dictated to five secretaries simultaneously. His final great work, the *Summa Theologiae*, is a million words long, is unfinished, and he has an extraordinarily powerful and capacious mind. Something had happened before Aquinas—was happening as Aquinas was coming to intellectual maturity, that would have an

enormous impact on his thought and, indeed, on medieval philosophy more generally, and that is the rediscovery of Aristotle.

- 2.54** For many centuries, the texts of Aristotle and Plato had vanished. Very little of Plato survived, very little of Aristotle survived. Augustine would, might have heard of Aristotle, but would have had no idea what he wrote. He would have had no idea about the *De Anima*. He was dimly aware of Plato, but probably didn't read any Plato in the original, just had hand-me-down Plato from others.
- 2.55** And what happens, though, towards the end of the 12th century, the 1100s and then into the 13th century, is that the texts of Aristotle are rediscovered, mainly having been preserved by the Abbasid Caliphate in Baghdad, which was the center of Islamic learning at the time, the eighth century onwards. And those texts, through processes not entirely clear to us, as part of the so-called translation movement, these texts end up probably on some Sicilian fishermen's boats all the way across the Mediterranean, somehow made it into Spain, got to Toledo, where a big translation exercise was put underway, was commissioned.
- 2.56** Then slowly, over the course of the 1100s and the 1200s, Aristotle's texts made it up into the bloodstream of European thought across the Pyrenees. This had an electric impact on European thinking, on European philosophy, on European science, that's difficult to overstate. Of course, most of all, this idea of hylomorphism, of form-matter, starts to emerge. Aquinas is reading about it, he's absorbing it, and he sets himself the challenge of baptizing Aristotle, you might say, of taking Aristotelian theory of mind and of the soul, and trying to embed it within the Christian theological framework.
- 2.57** You could say that much of the history of philosophy can be explained as a boxing match, a push and pull between the Hebraic and the Hellenic, between the influence of Abrahamic monotheism— Old Testament, New Testament in particular, then Christian writings and the Church Fathers, and theologians after that. Then, on the other hand, the Hellenic—Plato, Aristotle, all the schools that come out of them, the Stoics, the Epicureans, the Cynics, natural law in Cicero and in Seneca, Epictetus, Marcus Aurelius, Plotinus, and so on and so forth. These are the two engine rooms, you might say, of Western thought. They feed and fuse into each other in different ways.
- 2.58** What Aquinas is trying to do is fuse together certain Christian theological principles with pagan, as it were, Aristotelian philosophical ideas. This actually creates problems. Three years after Aquinas's death in 1277, Bishop Étienne Tempier, the bishop of France—bishop of Paris, I beg your pardon— announced that 250-odd propositions from Aristotle were to be condemned, and were not allowed to be taught, and were to be treated as anathema, that is to say, don't touch them.
- 2.59** For that reason, Aquinas fell out of his influence as nothing like what it might have been, had that condemnation not happened. Because there was a sense that this was threatening. Here we have this genius, Aristotle. Aquinas, whenever he refers to

Aristotle, simply says, "Philosophus," the philosopher. Aquinas was aware of Plato. He was aware of many of the great Arabic philosophers. He was aware of a lot of the most significant philosophical figures. But when he's talking about Aristotle, the Philosopher, capital P: "the Philosopher says this."

- 2.60** What Aquinas is trying to do is deal with the threat that Aristotle poses. We have this philosophical genius who had never read the New Testament, never heard the Sermon on the Mount, never read Hebrew scriptures, and yet he invents biology, he invents physics, he invents the study of rhetoric, the study of literature, of logic, of metaphysics. He writes the first textbook on politics. The reason we call politics, politics is basically because he did. His book was called *Ta Politika*, the things to do with the city, the things to do with the polis, the politics.
- 2.61** And so, the great challenge was, could there be a mind that was capable enough, powerful enough, to absorb these great insights of Aristotle? This is what Aquinas does. He tries to develop a form-matter account of the human soul, the human person, that is attuned to Aristotle's hylomorphic theory. It's a clunky word, that hylomorphic, hylomorphism. But you remember the Greek for matter, for stuff, is *hylō*, or *hylē*, and for form, is *morphē*. So the word hylomorphism simply means the form-matter theory that Aristotle develops when giving an account of the human person.
- 2.62** And so Aquinas tries to push for this, too—a hylomorphic account. The challenge here that Aquinas has to navigate is that, on the traditional understanding, on the Christian theological understanding, at biological death, the soul persists beyond death, to judgment, to possible eternal reunion with God, eternal union with God in the beatific vision. And that's without the body. That's just the form floating around.
- 2.63** So, Aquinas is having to reconcile this Christian theological picture to the Aristotelian fusion picture where soul and body go together. At the moment of death, Aristotle hasn't got any theory about the soul surviving the body in a way that Plato does have. And so you've got this challenge, and Aquinas tries to deal with it.
- 2.64** What he attempts, the synthesis that he comes up with, is to say that the soul has mental operations, and it has physical operations. It's not that the soul is the mind or the soul is the body, but really, the soul is the organizing principle in virtue of which the human person can do mind stuff and body stuff. But it's not like the mind is doing body stuff, as you would have on the Platonic picture. There's soul, and it's capable of doing mind stuff and body stuff.
- 2.65** When the person goes through biological death, the capacity to engage in mind stuff and body stuff, or the capacity to engage in bodily actions, ceases, but the capacity to engage in mental operations continues, and it's the soul doing that. The soul is also capable of being resurrected into a physical body, which is another central commitment within Christianity. But there are these tensions here already between

Christian theological understanding and Aristotelian, Aristotle's psychology, Aristotle's theory of mind.

- 2.66** Before we leave the medieval period, I want to note that, broadly speaking, it's pretty successful. The mind is not a mysterious feature of reality for the medievals. Yes, there are problems about how to square theology with philosophy, Christian doctrine with Aristotelian psychology and philosophy of mind, but broadly speaking, it's not a dominant question. It's not a dominant problem.
- 2.67** And although it's popular to blame things with the phrase, "Oh, that's just medieval," it always annoys me when people say that, because if anybody knew anything about medieval philosophy, they'd know how sophisticated and difficult it is, and what an achievement that they pulled off in, as it were, coming up with a view of the mind, a view of the soul and the human person, that honors and accommodates brilliant philosophical insights, even insights that might be quite threatening, into a Christian doctrinal, theological, theistic framework that the brilliant philosophers knew nothing about.
- 2.68** However, there is an instability there. There are tensions, and I want to say a little bit more about those. The first challenge, you might say, that emerges materializes in the scientific revolution that begins in the 1500s and is well underway by the 1600s, in the 17th century. What are the changes that emerge that suddenly make Aristotle and Aristotelian ideas extremely unpopular?
- 2.69** Well, the first, one key development would be the shift towards thinking about reality in nature, not in terms of kinds of being, forms, and essences, and God, and angels, and human beings, and animals, and all of these different, distinct forms of life, but really in terms of maths plus matter. Maths plus matter. Physics is maths plus matter, and all of reality, really, is just physics.
- 2.70** Galileo, for example, in the early 1600s, Galileo develops famously this idea that, really, physics is purely—it's purely to do with quantities, not qualities. By quantities, we mean size, shape, motion, number. Qualities would be more things to do with color or certainly ensoulment; these are forms or essences. These are not just observable quantities. These are more like qualities. And that is what Galileo's picture of the world is beginning to illuminate.
- 2.71** We have also the rejection of the idea that there's any purpose in nature, which Aristotle is very keen to establish, the idea that there are causes, that there are ends, that there are horizons. The horizon of an acorn is to become a flourishing oak tree, and that's wired into the acorn. It's not going to become a willow tree; it's going to become an acorn tree. It's directed towards oak tree.
- 2.72** For the early modern picture, for the scientific revolution, this was just spooky. How could something point towards something in the future? We can't see that pointiness, as it were. We can't see that directionality. It's just an acorn. It's not for anything. We

describe it. We could just describe how it's made up, and we can classify it, but we can't say it's directed towards being an oak tree, becoming an oak tree.

- 2.73** So, you get this new way of thinking about the body, the human person, as really just collections of particles in motion. Really, here, you're beginning to see, broadly speaking, the modern picture of what human beings really are, "really being," brackets, what the scientists tell us we are. Because what room is there for soul anymore? That's spooky stuff. It's like the acorn being directed—the goal of the acorn being directed towards an oak tree.
- 2.74** We can't see it; we can't touch it. It's got no size, it's got no shape, it's got no— it hasn't got any obvious GPS location. And so, you start to get the rejection of the whole classical and medieval paradigm of what it is to be a human person. And so, for science to really get off the ground, there is this insistence that the method, the experimental method, has got to be mathematically precise. It's got to be mechanically intelligible. And medieval conceptions of this spooky talk of forms and essences and substances don't help us, don't make any sense.
- 2.75** We see in all the great universities, in the 1500s and 1600s, the slow decline of Aristotelian ways of thinking, and the replacement and the new ways of thinking coming through, particularly with Francis Bacon and people like John Locke and David Hume and the British empiricists. The idea is that we're starting fresh. We're putting all this old medieval, scholastic stuff behind us, and we're starting anew.
- 2.76** That starting point, far from being a supremely rational and insightful one, is a starting point that contains within it the San Andreas Fault line of consciousness and the problem and the philosophy of mind. The whole way that modernity sets up the problem is to say, there's the world, there's reality, and that is physical reality, that's the world of physics, and that's it. Oh, but hold on. Who's deciding that? How do we fit in to this world, if it's just physics?
- 2.77** Well, we must be just physical objects, too. We must be just particles that are arranged in a particular way. We've also magically got this insight into the fact the world is just physics and that we are organized in a particularly physical way. And immediately, you start to get this problem of: Is the thinking self, is it extended? Is it just a material thing? If it doesn't belong to the world of physics, then how can it exist at all? How can we make any sense of it at all?
- 2.78** This is really the birth of the mind-body problem. This is really where it starts. It's not that it wasn't at all a problem beforehand. We see with Plato and Aristotle and Augustine, Aquinas, they're trying to give a good account of it. But it's a much more fundamental problem now, because the story is—all of reality, from the scientific revolution onwards—the understanding is: all of reality is just science. All truths are scientific truths, all truths that you can explain away in terms of scientific truths.

- 2.79** We might talk as if we've got minds, we might talk as if we're free, but those are just comforting fairy stories that we tell ourselves to cope with the world. But really, it's all science, all the way down. As soon as you accept that starting point, then it's very difficult how you fit human beings, the questions of human self, human subjectivity, consciousness, freedom, agency, back into a world that is structured to exclude them.
- 2.80** This takes us towards one of the greatest philosophers that Europe has ever produced. That philosopher is René Descartes, 1596 to 1650, a man who stands, as it were, on the threshold of modern thought, of modern philosophy. You might say that before Descartes, you can say philosophy is still part of antiquity in a funny way, part of the gradual unwinding of the thoughts of the ancients, but also marks the beginning of a new way of doing philosophy, one that is revolutionary in its implications and, therefore, one that deserves close scrutiny, as we turn to consider Descartes's ideas and some objections to those ideas in the next lecture. Thank you for listening.
- 2.81** You mentioned how the scientific revolution essentially seeks to explain the modern world, and as philosophers, we seek to explain the world. How would that contrast with religious explanations for the world?
- 2.82** Yes, very good. I suppose what religious explanations would offer is not just the claim that the world can be understood, but also an explanation for why it can be understood. Religions can give an understanding, would claim that they can give us an understanding of why understanding the world is possible.
- 2.83** Whereas in a purely scientific secular context, there's just the world. It popped into being out of nothing. We have no idea why. We have no idea why it's intelligible to us, why we can understand it. We've got no reason to trust our understanding of it, necessarily. It's a little bit uncertain. So, that would be the religious claim.
- 2.84** You could also say that, if you're a religious person, you don't care about having to be an atheist in the lab. You want the scientists in the lab to be atheists. Why? Because Christianity basically introduces the idea that the natural world, when you're studying the natural world, you don't need to check what Poseidon thinks. You don't need to ask Zeus. You haven't got any earthquake gods anymore. You haven't got any sea gods. You haven't got any horse gods.
- 2.85** Christianity, in this, that whole, that particular tradition of religion, evacuates the world of all of these gods, except for one God who is not in the world, but outside it, but supremely rational. And therefore, the created order is itself, because it's the product of a supremely rational being, is intelligible. That's the departure, really. You could say that the religious frameworks are—what you have with Francis Bacon in the 1620s, who introduces, really, the scientific method, is this idea that you're methodologically an atheist in the lab.
- 2.86** When you're doing science, the religious thing to do is not to be religious in the explanations that you invoke. You're not going to say, "All the particles are arranged

this way because the Holy Spirit's arranged it this way." You say, "No, we believe in the kind of God who doesn't play tricks on us in the lab, who believes in patterns, who believes in consistency, order, regularity, and wants the world to be legible to us, and not divinized, not turned into some spooky pagan enchanted cosmos, necessarily, or where there might be demons rushing around trying to fiddle with your numbers and your experiments."

- 2.87** That's why I don't think it's an accident, but it's the intellectual cultures that are most dominated by that idea, the idea that the world is created by a supremely rational being, that produce the biggest and best scientists. If you were a proverbial alien landing in Europe in 1500 AD or just landing on the planet, and you had to guess which part of the world, which part of the planet, was about to trigger the most extraordinary revolutions in technology and in industry and in capitalism and so on, would you put your money on the northwestern rim of Eurasia, full of terrible weather and people basically living in huts and killing each other a lot?
- 2.88** You wouldn't have bet on Europe. There was nothing. You would have put your money on China, you'd have put your money on India, maybe parts of South and Central America. But it was that part of the world that got it. And why? There's long discussions about why, but it's plausible that it's your way of thinking about the world. It's ideas that drive change so often, your basic outlook, your basic understanding of the way the world is.
- 2.89** The idea that the world is something that could be experimented on, that could be made to be useful, that could be manipulated, that we can engage and interact with the world in incredibly complex ways, is something that you really only find within the monotheistic traditions, specifically, I'd say, the Christian monotheistic traditions. In a way, the scientific revolution, it's a revolution, but it's also continuous with many of the ideas that it was revolting against, as is almost always the case with revolutions.

Lecture 3: Mind as Mechanism

At a glance — Mind as mechanism — the modern turn and the mechanical picture of nature.

- 3.1 Welcome to lecture three of Introduction to Philosophy of Mind. We stand at the beginning of lecture three on the threshold of modernity, or what historians of ideas call at least the threshold of early modernity. It's a period that you might say begins around about 1600, 1650, and persists to, let's say, 1750, 1800. It's a period of enormous intellectual ferment, enormous intellectual change and revolution. We touched on what drove that revolution a little bit in the previous lecture.
- 3.2 But effectively, you have a new worldview, an entirely new way of understanding reality. And you see all kinds of shifts, a shift from what you might call a theocentric way of understanding the world, let us say, one grounded in God as the center, as a central explanatory factor in understanding the world, to an anthropocentric way of understanding the world, one that understands the world purely, exclusively from a human point of view, from our point of view.
- 3.3 You have the emergence of what you might call the new mechanism or the mechanical worldview. The key figures are people like Galileo and Kepler, and of course, Isaac Newton in the sciences. The basic idea here is that the way to understand the world is not by appealing to Aristotelian forms or essences or things with mysterious capacities and dispositions and powers.
- 3.4 Remember, we talked about the acorn's disposition, or direction, or power, to become an oak tree? This is something seen as spooky, as something that was not capable of being elucidated and analyzed in methodologically neutral, methodologically dispassionate terms. The idea is that, really, all of reality is to be understood as physical reality. All physical events can be understood simply as matter in motion, matter in motion, obeying and conforming to certain very complex mathematical laws and mathematical principles.
- 3.5 No more final purpose, no more natural powers, no more substantial forms. Everything is reduced to mathematical or geometric extension in space, plus motion, plus matter, of course. And so the question then is: Where does this leave us? Where does this leave the very people who've come up with the idea that this is how to understand the world? We've come up with a picture of the world in which we ourselves, the painters, have no obvious place in it. We've got no role in it. How do we understand that? How do we make sense of it?
- 3.6 The key figure here, of course, is René Descartes, the father of modern philosophy, as he's often called. Descartes is most famous, of course, for developing a new theory of mind, you might say; it's called in the textbooks "substance dualism." But he wasn't just a philosopher of mind. He was one of the great mathematicians of his age, perhaps one of the greatest European mathematicians to emerge, certainly in the 17th century.

- 3.7** His obsession was with the nature of self, the nature of certainty, and how one could establish, how one could fit the human person back into a world of merely geometric extension, a world merely of matter in motion. And so he publishes this fascinating work called the *Meditations*, or *Meditations on First Philosophy*, 1641. And that's the first point to note: these are meditations.
- 3.8** Do you remember I said in the previous lecture that Augustine produces this work of a kind that nobody had ever produced before? The *Confessions*, this autobiographical diary to himself, but actually to God, an I to you, and very introspective, reflecting deeply on his inner self and seeing that inner self as real, not something that should be dissolved or forgotten about or absorbed into the one, as you will see in many Eastern traditions. The self is real and distinctive.
- 3.9** But what makes it real? It's real in a different way from the way in which rocks and flamingos and trees are real. How do we develop this? What does he do? How does he set about trying to reconcile the world of us and, as it were, the world of the world? How do we make sense of mind and world? How did the two fit together? Well, his first method, famously, is to attempt a comprehensive exercise in doubting everything. Doubting.
- 3.10** The idea is that, if I keep on doubting absolutely everything, could I ever get to some residue of beliefs or propositions that I couldn't actually possibly doubt? In other words, can I get to certainty somehow in my thinking? Can I reach bedrock? Can I keep on digging until I reach some certainty, some foundation to all knowledge? Once I've got the foundation, the idea is—or seems to have been—I can then start to build up brick by brick, back up, but this time on the foundation of really understanding what's certain and what's real.
- 3.11** And so, he imagines what he calls a "malin génie," an evil demon, an evil genie, who is constantly fooling him, constantly kidding him, constantly deceiving him about what he thinks, about what he sees, about what he tastes, about what he remembers, what he understands, what he wants. And he says, "This demon could keep on deceiving me, keep on deceiving me. But there'll come a point where he can't actually deceive me anymore. That point is where I am thinking. He cannot deceive me without me having thoughts."
- 3.12** We saw this idea with Augustine, just a trace of it. Remember, "Si fallor, sum." If I am deceived, I am. Because as an "I" being deceived, even if I'm systematically mistaken, there's still an "I" who is mistaken. This is a very similar idea, similar approach. Descartes says, "In order to deceive me, the evil demon relies upon me having thoughts, needs me to have thoughts, otherwise I can't be deceived." And so he concludes, "You can be a skeptic as much as you like about absolutely everything, but the one thing you can't be a skeptic about is the fact that there's a you."

- 3.13** There's a "you." Something is a skeptic. Some thinker, some "I," some subject is a skeptic. And so Descartes thinks, "Well, aha, there we go. I am—the one thing I cannot be in any doubt about is that I have thoughts. I am a thinking self. Je pense, donc j'existe. I think, therefore I am. Cogito ergo sum." There are thoughts; there must be an "I." Of that, I can be certain, because nothing can deceive me about that, without presupposing what I'm certain about—namely, that there's an "I" and that there's an "I" that has thoughts that are vulnerable to being deceived.
- 3.14** So, that's where he ends up. He says, "There is an I." Then the question is, what is the I? Well, he says that it can't be a physical thing. It's got to be a different kind of thing. The word that he comes up with for thing is, really, is substance. Substance, let's say, something that is capable, an object, an entity that's capable of some kind of independent existence. He says that the self is a radically different substance. Why? Well, various arguments he puts forward for this.
- 3.15** The first is the so-called divisibility argument. He says, with stuff, with matter, with bodies, you can cut them up, you can divide them up, down to atoms. You might even be able to split the atom, and then you can just keep splitting. They're made of parts. But the mind, the self, the "I," is indivisible. What would it mean to say, "I am two 'I's.'" There are two 'I's.' There are three 'I's.'" No, there's something in the very notion of being a subject, being a you, being an "I," that you're unified, that you're one thing. You're not one thing that's made up of different things, one thing that emerges out of other distinct things.
- 3.16** How could you have half a thought? What would half a thought even be? Or what would part of a thought even be? You can't have a third of a belief. These are things that only make sense in terms of unity. And so, Descartes says that there is something completely, radically different from physical, divisible things, what he calls "res extensa", which simply means, in Latin, matter extended, stuff extended; that is to say, stuff in space and time, with coordinates and geometrical coordinates and so on, matter in motion.
- 3.17** And on the other hand, "res cogitans," stuff cogitating, stuff cognitively thinking, stuff in a state of, as it were, cognition. And these are the two substances. This is why Descartes's philosophy of mind is known in the textbooks as substance dualism, substance two-ism.
- 3.18** There are various other arguments that Descartes develops for his position. One, probably the most famous one, is the so-called modal argument. Modal, in philosophy, refers to that area of philosophy that studies possibility, impossibility, necessity, contingency, and so on. And the argument, as Descartes advances it, is to say, "I can clearly and distinctively conceive of myself or dream of myself or imagine myself as existing without my body."

- 3.19** Even if that's impossible, even if that's physically impossible or scientifically impossible—probably actually not so clear that that is so impossible these days, but we accept that it's physically impossible—but Descartes says, "I can still imagine a world in which the science allowed me to detach myself, and the mind could just exist without the body. I can still imagine that." I may, for example, refuse to accept that there's life after death, but I don't think that people who believe in life after death are the kind of people who might try and think they believe in square triangles. It's still a thinkable thought that there's life after death.
- 3.20** So, he goes on to say, it's also the case that I cannot conceive clearly and distinctly of my body existing without having extension in space and in time. That's not something—because it belongs to the meaning of the concept of body, that I'm extended in space; that's just what it is. So he says, "I can't separate that out, but I can imagine myself hovering above my body. I can imagine it. I can at least conceive of it."
- 3.21** So he relies on this axiom, which is not uncontroversial, but the axiom and the idea is that whatever I can conceive clearly and distinctly to be the case is at least philosophically possible. It's metaphysically possible, even if it's not scientifically possible. It's not metaphysically impossible in the way that a square triangle is metaphysically impossible. And so he concludes that the mind and the body are distinct kinds of things.
- 3.22** I can conceive one thing about my mind, namely that it's separable and can exist independently of itself, independently of the body. And on the other hand, I cannot imagine the body to be something that is not extended in space. I cannot imagine a body as not being a body. That just doesn't make sense. It'd be like saying, "I can't imagine a triangle as not being a triangle." So he thinks there are two completely—because these different ways of reflecting metaphysically on possibility throw up clear distinctions between these two substances, these two kinds of things, they must be distinct kinds of things.
- 3.23** And another argument, the final argument I just want to touch on is, often we might call it the argument from reason, the argument from rationality or discursive, the discursivity of our rationality. The thought here is that matter operates according to mechanical principles, mechanical necessities, laws of nature, analyses of atoms and elements, and so on and so forth. The way in which matter interacts and affects the world, imposes itself on the world, is primarily to be understood in terms of such relationships as cause and effect.
- 3.24** One billiard ball knocks into another billiard ball and moves it. It's push-and-pull. It's cause and effect, everything that we learned in physics class at school. Then, if we turn to what's happening in our minds or brains when we are thinking, or when we're following an argument that a lecturer is trying to develop, the question is: Are those processes a special causal process, in the way that the billiard balls knocking into each other are a causal process?

- 3.25** That becomes very difficult to grasp or make much sense of. I mean, yes, we sometimes talk about our thinking processes as if they were physical processes: "I get that. Do you follow me?" We use that kind of language. "I found it. I found the answer." We're using physical language to describe mental processes. But isn't that just a metaphor? Isn't that just a way of talking about how we understand things or don't understand things?
- 3.26** Descartes's point is that rational processes, the connections that we form when we're thinking about the world or stitching beliefs together or reasoning through an argument or acting out from intuition, these are completely different processes that you can't possibly explain in terms of physical cause and effect. These are rational connections, like connections between thoughts, between propositions, that lead to certain conclusions and inferences and inductions and deductions.
- 3.27** We might use the language of physics: "I get that, do you follow me," etc, but that is not literal. It's not describing any physical neurophysiological process happening in the brain. Descartes takes this for granted. I myself think it's fairly plausible. Others will say it's not, that there are ways of trying to reduce rationality to neurophysiological processes, causes and effects in the brain.
- 3.28** But Descartes takes this as self-evidently true. This is a very, very plausible way of understanding, of conceiving of rationality, namely as something that's completely distinct from ordinary, from any other cause-and-effect relationship. And so, this is the position that he lays out in the *Meditations* in 1641.
- 3.29** At the time, he's in close correspondence with a fascinating woman called Princess Elizabeth of Bohemia, Princess Elizabeth of Bohemia, who was a pen friend of Descartes and read the *Meditations* when they came out. She raised lots of very interesting objections. She's really the first great critic of Descartes. Her most famous objection, in 1643, a couple of years after the publication of the *Meditations*, is what is now known as the interaction problem, the interaction problem.
- 3.30** The interaction problem is simply stated: How can an immaterial thing move or have any impact on a material thing? If these two substances are so different, are as different as you, René, make out, how could they have anything to do with each other? If the world of the body and the world of physical objects and stuff obeys laws of science and physics and so on and so forth, and this other stuff, this other substance, the thinking substance, doesn't, are there laws that the mind obeys?
- 3.31** But whether there are laws or whether there aren't, what are the laws governing the relationship between the two? There must be something in charge. How can one have anything to do with the other? This is her objection. The mental and the physical operate according to different laws. Maybe the mental doesn't operate according to any laws at all, but simply human spontaneity and human freedom.
- 3.32** But Descartes takes it for granted. Descartes argues, these are not—the mind, the mental is not driven by causal scientific laws. So the question is: How do they influence

each other? How can something that's not in space and time, that's not extended, cause spatial events? This is the puzzle. Now, in some ways, that's not a new problem. When else would we have worried in the history of human thought about how a nonmaterial body could affect material things in the world?

- 3.33** How is it that Aphrodite, in Book 3 of the Iliad, just walks onto the battlefield? Does she walk? Would they have seen her? Homer is not always clear. There's often a mist, and it's a bit unclear, but she was definitely there. This is a problem in all religious traditions, all traditions that take God or gods to be some immaterial being. There's always some story about how that being has had a causal impact on the world. If there had been no causal impact on the world, we wouldn't know that there was, or wouldn't even believe that there was, an immaterial being.
- 3.34** So, in a funny way, this is true of many of the problems in the history of modern philosophy. They are mini versions of theological problems and problems that have been encountered in the philosophy of religion beforehand. So, this is Elizabeth's, Princess Elizabeth's, objection. How can soul move body? How can the two have anything to do with each other? Descartes doesn't really come up with an answer that has satisfied philosophers down the centuries. Others have tried.
- 3.35** There's a famous guy called Nicolas Malebranche, a French philosopher, who effectively accepted Descartes's dualism. He says that there is mind and body, but we don't have to worry about how they interact, because they don't actually interact. What happens is that God coordinates mind and body. So whenever I think I'm kicking the ball, actually what's happening is, when I will to move my foot to kick the ball, God intervenes and kicks it for me, or uses my limb to kick it for me.
- 3.36** The mental and physical events are occasions in which God can act. God conveniently knows exactly what I'm going to think, exactly what I want, exactly what I'm thinking. He's also got total control over my body. And so, effectively, whatever I want, even though I've got no access to my body, because the mind can't interact with the body, God does. So my thoughts are uploaded to God, and then God downloads the causal agency into the body. Extraordinary.
- 3.37** But this was the price that at least one brilliant philosopher was willing to pay to try to avoid this interaction problem because it seemed so insoluble. I guess if God is part of your philosophical picture already, then you can put him to work to explain things in lots of unusual ways. The trouble is that this way of doing things basically abolishes human agency. It means: Is God, therefore, the author of all my sins? Is God the causal origin of all my sins? Well, that's a bit of a problem. You don't need to be a—you don't need a PhD in Christian theology to see why that's a problem.
- 3.38** Another version, another attempt to get around this was Leibniz, Gottfried Leibniz, 1646 to 1716. Brilliant, also a brilliant mathematician. His solution was not too far off Malebranche's. He says that you've basically got this—the mind and body, mind and

body are like these two synchronized clocks. There's this preestablished harmony between mind and body.

- 3.39** We don't program it. The mind doesn't program it into the body. The body doesn't program it into the mind, but it is preprogrammed by God, by the big man upstairs. This is Leibniz's view. God preprograms perfect coordination, perfect synchronization between the two clocks: between the mental clock and the body clock. Then our lives, our biological lives, are really just the ticking of those clocks together in perfect unison.
- 3.40** And so, you don't need to worry about the interaction because they're not interacting. It looks like they're interacting, but they're just perfectly synced. And so on and so forth. There are lots of these attempts to explain and come up with, preserve Descartes's insight that the soul, the mind, is something completely different from the body, but also attempts to kind of put those two back, to put Humpty Dumpty back together again.
- 3.41** One solution, another very interesting solution, is that of George Berkeley, who is a bishop, was a bishop, 1685 to 1753, and he is a so-called idealist. We haven't come across many idealists so far. You might say Plato is an idealist in some way, but the idealist is, you might think of as the opposite of the materialist. If the materialist thinks that the ultimate, if you had to make a shopping list of all the most ultimate things in all of reality—matter, plus maybe laws of nature, plus maybe space and time—is what would make it onto that list.
- 3.42** If you're an idealist, the only thing that makes it onto that list of ultimate reality, the shopping list of ingredients for ultimate reality, is mind, thought, ideas. And Berkeley is very skeptical of materialism. He actually kind of radicalizes Descartes's approach, and he gets rid of matter completely. He says that maybe the problem is not mind, and how we fit mind into matter or mind into world, maybe the problem is just matter and world. Let's just get rid of that.
- 3.43** He says that if we can only know ideas in our minds, and that's all we really know, is what our mind tells us, then why bother? Why bother argue that there's any matter at all? Our beliefs that there is a material world, that there's a world out there, are closer to us, are more certain to us, than the world that we have beliefs about. That's his idea. So, if you're going to choose one over the other, you go for the mind that is telling you everything, the mind that is the reason why you even think that there's a world.
- 3.44** It's a very, very radical solution. What he says is that, really, all the things that we think we see exist in our minds. Galileo had made this distinction between primary properties and secondary properties: primary properties being size and scale and shape, and secondary qualities being color, flavor, taste. The primary qualities are what exists actually in the world. The secondary qualities, capacities, dispositions, we get rid of, because those are all Aristotelian, you can't see them, and they're not part of the scientific picture.

- 3.45** Berkeley flips that on its head and says that actually, all properties, including size, scale, motion, and shape, are what they are because we see them to be what they are. It's what we see them. There's no real distinction between the redness of an apple and the size of an apple. Those two properties are the same ways that apples are in the world, and I perceive them. How else would I know the scale of something if I couldn't perceive it or had no notion of scale?
- 3.46** And so he says that for the apple to be, is just for it to be perceived. What makes the world the world is that there are minds engaging it and observing it and perceiving it and thinking about it. *Esse est percipi*. To be is to be perceived. It's all in the mind. Matter, what we think of as matter and solid stuff, is simply ideas that are structured and configured in the mind.
- 3.47** This leads to one of the great puzzles, one of the great limericks in the history of philosophy, which goes like this. This is how Berkeley answers one very obvious question, an obvious objection, a very obvious puzzle, to this idealist framework. The limerick goes, "There was once a young man who said, 'God must find it exceedingly odd to find that this tree should continue to be when there's no one about in the quad.'"
- 3.48** What's the problem there? What's the objector drawing attention to? Well, if to be is to be perceived, what happens when none of us are around to perceive the red apple or the tree in the quadrangle? Does it just pop out of existence and then pop back into existence when somebody's around and catches sight of it or hears it? This seems very strange, that the world is just randomly, selectively, contingently dependent upon bipedal hominids who just happened to get lucky in the evolutionary lottery, that the world is just dependent upon us. That seems implausible.
- 3.49** The response done in Berkeley's vein—this isn't Berkeley himself, but this is how the response goes—"Dear sir, your astonishment's odd. I am always about in the quad, and that's why this tree will continue to be, since observed by yours faithfully, God." And so, this very strange system of idealism that Berkeley pushes forward turns into this argument for the existence of God.
- 3.50** The only thing that really saves his system is to say that there is a timeless, spaceless being that has a complete apprehension of all the contents of space-time and all the events and all the objects and all the relations between objects of space-time. And he apprehends it in a single flash of simultaneity. That's all the perception you need to sustain every event, every object, every aspect, every relation internal to space-time. So we don't have to worry about things popping in and out of existence. This is Berkeley's solution.
- 3.51** And so, again, this is a radical solution to the mind-body problem. Just get rid of the body. That's the problem. It's just mind. There's no interaction problem because there's

nothing to interact. It's just mind, mind and ideas, a thinker and his thoughts. There are all kinds of problems with that that we probably don't need to go into for now.

- 3.52** But I flag Berkeley there as an unusual example of going in completely the other direction, going completely towards the other extreme. At a time when almost everybody else was trying to reduce mind to world and get rid of mind and eventually eliminate mind completely, Berkeley is moving in the other direction and eliminating world from mind, until there was just mind and no matter, and it didn't matter as far as he was concerned.
- 3.53** Over the course of the 18th century and the 19th century, mind doesn't go away. It keeps persisting. You might say that the mind, as a philosophical concept, always buries its undertakers. Every time in the history of philosophy, some philosophers come along to explain why belief in soul, belief in immaterial beings like a god or selves or minds and so on, finite minds, were to be dismissed and repudiated and not believed in, suddenly comes back in with a vengeance.
- 3.54** We see this with Berkeley. We see this also with Kant, the philosophy of Immanuel Kant, for whom you also have, I suppose, an attempt to dissolve the mind-body problem. Everything for Kant begins with the thinking self, the I. He says that we just couldn't make sense of anything in the world if there wasn't an "I," a stable mind, apprehending everything that was continuous over time, that could pull everything into a unity of perception. If there were multiple "I's," I couldn't make any sense of experience.
- 3.55** How would they be talking to each other? If they're talking to each other, who's making the final decision inside me? Which "I" is ultimately the "I" that's the "I" when I'm speaking? OK, I get that I might have multiple mental executive assistants, possibly. But in the end, there's a CEO, and there can only be one. Kant's style of argument is very interesting. Kant basically says, "I don't need to argue that there is an 'I' that is pulling all these perceptions together. I don't even know how to argue with somebody who thinks that they're not an 'I.' Who do they think is doing the arguing or the listening or the responding?"
- 3.56** See, Kant says that it's obvious, it's self-evident. It's the beginning, it's the condition of the possibility of knowing and experiencing anything at all, that there's a me. There's an "I" that's doing the experiencing, doing the thinking. It's not some shared collaborative exercise. Even if it were, you'd need a CEO. You'd need somebody in the end to say, "OK, got your various inputs. This is what we're deciding."
- 3.57** Kant says it is obvious that there is an "I," and it is obvious that there is a central unified center of subjectivity. Then he says, "What must be the case for this to be true?" What he argues is that the "I," the self, must be something that transcends stuff, that transcends space and time, and the world of phenomena, the world of what can be seen. Phenomena, effectively, is Greek for things that appear.

- 3.58** Kant says there's the phenomenal world, and I can process the world of experience, the world of phenomena. Even though it's distributed across space and time, I can pull it all together into a single meaningful experience, and I can reflect upon it. But I myself, though in the phenomenal world, I'm this biological organism that you could do scientific experiments on, that you could check whether it's healthy or not, etc., but that's not the "I."
- 3.59** That's just a physical object that couldn't possibly explain; no object, no physical object, could explain how it becomes a subject, a unified subject, of all these different experiences. So there must be a self, says Kant. I don't need to give you any further arguments. I don't need to give you any contentious arguments as to why there is a self. There could not be any experience if there were not a self.
- 3.60** Now, quite what the self is and how he described it, he goes on and develops lots of arguments for it. But he effectively says that if you're looking for arguments to get to the point where you can say, "Aha, you see? Therefore, I am an 'I,'" he says something's gone really wrong. If I've decided that I am "I," I am an "I," I am a subject, at the end of the argument, who was there at the beginning? Was it somebody else?
- 3.61** Was it like some baton that you passed on with each premise and suddenly, boom, the "I" pops out? "Oh, yeah, I am an 'I.' Yeah. Good to have that confirmed." Kant says that's not, it's the wrong place to start. The "I" is the enabling condition of the possibility of all experience. The "I" is more basic than anything else, than the "it" or than the "they." This has an enormous impact on subsequent philosophy.
- 3.62** I think I mentioned in an earlier lecture that there are only two philosophers in the history of thought who you can attach the prefix "pre" to and the prefix "post" to, in a way that makes sense of the history of philosophy. The pre-Socratics, remember the pre-Socratics with Anaxagoras in lecture one? And the post-Kantians. Kant has such an enormous impact on Western philosophy that we can talk about philosophy dividing before the 1780s, when Kant is writing his great trilogy, and after the 1780s, pre-Kantian and post-Kantian.
- 3.63** One immediate figure who follows Kant, who's also enormously influential, is that of Hegel, H-E-G-E-L, 1770 to 1831. Hegel, too, is restless, not willing to accept a materialistic paradigm, nor is he willing to accept the Cartesian dualist paradigm or even Kant's dualist paradigm, because Kant draws this distinction between the phenomenal, the world of science and space and time, and what he calls the noumenal, the world of the "nous," the mind, the mental, you might say.
- 3.64** Those two domains are still there in Kant. And what Hegel tries to do is effectively diffuse that dualism. He says that true philosophy has to overcome these dualisms between mind and matter, between freedom and necessity, between subject and object. What Hegel argues in his famous Phenomenology of the Spirit, 1806, 1807, is that reality is fundamentally mental, fundamentally spiritual, you might say.

- 3.65** He develops this extraordinary thesis about how the development of the world, development of reality, is nothing other than the world's spirit, the "Weltgeist," the world's spirit, gradually, as it were, diffusing itself through the world and through the processes of history; that the world itself has a kind of consciousness, and that history is that process of the world coming into an awareness of itself, coming into self-consciousness. And mind and matter are just phases in the development of that world spirit, of geist.
- 3.66** The thought here is that the mind-body problem is a confusion. It's a false separation, that really what we should be thinking about is in terms of consciousness at different phases and in different degrees. He says that the sense of spirit and mind emerges over time. The famous example that he gives here is of a dialogue that he imagines, or a life that he imagines, between a master and a slave.
- 3.67** He says, a master and a slave, you've got this radically asymmetric relationship: master having complete power over the slave. But then over time, that relationship shifts a little bit, and the master becomes more and more dependent on the slave, as the slave makes himself more and more useful and more and more indispensable. What you have, as it were, over time, is this dynamic process of recognition.
- 3.68** The master begins to recognize the slave not just as an object, but as a subject with intentions, with desires, with will to do things in the world, to have an impact on the world, to serve him. Conversely, the slave becomes more self-conscious of himself as a subject. This process continues, and it unfolds. And the self-consciousness that the master has as a master is there because he's got a slave. Conversely, the slave comes to see himself as a slave turning into a servant, turning into an equal, because of the presence of the master.
- 3.69** And so this struggle for recognition is what creates these master-slave relationships that are unstable, but it's through this process of mutual recognition, the mutual dawning of a self-conscious awareness, that history evolves. Hegel thinks that this is what is happening all across humanity, all across the world, all across civilization. And this idea is that the world mind, the world spirit, achieves objectivity, not by just coming to know external matter, but by creating institutions, like the family or law or government.
- 3.70** These are, in Hegel's view, these are like—this is thought, world spirit, world intellect, crystallized, community intellect crystallized into particular forms and structures of life. And so the mind-body problem gets resolved through almost political and social development. So, we've looked at lots of different options across what, just over, barely 200 years, from 1641, when Descartes writes the Meditations, up to the death of Hegel in 1831.
- 3.71** You still see, within the history of philosophy, even after Descartes, this deep tension between whether we understand what we're doing in the world, primarily in terms of

reason, which would be the case with many of the continental European philosophers — Descartes we've mentioned, Spinoza, Leibniz.

- 3.72** And on the other hand, those philosophers who say, "We're skeptical of reason, we think rationality doesn't get us anywhere. It gets us to the barricades of the French Revolution in 1789, all these crazy revolutionaries coming up with utopian schemes of how they can fix the world, and they're actually going to wreck the world. They're going to destroy the world.
- 3.73** What we should really be focusing on is just common sense, sense experience, not put too much faith in those clever, clever Europeans who've got all these clever schemes that they think are going to lead to a kind of political paradise. We just take the world as we find it, and we should focus on our sense experience more than we should focus on our reason. We should think more about maybe feelings, our desires, than we should about facts alone."
- 3.74** In a way, this swings back and forth throughout the 17th century and throughout the 18th century, too. The resolution to that, you might say, is in the philosophy of Kant, because in Kant, you have this attempt to bridge the two. Kant says that thoughts without content are empty. If it's just reason, if it's just my mind, but nothing for my mind to get its teeth into, in sense experience, then I've just got an empty mind, empty thoughts spinning frictionlessly in the void. But perception and sense experience without reason and thought, without the mind to inform it and to make sense of it and to filter it, would be blind.
- 3.75** I think I'd be perceiving the world, but if I'm not thinking and if I've got nothing, if my reason can't shape what I'm experiencing in any way, then I might as well be—I'll be in the equivalent of a persistent vegetative state. Because the pixels will be coming at me, but I'll have no way to sort them into anything I can make sense of. Kant says you need both.
- 3.76** If all you've got is a pixelator, you've got an iPhone, but you've got no pixels coming through, you've got the mind, but you've got no sense experience from the world filling it, then it's just a dead iPhone. It's not going to tell you anything. It's not going to tell you anything. It's not a window onto the world in any way.
- 3.77** On the other hand, if all I'm getting is the pixels, but no phone to organize the pixels, if it's just sense experience, but no mind, it's just matter, but no mind, then it's just going to be this avalanche of data that's not even data. It's just this pixelated—it's this waterfall, as it were. It's like a torrent, a tsunami that I can't make sense of. I might as well be in a persistent vegetative state. I might as well just not be experiencing anything.
- 3.78** Kant's genius is to see that the mind and matter have to come together. And quite how they do, Kant doesn't really tell us, or at least the way his arguments for how they come together are extremely controversial, and effectively, nobody really accepts

them. But what he was good at is saying that, however they come together, they have to come together. It must be the case that you can't just have mind on its own, and you can't just have experience on its own. The two have to go together.

- 3.79** The mind has to filter and shape and render experience intelligible. And if there's no experience there, then that's just an empty mind, and nothing will do as well as an empty mind. That's Kant's great achievement. What we will see and what we'll turn to in the next lecture is a leap forward in the direction not of Kant or of Hegel, or certainly not of Descartes, but away from this attempt to bring the mind back into the matter and back into the world, and a drive towards a completely materialistic universe, a completely materialistic landscape, that tries one more time to get rid of mind altogether.
- 3.80** Part of what's driving this is the sciences, and particularly the publication in 1859 of Darwin's *Origin of Species*. This return of an idea that human beings are and only are biological organisms, and in many ways, you might say, well, that's quite similar to Aristotle. Remember Aristotle? He was very into sense experience, nature, science. He thought the soul was everywhere, in all living things.
- 3.81** Remember the three tiers? The nutritive soul that all plants, animals, and human beings have, the sensory soul that the animal kingdom has, and then finally, the rational soul that human beings have. The difference with Darwin and Darwinian ways of thinking about what it is to be a human being is, it's a return to that very naturalistic, nature-based scientific focus, but without any talk of Aristotelian soul. There's no sense that somehow matter is informed in some way.
- 3.82** That's still very much part of what's been repudiated by the scientific revolution. And so, questions of mind and consciousness become much more mysterious, and they're not so much explained as they are explained away. And that will take us for the next lecture into where the arguments really get interesting and technical and thrilling, particularly, it's really after the Second World War, but there are some precursors for that that are worth flagging.
- 3.83** So in the next lecture, we're going to dive, we're going to do a hop, skip, and a jump into the 20th century, and we're going to, hopefully now, we'll be informed by all the extraordinary historical hinterlands and explorations of this problem, and will be in a position that most university students doing this course or the equivalent to this course will not be in. So most university students doing this course will be starting the course now, without any sense that any discussion or exploration of these questions occurred before about 1900. Well, normally, Descartes is mentioned as just this foolish Frenchman who had these crazy ideas.
- 3.84** But what I hope that we've been able to do in these first three lectures is to go through, really, the whole history of Western philosophy. We haven't covered everybody. We've covered a lot of the big figures on this, arguably the hardest question that any

philosopher can ask, namely: What am I? Who am I? What is it to be minded, if we are minded at all? Thank you for listening.

- 3.85** If a person is born blind, will that support the idea that reality is mental?
- 3.86** Great question. I thought you were going in a different direction when you started. The person who says that there is no mind would be able to say that the blind person has thoughts like anyone else, that those thoughts will not extend to thoughts about the way the world can be seen. Actually, it's very interesting talking to congenitally blind people about what they think they can—do they see anything? They don't. They don't see anything.
- 3.87** Could they understand shape if that's all they—this is a famous problem that John Locke gets occupied with. If you gave somebody a cylinder who'd been blind from birth, could they see it as a cylinder? Could the sense of touch be connected somehow to a defective sense? It's a really interesting question. But I think it wouldn't be a challenge to the person who says there is no mind. It would simply be, well, blind people have an interior life. It'll be different from a sighted person's interior life.
- 3.88** But the materialist will presumably have an account of why it is that our interior life is not in fact interior, but is just the firings of synapses and brain chemistry. Just as that person thinks that—those philosophers think that we can explain ordinary sighted conscious experience in physical scientific terms, the inner life of a blind person, such as it is, whatever it might be, can also be explained in reductive terms.
- 3.89** But I think the idea of going through life blind, or perhaps going through life without any senses at all, still, one wants to say, there's an interior life. There's an interior life. Locked-in syndrome, for example, that wonderful book called *The Diving Bell and the Butterfly*. I don't know if you know, if you read that book of this famous French, I think he was a fashion editor. He had a terrible accident, and he ends up in the hospital, paralyzed completely, except for one eyelid.
- 3.90** And over the course of many months, he writes a book with his eyelid. Think about that. And develops a writing system. One blink, A. Two blinks, B. They worked it all out, and he produces this book. It's the most fascinating book. What was he thinking? What's he feeling? What's his—but it is the work of somebody with an incredibly dense inner life, even though he can only move one eyelid. But that one eyelid allows him to communicate what's going on inside him.
- 3.91** So, there is something going on there. There's something in there which is subjective. It's something different from what's objectively given. But yeah, so I think, as a problem for the person who says there's no such thing as mind, there's no internal interior theater, they'd say, "We've already done the difficult bit. We've come up with some account of why it is that sighted people think they have inner lives. It's like a comforting folk delusion. It's some weird thing that we don't understand yet, but give us some more money and time, and we'll come up—"

3.92 The tech pros in Silicon Valley will explain to us how actually there is no such thing as consciousness, and we'll get to strong AI, and we can upload ourselves into the internet, whatever it might be, whatever Neuralink wants to do. They'd simply say it's not an issue for us. It's not a problem. Now, I think it is a problem, but it's not a problem that— it's a problem that they have when it comes to explaining how sighted people, as well as blind people, have a sense of an inner life.

Lecture 4: Mind Meets Science

At a glance — Mind meets science — how empirical science reshaped the debate.

- 4.1 Welcome, everyone, to lecture four in Introduction to Philosophy of Mind. In the first three lectures, we covered a lot of historical hinterlands to our central problem, the central problem being: What am I? What is the I? What is it to be a subject? What is it to be conscious, to have beliefs, to be able to reason? All of these features of our existence, of what it is to be human, are not just nice add-ons. They're the conditions of the possibility of having any engagement with the world at all.
- 4.2 And yet, it is a mystery, particularly in the modern world, how these things are possible, how it's possible to reason, how it's possible to have beliefs, how it's possible to entertain thoughts, and so on and so forth. Part of the reason for that, part of the reason that the mind-body problem is a problem in the modern world in a way that perhaps wasn't quite so much with Plato and with Aristotle, Augustine and Aquinas, and it is that science has the, as it were, dominant hold on the orthodoxies of contemporary philosophy and indeed, contemporary popular culture.
- 4.3 When we think of science, we think, perhaps a little bit less so in the wake of COVID and lockdowns and all the public debates over that, the legitimacy of science and capital Science TM; but nevertheless, science still has this dominant, authoritative voice on the modern world, in terms of what counts as really real, what counts as actually the case. This superstition, I think, is what it is, really, is called scientism.
- 4.4 You can believe in the natural sciences and their power and all the blessings that they brought and all the—whatever the opposite of blessings is, and they've brought plenty of those as well, without believing in scientism. That is to say, without believing that the best account of all reality is the one that science gives us.
- 4.5 Part of the problem there is not just that science has to be agnostic about whether or not there are such things as minds, because if there were such a thing as a mind, science wouldn't be able to tell us what it is, because what it is to believe that there are minds, mental states? It just is to believe that there is some non-physical, non-scientific dimension to reality.
- 4.6 Even if we can get comfortable with the idea that there are no minds, can we also get comfortable with the idea that there are no numbers? There are no mathematical objects? Scientism gets rid of those, too, because you can't do scientific experiments on the number two. Similarly, with moral truths, we have to get rid of those. You can't see courage under a microscope. You can't do experiments on different virtues, and so on and so forth.
- 4.7 So there's a whole—many, many dimensions of reality and of human experience that fall away when we take up this scientistic perspective on reality. Nevertheless, that is

the dominant view within philosophy departments all around, all across the West. It's, broadly speaking, I would have thought, maybe it's losing a bit of ground, but it's probably reflexively what people, as it were, the common man thinks, that is to say, on the streets at the popular level—that science has still got this disproportionate influence over what counts as real, how we're really to think seriously about the world.

- 4.8 What we're going to do now in this lecture, we're moving much more now into contemporary territory, the contemporary debate. We've done some historical scene-setting, and now we're really nearly at the 20th century. In fact, we can begin, really, around about 1900 with two Cambridge philosophers: G. E. Moore and Bertrand Russell, two young, very brilliant philosophers at Trinity College, Cambridge, and I think, King's College, Cambridge.
- 4.9 And these two young turks, as it were, these two philosophical revolutionaries, first made their name by going up against something called absolute idealism, or British Hegelianism, British idealism. You'll remember in the previous lecture, I talked very briefly about Hegel and the way in which he comes up with this idea of spirit or mind, the world having a spirit, the world having a mind; and the processes of history are the processes of a world coming increasingly to a state of self-consciousness about itself.
- 4.10 Well, this gets going in all—this has an enormous impact on continental philosophy and, in turn, on British philosophy. There are the so-called left Hegelians and the right Hegelians. The left Hegelians are really the Marxists. So Marx takes up Hegel, he gets rid of all the spooky stuff, he gets rid of the world soul, and he materializes it all. Everything becomes material. And so, what's driving human history is not the processes of geist coming aware of itself; the driving forces of history are the factors of production—the means and the factors of production, the control of the factors of production.
- 4.11 It's a purely socio-economic, materialistic analysis. But the basic claim is still very similar to Hegel's, this idea that there's a dynamism to history, that there is a moment of resolution, and then there are the sunlit uplands beyond. They share a great deal in common. The right Hegelians took Hegel's metaphysics, his theories about mind, and developed those a great deal. That took off in England, in particular in Oxford, particularly Balliol College, Oxford, where I was, many years ago, as an undergraduate.
- 4.12 And this, in the 1860s to the 1890s, this is really the dominant view: that reality is fundamentally mental, fundamentally spiritual. It's very surprising to see this view emerge at a time when science is really reaching its peak in terms of its power, its powers of discovery, and its powers of cultural influence, that this still persisted, this idea of absolute idealism. The view is that there is this absolute mind that encompasses all individual minds and all physical objects, and that effectively human beings, as it were, have a refraction of the absolute mind.

- 4.13** There's no genuine mind-body problem because it got rid of the body. It got rid of the matter. It's just mind. It's mind all the way down. No matter, and that doesn't matter. It's striking, even as I describe absolute idealism at the end of the 19th century, how similar it is to the theory of Anaxagoras. Right back at the beginning of the course, do you remember Anaxagoras? Born in 500 BC, dies around about 428, 427 BC. This is basically his view, that there is this single absolute mind that drives the intelligibility and transparency of the world and accounts for why there are many minds participating in the absolute mind.
- 4.14** Now, in a lot of the ways it's framed, it's, of course, very, very different. They're not thinking of Anaxagoras, but it's very interesting that, what, 2,500 years on, you've effectively got this group of philosophers in Oxford, the cutting edge of 19th-century philosophy, broadly speaking, restating Anaxagoras's original insights. Just going to pause for a moment. This is a little tangent, but it's an important one.
- 4.15** One of the most glorious things about philosophy is also one of the most frustrating things about philosophy. Namely, that we're used, particularly in the natural sciences, to progress. We make progress with problems and arguments and debates and experiments, and so on. Philosophy, unfortunately, never makes progress of any kind. That's because it's in the nature of philosophy to ask questions that can't be answered in the way that a scientist or a mathematician can answer them. There are no slam-dunk arguments in philosophy.
- 4.16** As Cicero and Descartes said in their different ways, there is no idea that isn't so crazy that some philosopher at some point in history hasn't been willing to defend it. It's true. End of the 19th century, this view of absolute idealism, absolute mind, it would seem as if, "Haven't we addressed that? Haven't we moved on a little bit since the fifth century BC?" But no, there's no moving on, because there's no evidence that can count dispositively, decisively, in favor of the conclusion to any philosophical argument.
- 4.17** It will always be possible for a rational person to listen to any argument in the history of philosophy and still walk away, saying, "I don't buy it. I don't buy it." That's not possible in mathematics. It's not possible, really, in science. It's not possible in a whole load of other areas. There, if somebody walks away, saying, "I don't buy this strange belief you have, that $2 + 2 = 4$," there's not a problem. It's not, "Whatever you think, and let's agree to disagree," instead of, "You need therapy," or something. It's not to do with reasonable disagreement about these conclusions.
- 4.18** And so, we see idealism is back in a big way in the end of the 19th century. This is what G. E. Moore and Bertrand Russell, over in Cambridge—this is partly an Oxford-Cambridge dispute—react against so aggressively at the dawn of the 20th century. Their responses were—we don't need to go into great depth about what Moore and Russell did to change the whole history of Anglo-American philosophy. In many ways, they founded Anglo-American philosophy in refuting the idealists.

- 4.19 It's often called analytic philosophy now, and it's a particular, should we say, style of philosophy, a school of philosophy, that is typically distinguished from continental European philosophy, though that distinction is not always easy to apply. For example, Moore, we've come across already. We've come across at various points. I think we've talked about G. E. Moore and his insistence that, really, when we see the world, that's the world that we get.
- 4.20 We're not looking at intermediaries here. This is so-called direct realism. When we perceive the world, we perceive it directly. We're not seeing ideas of the world in front of us. He thinks that mental states are completely transparent. When we're seeing blue, we're aware of blueness. We're not seeing some mental state that we have of blue. It's not like we're looking through some, like the mind is like a window that we're looking through. But we actually perceive and apprehend the world right there.
- 4.21 And Russell, too, Bertrand Russell, brings in this idea of logical atomism. He has an unusual idea, what he calls neutral monism, where he says that all the world is made up of a single kind of stuff, which, as it were, can have both mental and physical elements, which are built up out of sense data that we see and perceive in front of us. The way that sense data is configured will account for whether or not they are mental elements or physical elements.
- 4.22 Now, no one's really still on board with Moore and Russell's ideas on mind and perception. A few are, but they're definitely, as I said, haven't won the argument 125 years later. But what they did do is, they reset the history of the mind-body problem, the history of philosophy of mind, in the impact that they had on philosophy. They rejected idealism, and particularly idealism's attempt to dissolve the distinction between mind and world, between mind and matter.
- 4.23 They, as it were, put back on the table this problem of: we've got these physical phenomena, we've got these mental phenomena, how do we fit these together? In the wake of Russell and Moore, you have, in the 1920s in Vienna, the emergence of a new movement, a new school of European philosophy called, to begin with, the Wiener Kreis, the Vienna Circle. And from that, this is people like Rudolf Carnap and Otto Neurath, fascinating figures in 1920s Vienna.
- 4.24 And a young Englishman visited them in the late 1920s by the name of Freddie Ayer, A.J. Ayer, A-Y-E-R. Spent quite a bit of time with them and learned some German, went back to London, and I think, in a bar in Soho, wrote in about three weeks a book that became one of the most influential works of philosophy in 20th-century English, certainly one of the leading Anglo-American works of philosophy.
- 4.25 That book was *Language, Truth, and Logic*. Not the snappiest or catchiest title, not what you'd expect to be a bestseller. It wasn't quite a bestseller, but in philosophy terms, it was. 1936, *Language, Truth, and Logic*. What Ayer did in this book was effectively to digest and explain, in a very compelling way, what these guys in Vienna were up to.

Although it was not a great deal of originality in the book, it's more the way he puts it together. It's in this very fluid style, very easy to read, probably because he was writing it in three weeks. It was just in a bar; no doubt that was lubricating his prose style.

- 4.26 But it had a huge impact. A lot of people were reading it. What the book did is, it effectively set up a way of thinking about philosophy that became very dominant indeed, particularly in Oxford, which at the time was a big rival to Cambridge, but Oxford was a very significant school of philosophy in the West, probably the dominant and the biggest department in the world at the time. It's actually, I think, very close to being that still.
- 4.27 What Ayer argues is, as he tries to convey what the Vienna Circle were trying to do, he was effectively explaining that, when it comes to understanding what we say, when it comes to analyzing language, which is the fashionable thing to do at the moment in these circles, we're thinking about language, we're thinking about what language means and how we analyze language precisely and carefully. Because if we don't, then if our talk is wrong, our thought will be wrong.
- 4.28 There is this resurgence of awareness in Anglo-American philosophy that distinguishes them from continental philosophy when it comes to precision, accurately describing and capturing in our words and in our arguments exactly what we're referring to. Now, this could go too far. Indeed, it did go too far, but it was a perceived response to the very grand rhetorical style of the continental philosophers, of a Nietzsche or of a Hegel or of a Marx, even of a Kant, who was himself actually quite precise.
- 4.29 But a lot of it, it feels like guff, as the English say. I don't know if that's a word in American, but it's a style that is maddeningly imprecise and has a lot of allusions, and it's very historically situated, but it's not easy to pull out the arguments precisely. This is what these circles focused on, and so they were very interested in the nature of language.
- 4.30 In effect, what they suggested, and what Ayer describes in his book, is that, really, language, all statements, could be divided up into three categories. The first two categories are statements that are meaningful. The third category are statements that are literally meaningless. Category number one are those statements that are true in virtue of the terms that are being used. They are true a priori. You can grasp them a priori, that is to say, prior to getting up out of your armchair and inspecting something in the world.
- 4.31 So, all bachelors are unmarried men. All bachelors are unmarried men. This is the famous example. Nobody can say, "No, that's wrong. I met one last night in the bar." "No, you didn't." "But I know, I really did." "No, you didn't." "But you weren't with me at the bar." "It doesn't matter that I wasn't with you at the bar." "Why not?" The answer to that is that you do not understand the terms that you've been using in that

statement. You somehow think that being a bachelor carries exceptions, or that it doesn't mean being an unmarried man.

- 4.32** That first category of statements are just true; they're logically true. Their denial entails a contradiction, different ways of describing analytic statements, but let me say their denial entails a contradiction. The denial, "Yes, I did meet a bachelor in the bar last night," then you've got an immediate logical contradiction here.
- 4.33** Or you might simply say it's just true in virtue of the terms that are being used. That's basically a definition. It's trivially, definitionally true that bachelors are unmarried men. So far, so good. And that has meaning, says Ayer and the Vienna Circle. Those kinds of statements have meaning.
- 4.34** The second category of statements is simply a posteriori statements, that is to say, statements that we can verify to be true after we've got up off our posterior from the armchair and inspected the world in some way, gathered some data. So all of science, everything that we can appeal to evidence for, or that relies on somebody who's gathered the evidence and evaluated it, all those statements are meaningful. They carry meaning.
- 4.35** In the third category is all the statements that are not true in virtue of the terms used, or that are not verifiable by inspecting the world. All other statements are technically meaningless. They lack meaning. They are non-sense. They do not have sense. That may sound plausible until we consider what statements would go into that third category, as far as Ayer and the Vienna Circle are concerned.
- 4.36** "Peter loves Jane. Peter loves Jane." That is a meaningless statement. It doesn't belong to the definition of Peter, that he loves Jane, or doesn't belong to the definition of Jane that she is loved by Peter. What would an empirical or scientifically satisfactory account of Peter's loving Jane even look like? Well, there are these neurochemicals in Peter's—I mean, it's going to be very, very difficult to support that.
- 4.37** So that statement, which seems meaningful to us, strictly speaking, has no meaning on the logical positivist view. It's neither logical, nor is it empirical. "God exists. God does not exist." That doesn't work at all. If you're tempted to, anyone tempted to watch the Introduction to the Philosophy of Religion lectures for Peterson Academy will know that, actually, there are some theists who would say, "No, God exists, in fact, belongs in the first category. It belongs to what it is to be God, that he can't fail to exist." But I'm not going to go down that rabbit hole here in the Philosophy of Mind.
- 4.38** The third category is important because it also covers all the questions that we've been considering until now—questions about mind, about consciousness, about belief, about intentionality, how our thoughts are about the world in some way. Why? Because we're not talking about analytically necessarily true statements when we're talking about mind. They wouldn't qualify for the first category.

- 4.39 Secondly, in the second category, the question of scientific verification, well, the whole history of the mind-body problem is the problem of how we can make sense of a reality that seems completely indispensable, but that doesn't measure up to scientific inquiry, is invisible to scientific inquiry. The question is: Is it invisible because it doesn't exist, or is it invisible because science has its limits? It has a domain beyond which it can't illuminate us or tell us anything new as science.
- 4.40 But nevertheless, this whole new paradigm within Anglo-American philosophy, of meaning first, logic first, then evidence, and if it's not logic or evidence, it's nothing, it's nonsense, it's certainly not philosophically interesting, and we're not going to discuss it because it literally has got no sense, you can't discuss it, you can't argue about it, it's a very radical move.
- 4.41 What it does, really, in the wake of the Second World War, you have a variety of—this is when philosophy of mind really gets going in its contemporary form. You begin to have different attempts to make sense of mind within the broad paradigm of the logical positivist revolution, the A. J. Ayer revolution, the Vienna Circle revolution, the Moore and Russell revolution, too. Russell and Ayer are good friends.
- 4.42 That's what sets the scene, really. In the beginning of the 1950s, the great challenge, the El Dorado of philosophy of mind, is to come up with a theory that explains why there is no mind at all. Nothing. No consciousness, no beliefs and intentions that are not completely reducible to the gray, gooey, yogurty substance weighing about a kilo inside our skulls. That's all it is.
- 4.43 What we're going to do now is just consider three of those attempts, three of those strategies, that really dominated philosophy of mind from the 1950s all the way up to, let's say, the early 1990s, I think would be fair. These three are behaviorism and identity theory, and third, functionalism; and they all share certain connections and similarities, and we'll go through those in some detail.
- 4.44 So, behaviorism. What is behaviorism? Well, behaviorism is an attempt to eliminate our inner worlds. It's to say that, actually, what's going on inside, what we think is going on inside our own minds, is just a confusion. And I think part of the problem here is, part of the driver for it, was also the emergence of this field called psychology. It's really quite a new form of human inquiry. It's not really getting going until the early 1900s in Vienna, with Freud and with Jung and a number of others as well.
- 4.45 The problem with psychology, hopefully you'll be alive to this, what's that first half, the first syllabus in psychology, psych, psyche? Do you remember that from the Greek word, how difficult it was to define? It means soul. It also means animating life force. Aristotle thinks it's everywhere. Plato thinks it's locked in our corporeal cages. But it's plainly something that's not material. It's not something you can see and touch and smell and so on.

- 4.46 And so, by setting up an entire discipline, psychology, which is purporting, on the one hand, to be a science, like physics or biology or whatever, but whose central subject matter is the driving force behind one of the biggest debates in the history of philosophy from the fifth century BC onwards, namely whether or not it is a scientific object, whether it is an object of scientific inquiry—this is a very unstable foundation for a discipline.
- 4.47 Here's an interesting exercise. What would you—suppose at the end of the 19th century, claims began to be made for the existence of fairies. A science of fairyology, an entire discipline was set up, and these very influential figures in fancy European cities and universities started arguing, writing long monographs about this particular aspect and this particular approach. This is the correct approach to fairyology.
- 4.48 Then one of his acolytes breaks away and starts a rival school. "No, this is the approach to fairyology. Don't believe that guy." Suppose this carried on for decade after decade after decade. More schools opening up, more rival camps, more academic journals, more books. It starts to filter into popular culture, different apps, and so on and so forth, entire cottage industries doing fairyology consultations and so on.
- 4.49 What would you expect, 120 years on? How would you describe this scene, this landscape? What you would probably say is, "I'm not too sure about the existence of fairies," but if fairies didn't exist, then this is very likely what the history of fairyology was always going to look like. There's no consensus. There's nothing that quite counts as evidence in favor of one group or the other, which allows another group to break away and so on.
- 4.50 There's revenue here, there's money. You think of all these diehard fairy fanatics. They're going for it. They think they're so committed to it. They're willing to pay a lot of money for it. I think the analogy to psychology is, what's happening at the beginning of the 20th century, in my view—this is a controversial view, but I think it's probably true, and it's relevant to the philosophy of mind because of this confusion around whether or not the mind is something that is a scientific object or not—what I think you see in the history of psychology is fragmentation, that sense of that there isn't really a guiding consensus.
- 4.51 That's because the feedback loops for correctness and course correction don't exist, because the feedback loops are not feedback loops with anything that we understand at a scientific level. We can say we understand minds, we can understand how people behave, and so on and so forth.
- 4.52 Maybe social psychology works because what you're doing with social psychology is, rather than trying to make sense of an individual person's thought processes and mind and consciousness and feelings and imagination and history and so on, you're actually doing something a lot easier. You're trying to do that times a million, times 100 million. Now, why is that easier?

- 4.53 Well, because what the social psychologists can tell us is, say, "For any one individual, we haven't got a window into their hearts, we haven't got a window into their lives, we haven't got a window into their minds. But when we ask this question of 10 million people, 'Does X make you happier, all other things being equal?', this is the clear pattern that emerges. Like, yes, 80% of people say X."
- 4.54 Now, that's not irrelevant; that's a significant finding. But it's only psychology in the very, I think, not the original sense. That's really just seeing patterns in human responses and being able to base public policy on that, but much, much harder to do that at the individual level. So, this is what's going on. Psychology has got an inferiority complex—this is my speculation.
- 4.55 It wants to be a science. It wants to be believed to be a science. It wants the credibility of science. It wants to invest itself with the authority of science. But it's not clear that it is a science. Physics studies atoms; biology studies living organisms; psychology studies soul or mind? It's not to say you can't study those, but is science and experiment and the entire scientific method, which was supposed to have reduced and explained all that stuff away, really credible as a science?
- 4.56 You can make sense of neuroscience, right? If you're a materialist who thinks that there's no mind, it's just matter, OK, fine. Then all there is is the gray gooey yogurt, and we just need a science that explores gray gooey yogurt, and that's neuroscience. Most neuroscientists, until they start publishing books and popular books, most neuroscientists don't make grand claims about what they can show from MRI scans to how somebody's going to behave next week. Sometimes they end up saying things like that, but it's false. It's just not true. They can't do that and never will be able to.
- 4.57 So, this is the situation. The behaviorists emerge because they want to try to find some scientific basis for making sense of what leads us to attribute mind to human beings. Let's just put it that way. What is it that makes us think human beings are minded creatures? What the behaviorists say is that we've got to get rid of all this introspection, this idea of there being some inner life.
- 4.58 We just need to say that all the conscious mental states are, are dispositions to behave in particular ways in particular situations. Dispositions, that is to say, the way you're disposed to, the way you're inclined to behave in a particular way. There's nothing more to mind or to having a mind than being disposed, inclined to behave in particular ways. OK, what does this mean?
- 4.59 The key text here is Gilbert Ryle. Gilbert Ryle's *The Concept of Mind*, 1949, a brilliant work. Ryle is a friend of Ayer, wrote beautifully. Wrong about almost everything, in my view. But he writes beautifully, so everybody thinks he's right. What Ryle develops is this idea that actually dualism, mind-body dualism, Cartesian dualism, actually commits a fundamental error, makes a big mistake.

- 4.60 The example he uses is an American tourist coming to Oxford and saying, "Where's the university? Where's the university?" Now, in Oxford, the reason that question is a mistake, after the tourist has seen all the colleges and all the laboratories and all the faculties and then asks, "Where's the university?" he's already seen the university. That is the university. There is no campus at Oxford. There are 35 to 40 colleges, independent colleges running their own things or semi-independent.
- 4.61 And that's it. And the university is the basket of all those colleges, all those colleges put together. There's no university over and above that collection of colleges. Same in Cambridge, too. It's the medieval structure of the university. Ryle's point is that the tourist thinks that there is something over and above the collection of constituent elements in the university.
- 4.62 Ryle thinks that the dualist makes the same mistake when it comes to brain and mind. You've got all of the different ingredients, all of the different accounts of behavior and behavioral capacities—how people behave and how people act in minded ways—but then makes the mistake of asking, "Oh, and then, where is the mind here? Where's the mind? What's mind?"
- 4.63 Ryle's point is that, just as the tourist has seen everything that is the university, so too, once we've seen the behavior and all the different ways that a minded person is inclined to act and behave, you've seen the mind. They're legible to you. They're just transparent to you in their mental life. So mental life goes from the inner to the outer. Everything is inscribed on our behavior and the way we act and the way we would act in certain situations. There isn't some extra entity, the mind, over and above these capacities to behave in particular ways.
- 4.64 When we talk about mind-related terms, like intelligence or belief or being in pain, knowing French, these are actually ways of behaving. These are dispositions to behave in particular ways. How do we understand that? Well, intelligence, for Ryle, is not some mysterious inner faculty; it's the tendency to behave intelligently, to solve problems quickly, to learn from mistakes, adapt to new situations, and so on and so forth.
- 4.65 People who've got the dispositions to do that, they've got intelligence. But it's not some ethereal, spooky faculty that exists in a way we can't really understand in the gray gooey yogurt. Believing it's going to rain tomorrow morning is not some mysterious inner mental state for Ryle; it's the behavioral tendency to pick up an umbrella, to cancel any picnics or barbecues that we were planning, close the windows, talk to people about the interesting weather. That's all it is. That's all the belief that it's going to rain tomorrow morning is. It's all there. It's all to be seen in the behavior.
- 4.66 Being in pain, again, it's not some private inner sensation. It's a tendency to scream when you're pinched or whatever it might be, and so on and so forth. Ryle calls the Cartesian dualism that he's trying to criticize, famously, the idea that there's a ghost in the machine, a ghost in the machine. And these Cartesians, these dualists who keep

saying that the mind and body are related in these ways, are like people who believe that there's a ghost in the machine.

- 4.67** It's a very interesting phrase, that. It's famous as a satirical put-down to Cartesian dualists. But what does it reveal that he thinks human beings are? Machines. We've just got to get rid of the ghost and recognize that human beings are machines. I think the put-down actually can be turned against Ryle. That's a very, very bold claim, that we just are machines.
- 4.68** For a start, even if you are inclined to scientism, you might say, "We're not machines. I mean, at least call us animals. I mean, do us that much credit." Machines are actually very, very different in all kinds of ways from human beings. At least do what Aristotle did and say, "Look, we are complex, highly complex, indeed unique, members of the animal kingdom, to be explained in terms of biology, first and foremost, rather than physics." But anyway, it's an interesting and revealing way that Ryle thinks of human persons.
- 4.69** There's this interesting joke, the joke I heard the other day, of the behaviorist waking up one morning with his other half, and turning to her and saying, "Last night was great for you. How was it for me?" The joke being that the behaviorist has to check with his wife how he enjoyed last night, the previous night. He can inform his wife how much she enjoyed the previous night because it's all on the outside. There's no inside. That's the joke. "That was great for you. How was it for me?"
- 4.70** There are other important figures we need to touch on. Ludwig Wittgenstein, we should probably touch on very briefly here because he has an important role to play in the development of behaviorism, and particularly through something called his private language argument. Wittgenstein, there's a famous anecdote of him walking with G. E. Moore around one of the courts at Cambridge College, and Moore is worrying about the problem of the external world, skepticism about whether there is an external world, whether we could be brains in a vat, and how do our minds hook on to the world, and all of these different problems.
- 4.71** And Wittgenstein stops, turns to Moore, and says, "The external world. External to what? External to what?" Wittgenstein's view is that we've been held captive by this picture, a picture has held us captive, of the relationship between mind and world as being a relationship between subject and object, where I, as a subject, have this inner world, and then there's this world outside, and then all the problems of philosophy begin, at least all the problems of epistemology begin.
- 4.72** There's a whole vast, disciplined philosophy. How do we bridge the gap between the inner world of my mind and my thoughts and the outer world? It can't be physical. Is it a physical connection? That doesn't really make sense. But how do I form beliefs about it? How do I know that something's not getting in the way, that I can't see, like a

hallucination or an illusion, et cetera, et cetera? And Wittgenstein just says, "You need to dissolve your assumptions here."

- 4.73 If you get rid of this strange picture of there being this inner theater inside and then this outer world beyond it, if you drop that picture, then you cease to worry about anything. You don't have to worry about building a bridge. Mindedness, to have a mind and to be able to use terms involving the mind, is a purely external, or it's already everything's there, everything's legible in a person's behavior, says Wittgenstein.
- 4.74 He says, at one point in the *Philosophical Investigations*, which was published in 1953, two years after he died in Cambridge in 1951, he only ever wrote one book in 1921, 1922, the *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, and thought that that book had solved all the problems of philosophy, and therefore, he retired as a philosopher, because he believed he'd written a book that was the reason why all philosophers should now retire, and went off to become a gardener in a monastery in Austria, and then as a teacher, and then he got fired for that.
- 4.75 Then, gradually, at the end of the 1920s, he realized that the book that he had published that he thought had solved all the problems of philosophy had not, in fact, solved all the problems of philosophy. He was completely wrong. He spent the next 20, 25 years of his life trying to prove why his earlier self, his younger self, was wrong. He returns to Cambridge in 1929. John Maynard Keynes announces to his colleagues in King's College, "God arrived in Cambridge today. I met him on the 5:15 from King's Cross station."
- 4.76 He had this extraordinary personality. Over the course of the '30s and '40s, he developed, well, he wrote about many things, but one of his central concerns was language and how language connected to problems of the mind. One analogy that he asks us to consider is the beetle in the box analogy. He says, suppose everyone had a box, their own private box, with something inside it. On the box is written one word. On everybody's boxes is written one word, beetle. Beetle. B-E-E-T-L-E.
- 4.77 No one's allowed to look in anyone else's box. Everyone says he knows what a beetle is, only by looking at his beetle in his box. Wittgenstein's point here is that nobody really knows what the word beetle means. The word beetle does not mean anything in such a scenario. Everyone's referring to their own thing in the box with the word beetle, but nobody has any idea whether that same thing is in other people's boxes.
- 4.78 What's Wittgenstein's point here? He says that what this shows is that there can be no private language. You can't come up with a private language. You might think you can, but language is intrinsically social. It's public. It's shared. The only point in uttering the sound, beetle, is if at least one other person in the world knows what you're talking about. And Wittgenstein goes on to say that this is how we should be understanding mental language, terms referring to our consciousness and to our so-called inner life.

- 4.79 So, for example, if the word pain refer just to a private inner sensation accessible only to you, then Wittgenstein says you'd be in the same position as the person with the beetle in the box. No one could check whether you're using the word pain correctly. Who's going to check? Who, except you, has private, privileged access to whether you're in pain or not? Everyone would mean something different by the word pain.
- 4.80 Just as in the beetle scenario, the beetle in the box scenario, everybody would mean something different by the word beetle. The word wouldn't mean anything. It would just be a sound. It would have no reference. The word couldn't have a stable public meaning, and so the word pain ceases to have any application at all. But the word pain does have application. We do know what we're talking about, says Wittgenstein.
- 4.81 So it's not some inner mental state. It's something that is part of our public exterior behavior and understanding. The language we use about the mind has to be public. It's always got to appeal to observable public criteria. Otherwise, we simply wouldn't even be able to have a conversation about it. This is the idea. That's behaviorism. We've seen it through Gilbert Ryle and we've seen it through Wittgenstein. What are we to make of it? What are some criticisms? How would we evaluate it?
- 4.82 Well, it does lead to some problems. I mean, I made that joke earlier about the behaviorist and his wife, but that does touch on something true. I mean, Hilary Putnam, for example, one of the great American philosophers of the latter half of the 20th century, makes the so-called, the objection from Super-Spartans. He asks us to imagine a group of Super-Spartans who were even harder and more ruthless and more implacably opposed to showing any pain or emotion than the original Spartans.
- 4.83 And Putnam says that you can imagine a society of Super-Spartans that can feel pain, but have been trained from the age of three to show no pain behavior. Because that would be weak; it wouldn't be Super-Spartan. What is the behaviorist going to say in such a situation? Is he going to say that Super-Spartans don't feel pain? That seems implausible, because the reason we admire, would admire a society of Super-Spartans is precisely that they do feel pain and yet show extraordinary courage and resilience in enduring the pain.
- 4.84 Do we think such a society would have cured pain, gotten rid of pain? But on the behaviorist view, that's exactly what would have happened, that it follows from behaviorism that the Super-Spartans have found a solution to all pain and suffering. That doesn't seem right. It seems implausible.
- 4.85 Another objection is the perfect actor problem. You could imagine somebody exhibiting all the behaviors that we would classify as publicly available criteria for grief, for grief, while actually feeling joy internally, that is to say, a feigned behavior, and therefore, the challenge for the behaviorist is to say, "On what grounds can you distinguish, in that completely plausible scenario, between the behavior and the actual belief or feeling or conviction that this perfect actor has?"

- 4.86 It seems very puzzling. I watched an interesting interview last night, in fact, with a couple of actors who were describing how difficult it was to perform evil on screen. I think the first example was Anthony Hopkins in *The Silence of Lambs*, 1992, 1993. The second example, I think, was a year later with the young Ralph Fiennes, the English actor, playing the terrifying Amon Göth in Steven Spielberg's *Schindler's List*. It's fascinating, the different ways they went about it.
- 4.87 But what Ralph Fiennes did is, he immersed himself completely through the old method acting in National Socialist literature, and he tried to live and think and imagine in the way— it must have been a terrifying few months—that this awful camp commandant lived. His behavior, the way he acted, was quite extraordinary. He captured the evil in a remarkable way because he got all the behaviors exactly right. What are we to make of that? Again, there we have an actor engaging in completely feigned behaviors. But there's no principled way for the behaviorist to be able to distinguish between the outer life of Ralph Fiennes when he's acting and of Ralph Fiennes when he isn't.
- 4.88 Other problems would involve thinking about how beliefs and desires in our minds interact with the physical world, how it is that we cause things in the world. Behaviorism looks, really, at the end product, as it were, the outcome of what we used to think were our decisions and beliefs and intentions. But that makes very little sense, because a disposition to act in a particular way doesn't cause other dispositions to act in particular ways.
- 4.89 We're not just passive. We're not just passive products or effects of external conditioning that triggers our different dispositions. We actually have, to a large degree, control over the world. We can initiate action. We can activate our own dispositions. What's doing that activating? The answer, against the behaviorist, is the self. There's some agency with freedom, or at least a measure of freedom, and so on and so forth. There are lots of other issues that we could raise against behaviorism.
- 4.90 Noam Chomsky—let's finish with this one. Chomsky develops—it's not uncontested, but he develops this very plausible idea that human beings are born with an aptitude for grammar, for language. A child born in Illinois and a child born in Papua New Guinea, as human beings, are born with a certain capacity for language, capacity for grammar.
- 4.91 What that means is that you've effectively got examples of children picking up ways of talking, ways of speaking, ways of describing the world, which suggests that they have really got some innate cognitive patterns, innate patterns for language use and for understanding language, and that we shouldn't understand them just in terms of their behavioral patterns.
- 4.92 That brings us to the end of the first of the three attempts to lock in materialism, to lock in the idea that the mind-body problem is over, because we've shown that there is,

in fact, no mind. We'll move on to the second and third strategies in lecture five. Thank you for listening.

Lecture 5: Reducing the Mind

At a glance — Reducing the mind — reductive and physicalist attempts to explain consciousness.

- 5.1 Welcome to the fifth lecture, lecture five, in Introduction to Philosophy of Mind. In the last lecture, towards the end of the last lecture, we were looking at one of the three great strategies in 20th-century philosophy of mind to dissolve the problem, you might say, rather than solve the problem, of mind and body, and to dissolve the problem of mind and body by dissolving mind and asserting the primacy of matter and of brain and of physics and the scientific, as, really, the benchmark for what counts as real, and trying to chase away what Gilbert Ryle called the ghost in the machine.
- 5.2 I now want to turn from behaviorism to a second strategy. This is simply called, quite crudely, the mind-brain identity thesis, or the mind-brain identity theory, MBIT, which really emerges in the early 1950s with Feigl, but also, in particular, a brilliant Australian philosopher called Jack Smart, J. J. C. Smart, who wrote a famous article in 1959, *Sensations and Brain Processes*.
- 5.3 Smart's argument was that we shouldn't think of mind and body as being two distinct things that we then need to work out how they're connected and how they're related to each other. There is no question of how they are related to each other because they are each other. They're identical. Mental states are brain states. They're not something that's hovering above brain states that we need to try to explain in some way by appealing to behavior or whatever it might be.
- 5.4 When I feel pain, to say that I feel pain, my whole sensation of feeling pain, is C-fibers firing within my body, which is typically the thought to be the neurological correlate or basis for the sensation of pain in human beings. That's all it is. In a way, this seems a very drastic, radical solution to the mind-body problem. Just get rid of mind, or rather, don't get rid of it; just say it is the brain. There is such a thing as the mind: it's the brain. It really is the gray gooey yogurt.
- 5.5 This theory is probably not, and is certainly not a dominant view these days. It's seen as a little bit dated, but it still sees some attempts to defend it, because it doesn't really offer any explanation, even in the way that the behaviorist does. There must be something slightly different that we're talking about when we're talking about mental states.
- 5.6 Even though the behaviorist identifies it with physical behavior or the disposition to behave in particular ways, there's still a sense that the behaviorists are taking mental life seriously. They're taking the idea that there is something to mental state seriously. Whereas with the identity theorists, it's this collapsing of all of those questions into this identity thesis.

- 5.7** There are various problems with it. The first is this question of pain and what's happening when I'm feeling pain, I'm in a state of feeling pain, and it's me that's feeling it, nobody else. Only I can know what it's like to feel the pain that is my pain. I can describe it for others, but I will never be able to describe it in such a perfect way that they experience the pain as I feel it. That is simply not possible, because they're not me. They can't know what it's like. They'd know, if I could somehow hit them on the head with a hammer, then yes, they would know what it's like for them to feel the pain, but it would be their pain, their subjective pain, not mine.
- 5.8** One of the issues here is that it seems as if many things experience pain. We know that the octopus feels pain. What we want to say, if it was the case that mental states, including pain states, were identical to the brain states in our skull, in the gray gooey yogurt, then we should be surprised when we find that there's evidence that other beings feel pain that have a completely different material basis, as is the case with the octopus. The octopus has a completely different neural system, totally different, very interesting and complex neural systems, but not the same neural systems that we do, and certainly not the same stuff.
- 5.9** Similarly, we could imagine a Martian coming down, some extraterrestrial being from outer space coming down and responding in ways that we can associate as feeling pain and experiencing feelings, negative feelings, when struck with something or when hit with something. We can say, well, there's no reason to doubt that that entity, that other living thing, is feeling pain, maybe expressing it in a different way. But here we've got a completely different being, with a totally different material, neural, a neural substrate.
- 5.10** And so, the idea that there is a specific mental state that can be correlated or identified with a specific physical state seems very puzzling. It seems as if you could come up with almost any physical state, whether it's the material that makes up an octopus or the material that makes up our brains and so on and so forth, or maybe the silicon that makes up a zombie brain, a Martian brain.
- 5.11** We're not going to say that, therefore, if this is identical to feeling pain, how can you have completely different things, completely different material states, that are identical to pain? Because these are different things. If A equals B, and there's a claim that B is somewhere else, then let's have a think. Let's say, for example, in the case of human beings, A equals B. Mental states equals human brain states, human brain states, human brain neural networks.
- 5.12** Then we say, of the octopus, well, we've got the pain, the mental state, A, but we've got C, A equals C. Well, no, because we've just claimed that A equals B, so if A equals C, B equals C, too. That doesn't work. Because if A is identical to B, then what we're talking about with respect to the octopus has to be the same as what we're talking about with respect to the human beings. But the claim of the human beings is that the pain states are identical with the underlying brain states.

- 5.13** And so we're forced to conclude that the octopus doesn't feel any pain at all. It's not something we can recognize as pain, because we've already identified pain with specific human brain states. That's one, probably the biggest problem, the problem that pain has multiple realizations, so it's hard to see how it could be identical to any particular specific brain states.
- 5.14** We can move now on to the third great strategy, and this has been much more influential than the mind-body identity theory, mind-brain identity theory. This strategy is called, typically, functionalism. Functionalism. This really gets going in the 1960s, reaches a peak in the 1970s, and it goes hand in hand, as questions in the philosophy of mind often do, with the rise of particular forms of technology, and in particular, in the late '60s and '70s, of course, the rise of the computer.
- 5.15** The speed at which computational science develops in the post-war period, but accelerating in the late '60s and '70s, the dominance of that, again, remember how influential science is within popular culture, and science is the benchmark for what counts as real and true. It was perhaps to be expected that the computer, which does have these vast computational powers, in the same way that human beings have computational powers, that the analogy was almost too tempting to overlook.
- 5.16** Sure enough, particularly the distinction between software and hardware starts to become an analogy that is just too tempting to pass up, when it comes to thinking about the relationship between mind and body. It's very simple, as we've got the hardware—the body— and then we've got the software—the mind, consciousness, intentions, beliefs, and so on and so forth.
- 5.17** Therefore, the way to understand mental states in a mental life is on an analogy with computational states. What is it that defines a computer's state or a computer's output? Well, really, just the outputs and the inputs and the transitions, that's all that is going on with the computer. Now, it's actually quite simple, even though, of course, it can get very, very complex. The basic principles are straightforward.
- 5.18** The idea is that the mind is software running on the hardware of the brain. One way to think about this might be in terms of a thermostat. The input with a thermostat is what? It's temperature detection. It can detect temperature. The internal state is on or off. That's basically it. It's either on or it's off. The output is the heating system being activated when the input is such that the temperature is too low, and we want the heating to be activated.
- 5.19** The point here is that the mental state, the thermostat's, as it were, mental state, is defined not by what's going on inside it, but by what it does, by its function. The thermostat's state, what it is, is how it converts inputs into outputs. Temperature coming too low—boom, heating switch on. That's input and output. You can see how it's similar to behaviorism in some ways. It certainly takes its cue from behaviorism, but

just as a computer follows particular rules and programming, it's got an on/off switch, external stimulus, switch activated, and then output heating system on.

- 5.20** This is how to understand sensations or mental states for the functionalist. So, pain would be just a functional state on this view. There's an input: I cut myself with a knife in the kitchen. Then what does it cause? It causes me to scream. It causes me to run to the sink and clean the wound and dry it and get a plaster on, and all of these different outputs, to form certain beliefs about why I was a stupid idiot and I should never play with knives like that again.
- 5.21** But that's all that's going on. There's no inner process of deliberation. It's just input, then output. That's how we should understand conscious states, mental states. And this has had a lot of influence, particularly in the 1970s, and it's got less of a hold now, but it's got certain attractions, this view. It provides an analogy that is at least consistent or at least compatible with the natural sciences. It's given us a good scientific model in the computer, as it were, to understand how to think about mental states in a materialistically acceptable way, in a scientifically respectable way.
- 5.22** It also explains the puzzle of mental causation. How is that particular mental states lead us to act in particular ways? The answer is that, simply, there are outputs that are triggered by certain inputs. There's no mystery about a ghost in the machine directing the machine or a Platonic soul in the body directing the body. It's that there are inputs and then there are outputs, and the mental state is what converts them. It's just what it does. That's its function.
- 5.23** Now, there are a lot of issues that we could touch on with functionalism. I think probably the main worry is that it seems implausible to think that the definition of a mind, the way to understand mind or consciousness, is only in terms of functional organization. One philosopher has advanced an objection that's sometimes called "the China brain." I think he's at NYU, the philosopher Ned Block, the American philosopher of mind, and he comes up with this idea of China brain.
- 5.24** He said, just imagine that all the citizens of China were directed by President Xi on their apps, which they have to listen to in the morning, to download Xi's thought. Just imagine that all Chinese citizens had got the right instructions and all were perfectly compliant with those instructions. You could imagine an incredibly well-organized, functional arrangement of millions and millions and millions of Chinese, operating in an agreed way.
- 5.25** But Block says, we couldn't therefore say we've solved that China brain, China block, is conscious or can feel pain or has certain subjective perspectives on the world. We wouldn't say that. It's got to be, says Block, it must be the case that having a mind is something more than just having a functionally organized system.
- 5.26** You might also say that you could imagine a kind of functional duplicate, something that could perform the role that I perform, what I do, what happens when I cut myself

with a knife in the kitchen. You can just say that all of the states of pain that I'm in can be described by what I do when that happens to me.

- 5.27** But you could also imagine, as it were, a duplicate of me. There is a duplicate in all respects, except— is a duplicate in all respects, but that would completely lack my memories and my inner life, my whole history and life story, and that wouldn't really undergo any experiences at all, but just would correctly output whatever inputs would be outputted in the way that I do, in exactly the same way.
- 5.28** You could have something, a being like me, basically a duplicate and functionally identical, that behaves in exactly the way that I would do, generates exactly the same outputs as I do, given the same set of inputs, and still not know what it's like to be me, still not have any grasp of what it's like to be me, because that functional duplicate would not be me, even though it was identical to me in all of the ways, in all the ways it responded to particular inputs.
- 5.29** We've looked at these three attempts to push for the mind to be displaced in favor of the brain and in favor of matter, in favor of something that seems more transparent to scientific inquiry. We can really call all of these three attempts forms of materialism when it comes to the mind-body problem. But increasingly, and I think revealingly, the language and the label that's been given to these kinds of strategies has shifted over time.
- 5.30** It used to be, in the '50s and '60s, we talked about these theories as materialist theories, that is to say, theories that try to come up with answers and frameworks that only appeal to matter, to stuff. But more recently, in the '70s and particularly in the '80s, the language of materialism starts to fade, and it starts to be replaced by another word, and that word is physicalism. Physicalism.
- 5.31** There are all sorts of interesting things you might say as to why they decided to drop that word and come up with another one. I think it's partly because materialist theories were not delivering the goods in terms of explanation and philosophical success, but also because matter was becoming increasingly mysterious to us in the postwar period. The more we looked into matter, the more mysterious— the more we look into matter, the more mysterious it becomes, the more enigmatic it becomes, the less material it becomes.
- 5.32** Once we get into the subatomic world, it's not at all clear that what we're looking at here is stuff. There's a lot of air. There's a lot of stuff in between the different particles and so on in the subatomic world. That's part of what's going on here. Also, the sense of physics itself is expanding to cover all sorts of weird and wonderful things that we did not think would be the case even 100 years ago in physics.
- 5.33** But we can describe the basic strategy, the successors to the materialists, as physicalists. The basic view here is that whatever's going on when we're talking about mind is ultimately to be understood within the parameters of physics. It may not be an

entirely material answer, materialistic answer, but it is an answer that is going to be consistent with physics.

- 5.34** You might say that that's a concession, or at least to try to attempt to hedge the bets over precisely what does cover is included in physics. Because as we know from the theory of relativity and also the emerging field of quantum mechanics, physics is—the domain of physics, we are now forced to accept, includes, quite possibly, the subjective perspective.
- 5.35** This is really what's going on with all the worries about quantum indeterminacy, this extraordinary mystery that somehow a non-objective perspective— all perspectives are non-objective, that is to say, to have a perspective is for at least one subject to have a perspective on, say, the mass of a particle— that perspective will entail not knowing anything about the velocity of the particle and vice versa.
- 5.36** So, it does seem that this radical indeterminacy and perceiver-dependent physics, that seems to overturn things completely. We'll say more about that in subsequent lectures. For now, though, I just want to comment on the rise of objections to and criticisms of different physicalist strategies in contemporary philosophy of mind from, let's say, roughly the 1980s onwards.
- 5.37** The first argument is advanced by a guy called Frank Jackson, very distinguished American philosopher. Jackson asks us to imagine a scenario in which a brilliant young scientist called Mary has been trained from an early age and brought up from an early age in a laboratory. She's got a nice little house next to the laboratory, but it's all inside this big bunker, and there's no color in the bunker. It's just gray, blacks, whites, maybe a bit of cream occasionally. But that's it. There are no colors in Mary's world.
- 5.38** But she's trained from an early age to study everything there is to know about what's going on in the human brain and the human body when colors are experienced, and in particular, the color red. She knows everything there is to know. She has the complete neuroscience available to her, at her fingertips. Anything there is to be known about neuroscience, Mary knows. There's nothing she doesn't know.
- 5.39** There are no facts about what's happening when we see, when human beings see the color red. There's no facts that she doesn't know. She's memorized all the textbooks. She knows everything there is to know. There are no more facts for Mary to learn in neuroscience, or in any science relevant to understanding the physiology or the neurology or neurophysiology of the human being when it experiences the color red.
- 5.40** Then one happy day, the doors of the laboratory are thrown open, and Mary is led out into a field of roses. She sees the field of roses, she smells the roses, and she sees the reds, the extraordinary, all the different reds and different hues, reddish hues, of all the different roses. Question: Does Mary learn something new? Does Mary undergo an experience in which she acquires new knowledge about the world, namely what the color red looks like, actually looks like?

- 5.41 Remember, she knows everything there is to know about what's going on and anything that would be available to anybody wanting to read and discover what's going on when we look at the color red. What Jackson's argument is Jackson's argument is to say that the intuitions that we feel there is that Mary really is acquiring some new conscious state or perception of the way the world is. She really learns something new. She learns new facts, namely what the color red looks like.
- 5.42 She can now distinguish between a red apple and a green apple. Very plausibly, she couldn't do that before, even though she knew everything that was going on when a person was trying to tell the difference between red and green. But she didn't know how to do that; she still didn't know how to do that. This is an intuition pump. This is what philosophers often do. They come up with ideas, which are thought experiments, that will pump intuitions out for us and clarify how we might think about a problem.
- 5.43 The claim here is simply that if you do think that she's learned something new, then what you're conceding is that Mary learns non-physical facts about the world, namely, what it's like for her, Mary, to see the color red, not just to read about it, to read about what happens, but to see it, to know it, and to be able to distinguish it from other colors, and so on and so forth. She acquires a whole set of new capacities which she couldn't have had before. That's the intuition.
- 5.44 Physicalism must be false, because the scenario sets it up so that Mary knows all physics, all the relevant physics, all the relevant science. But if your intuition is that she really does learn new facts, then there are facts that are not physical facts about what's happening in Mary, within Mary, as she sees, as she stares at roses.
- 5.45 Another famous argument that's developed is by David Chalmers. He's Australian, originally an Australian philosopher. He wrote a very famous book in 1996, *The Conscious Mind*, it's called simply. We'll talk a little bit more about Chalmers in subsequent lectures. But, really, this book was quite controversial when it came out, but it was so well written, it was so clear, so elegantly argued, that it became a minor classic quite quickly, and it marked the beginning of something like a return of dualism.
- 5.46 It was a critique of physicalism, and it looked as if, and it still, actually, really did begin a modern revolution or renaissance in dualist ways of thinking, still ways of thinking that try to make dualism compatible and consistent with physicalism. But it's this book by Chalmers that is the watershed moment.
- 5.47 One of the most famous sections in that book is Chalmers's argument for dualism, or rather against physicalism, from zombies, the so-called zombie argument. What is the zombie argument? Well, what Chalmers asks us to imagine is, first of all, that zombies, at least philosopher zombies, philosophical zombies, are beings, let's say, that are physically identical, identical in all physical respects, to conscious human beings. Every single cell is replicated in these zombies.

- 5.48 But you could imagine such a zombie, although it was a perfect physical duplicate of a human being, lacking any inner life or any subjective experience. It's possible to imagine that. In fact, most zombie films and zombie movies—they're not my kind of thing, but I know they're popular—that's the power of them. They look like you, they look like us, but there's nothing there. There's nothing within, certainly nothing within that we can access or penetrate. It's perfectly possible for us to imagine that there's just no subjective experience there at all.
- 5.49 Why is that significant? Why is it significant that we can imagine this? What Chalmers argues is, really, what Descartes argued 400 years before, namely, that conceivability implies possibility. If you can conceive of something being true, it's possible that something is true. Remember what Descartes says? He says, "I can't conceive of stuff not being stuff." I can't conceive of stuff not being extended in time, extended in space. But I can conceive of my mind just floating away from my body. Even if that's not scientifically possible, I can conceive of it.
- 5.50 And so, Descartes says that's a good guide to what's metaphysically possible. The reason we know that we can say, even though we can't inspect all of reality, the reason we can say that there are no square triangles is that we understand what a square is and we understand what a triangle is. If we could even conceive that it'd be very, very unlikely for there to be a square triangle, but there might be one out of a million, million, million, million possible worlds in which there is, just a very strange world—No, no, there isn't. We know there isn't.
- 5.51 But Descartes says there's definitely some possible world, all kinds of possible worlds. The very fact that there are stories and there's science fiction implies that the mind could indeed be—it is possible, conceivable, it's possible for the mind to be distinct. And so Chalmers's argument is that it's perfectly possible for us to imagine zombies that are perfect physical, physiological, biological duplicates of human beings, yet they have no inner life at all, no subjective experience at all, no consciousness, no beliefs, no intentions, nothing.
- 5.52 They're zombies, after all. Chalmers's point here is that, therefore, we can totally imagine that mindedness and subjective experience is separable from, is distinct from, physicality, the body. We could imagine there being zombies that have no mind but complete matter. And therefore, remember what the identity people claim is? A equals B, mind equals brain. The two are totally inseparable. If A is equal to B, the claim is, A is equal to B in all possible worlds. There's no possible world in which those two are not identical.
- 5.53 And so what this suggests is that, because it's conceivable that consciousness is separate from the underlying body and physiological structures of human beings, that means that it's possible that it is, that there's no logically necessary connection between mind and body in the way that the physicalists insist is the case. And Chalmers

goes on to say, coins this famous phrase, "The hard problem of consciousness." The hard problem of consciousness.

- 5.54** He says there are easy problems when it comes to thinking about consciousness in the mind, when we're thinking about cognitive functions, behavioral dispositions, computation, informational processing, all of those questions. That's something that neuroscience can help us with, says Chalmers.
- 5.55** But the hard problem, the hard problem for philosophy is, it's the same old problem: How can there be any subjective experiences at all? How can that be possible in a world that we can only understand, at least through objective terms, when it comes to, if science is our only prism? There is something that it is like to be you. There is something that it is like to be me, which is incommunicable. So, this was an important moment in the resistance to physicalism.
- 5.56** Another objection worth pointing to is developed by the great philosopher Levine, I think it's Joseph Levine, who talks about the explanatory gap. The idea here is that, supposing we could find, we accepted the identity theorist or the functionalist view, suppose we could actually find exactly those brain states that connected to wanting to go for an ice cream or deciding to propose to somebody or whatever it might be or to go on a trip, suppose we could find those and suppose it was accepted that those were indeed the neural states that were being activated when those beliefs were happening, so, granting everything the identity theorist insists on, Levine says it would still be an explanatory gap. It would still be possible to ask, "But then why does that neural state give rise to wanting to go and buy an ice cream?" There's no solution here yet.
- 5.57** All we're being told is that there's this brain state and there's this mental state, and the two are connected. We're saying, let's suppose for the sake of argument that you've correctly identified the correct brain state that's correlated to the correct mental state and that they are linked in some way. That's granting a lot, but OK, let's concede all that, for the sake of argument. Why? Why that brain state with that mental state? Why that particular connection when it could so easily have been any other?
- 5.58** How do we understand the relationship between these two? Is it a law of nature? It can't be a law of physics. Mental state and the neural state and the brain state, is it physics that connects them? Well, the physicalist is going to say, yes, it's some law of nature, some psycho-physical law. But there's still, says Levine, there's still a gap. This doesn't tell us how you can jump from this neuroscientific entity to wanting to go and get an ice cream, and wondering which ice cream it's going to be, and so on and so forth.
- 5.59** Now, physicalists have developed responses to these objections. I don't want to say they haven't got objections. On the Mary thought experiment, the standard line, I think it's quite an attractive counter-objection, the view is that what Mary acquires when she leaves the lab and walks into the field of roses is not new knowledge, in the sense of

learning new facts. The claim that the physicalists have come back with is, "No, Mary just acquires certain abilities. She acquires a certain ability, a set of abilities—an ability, for example, to tell the difference between red and green, which she didn't really have before."

- 5.60** You might say, there's a big debate among philosophers about whether there's a difference between knowing that and knowing how. You could have read all bicycle manuals ever written in every language. That is to say, you have complete propositional knowledge of how to ride a bike. There's nothing that's ever been written or said about how to ride a bike that you haven't learned, digested, and memorized.
- 5.61** But put you on a bike, and what's going to happen? Well, you might do a little bit better than some, but you'll probably fall off a few times, and then you'll have to— some philosophers want to say, there's a kind of knowledge you still don't have. It's a different kind of knowledge, but we're still happy to use the word knowledge. We're thinking yet, "Do you know how to ride a bike?" "Yes, I know how to ride a bike. I know how to do it." It's a knowledge, the kind of knowledge that I have.
- 5.62** "OK, but what facts did you learn in order to learn how to ride a bike?" "Well, I didn't learn any. I mean, I learned that there's this metal object, and there are these two wheels, and I've got it that it's going to be difficult, but my dad's going to put me on it, send me down the path, see how I do." So there's a very interesting debate as to whether or not this is a kind of knowledge, this is a kind of way of knowing the world, knowing how as well as knowing that.
- 5.63** If you do accept that knowing how is a kind of knowledge, then perhaps you could say that there's a response for the physicalist to the Mary thought experiment, that Mary is acquiring knowledge. She learned something new. It wasn't available to her before, but it's a knowing how rather than a knowing that. That's the response.
- 5.64** My thought on that is: Why is it that she has the ability? How has she now acquired the ability to tell the difference between green and red? The ability hasn't arrived like magic. My counter-response to the counter-objection is to say that the only reason Mary has that ability is because she now knows what red looks like. That's why she's got the knowing how. She's acquired knowledge of what red looks like, what it feels like, what it's like, and she will always spot it ever after.
- 5.65** Only because she has acquired that knowledge, can we say that is it possible for her to have all the abilities that arise from having that knowledge, like telling the difference between a red apple and a green apple, or being able to drive a car and tell the difference between a red traffic light and a green traffic light, which, again, I think she couldn't do before.
- 5.66** So she has the ability, yes, and that's know-how. Let's accept that that is a kind of knowledge. But it's only there, because she's acquired non-know-how knowledge, qualitative knowledge, experiential knowledge, of what red actually looks like, before

she exercises any abilities. It's not just the acquiring of the abilities, she acquires the abilities because she learns something new about the world.

- 5.67** Then there are various responses that physicalists have brought forward, particularly around this question of conceivability and whether conceivability implies possibility. Again, that's quite a technical debate within philosophy more generally. The strategy against the zombie argument has been to say that the fact that you can conceive philosopher zombies that are perfect physical duplicates of human beings, that you also conceive not to have any inner life or any consciousness at all, doesn't mean that such a being is possible.
- 5.68** Now, I just say, it plainly is. If something is conceivable, it is possible. Just as if something is inconceivable, we say that it's impossible. I think the best way of thinking about this is that we cannot conceive of a square triangle. We can hear the words, but we can't form the thought. Why? Because it's an impossible one. We know that there's no possible worlds in which such a thing exists.
- 5.69** Flip that round. Can I imagine a zombie that I can't tell if it's a human being or not, with no inner life? Of course I can. There'd be a whole cottage industry of horror movies and Netflix series that would collapse if we were not able to conceive that as possible and be entertained by it. Other strategies that the physicalists have brought to bear is, especially, this is the physics, really, that is doing the talking. This is the great Korean philosopher of mind, Jaegwon Kim.
- 5.70** His worry is that, really, physics is closed as a domain. It's closed and sealed within space-time, and it's causally closed. That is to say, there's nothing non-physical that can cause physical events. This is the doctrine and the dogma of physicalism. You can give that up, says Kim. But if you give it up, you're giving up physicalism, and you're letting in spooky stuff through the door that may or may not be scientific, et cetera, et cetera. We can't have that.
- 5.71** For every physical effect, Kim says, we can find an adequate and sufficient physical cause. If then, on top of that, we say that there's also mental causes here, there's also minds directing this process, Kim says that is over-determination. There's too much explanation. In philosophy, we want only the lean explanations. If we can already explain a physical event by a physical cause, why do we then need to appeal on top to some controversial mental cause, non-physical cause? We should just leave that to one side. We need to keep the causal closure of the physical to purely causal explanations.
- 5.72** What do we make of that? I mean, in a way, that's not really an argument. It's just a restatement of the worldview of the philosophical outlook that physicalism insists on. It would be a little bit like saying to an atheist objecting to some feature of the world, of a theistic universe, the atheist saying simply, "Yes, but this isn't possible because there is no God. God doesn't exist." And so, any explanation that you come up with has to be consistent with there not being any theistic source of agency.

- 5.73** Now, that may or may not be true. So maybe the atheist is right, maybe the theist is right. But in the argument, it's not enough for somebody in the middle of the argument to stand up and say, "Hold on, can I restate my position, my overall position? And can I point out that the way this argument is going is not consistent with my set of assumptions? Stop."
- 5.74** I sometimes think this is what people like Jaegwon Kim are doing. They're saying, "Hold on, remember that we physicalists believe that causation is closed to anything other than physical impacts, physical inputs, physical causes." Now, again, maybe that's correct, maybe that's true, maybe it's not. But you've got to argue for it. You can't just stipulate it.
- 5.75** It's not going to convince the dualist, because the dualist is going to say, "But I just deny that." I simply deny that only physical causes bring about physical effects. I'm denying that as I'm speaking to you now. I'm denying that as I'm speaking to you now, because I am a subject with certain beliefs, certain intentions, certain ways of understanding philosophy, certain ways of following through different arguments. I'm talking to you now. It's not a rock that's talking to you. It's not an object that's talking to you. It's not any animal that's talking to you. It's a subject.
- 5.76** Deep down, you believe that, too. If you don't, if you've got any objection to that, then what I'm doing is, I'm simply restating my outlook on the world. I'm simply restating my view that, just as you can't understand there being any physical effects flowing from non-physical causes, I, the dualist, cannot make any sense of the idea that what we're doing now is having a conversation between two subjects, that entertain two irreducibly subjective conscious perspectives on the world.
- 5.77** If you try to—any skeptical argument you bring against me, I can simply say, "Sorry, this doesn't cohere with my understanding of how the world works, and sorry." That is basically what Kim does in restating this principle of the causal closure of the physical, the causal exclusion problem. It's really an outworking, if you like, of the physicalist dogma. It's not an objection in and of itself.
- 5.78** So, what we've looked at in this lecture, really, it's been a sequel to the previous lecture in as much as we've been laying out the contemporary strategies for a materialist or physicalist skepticism towards the idea that we are conscious beings, that we have an inner life, that we have beliefs, reasons for acting that are not completely reducible to, or identifiable with, neural states, physical states in the world. We'll continue in the next lecture to look at one or two other recent attempts to do the same.
- 5.79** But at that point, I want to move on to what I've described earlier as the revival of forms of dualism, very tentative forms of dualism, in recent years, partly led by David Chalmers, but by others as well. We'll start to see that mind, having been buried by its undertakers in the course of the 20th century, is coming back in through the back door

and threatening to bury its undertakers. We'll see how that develops over the course of lecture six. Thank you for listening.

- 5.80** My question is, Dr. Orr, is there a philosophical argument to be made for the dualistic religious or religious presupposition of the unification of the souls between man and woman in marriage?
- 5.81** It's a very good thought. In Plato's Symposium, Aristophanes has this famous humorous speech about how men and women come back, as it were, when in marriage are united, they're two parts separated at the dawn of time and that they find their way back together again. That idea comes up an awful lot. You do have these big questions about, if there is an absolute global Big Daddy mind, whether it's in a Hegelian way, or whether it's British idealism, or whether it's Anaxagoras, how is it that we can explain individual minds?
- 5.82** Isn't it to have a mind or to have a center of subjectivity to be completely unified and to have one perspective? We saw this with the Chinese block, the Chinese brain objection. You could have perfect functional organization across many, many, more than one-minded being; and yet, do we really want to say that that collection of minds is itself a mind, taken together? We'll come on to look at why this might be a problem here.
- 5.83** So, in the theological context of the sacrament of marriage, I think what that's seen as is a union. It's a form of union, but it is not a relationship of identity, you might say. In something like the way you might think of the Trinity. There is a union, but not identity. The Father is not the Son, the Son is not the Spirit, etc. But the Father is God, the Son is God, the second person of the Trinity is God, the third person of the Trinity is God.
- 5.84** You might say the husband is a constitutive ingredient in that sacrament. The wife is a constitutive ingredient in that sacrament. Without the husband, no sacrament; without the wife, no sacrament. But the two are distinct, nevertheless distinct. There are lots of interesting debates in philosophy as to whether or not there are group agencies, so whether you could say that a married couple has an agency that can't be explained in terms of their constituent members.
- 5.85** I can make sense of that. You might say that a club in London, one of the gentlemen's clubs in London, that means something slightly different in America. The gentlemen's club in London does not mean a gentleman's club in Arizona. But in these clubs, you have to apply for membership and be very strict. If there's one person who doesn't like you, drops the black ball, you're done. Most clubs operate like that.
- 5.86** You could imagine a scenario where you apply for membership of one club, and 25 people want you, but one person doesn't. The decision of the club is to refuse your membership. It acts in a particular way that can't be understood totally in terms of the individuals concerned. There's an institutional fact about the decision of the agency.

- 5.87** Now, the question is: Can we make sense of that in the same way that we make sense of individual agency? Maybe, maybe. We'd have to look at the rules and the procedures for the club, which they're being conformed to and so on. But it's a difficult question. But I'm inclined to think that there can be no shared consciousness. Consciousness is something that is uniquely unified and subjective. I can never know, in the way that you do, what it's like to be you, because I'm not you.
- 5.88** There are lots of thought experiments that you could go and think of. Well, maybe if you could divide, split your brain—the split-brain hypothesis. If you, number 2, went off around the world for 5, 10 years, and you came back together and you had a game of tennis, are you having a game of tennis with yourself? Would you think that that's yourself?
- 5.89** No, you'd think it's, I don't know where he's been for 10 years. I don't know where he has been. I don't know where I have been for 10 years, or whatever. It's very difficult to wrap our heads, or to even conceive of there being a second "I." Because what it is to be an "I" is for there not to be any other "I's". And so that would probably apply to the marriage question.
- 5.90** In regards to pain, if there was a scenario where there was a numbing cream, and I numb my arm and I'm getting pinched, I can see that I'm getting pinched, so therefore I can see that and I know that. If there was a scenario where I was not aware of that, I cannot see it, it was blind to me, to touch, sense, but it was still happening, how does that attract to our world in reality, and things that we are unaware of but are still happening around us?
- 5.91** Great. Good question. I think the reason that I use the pain example, and the way that it's an example that is very commonly used, is that it's very hard to make sense of the idea that, when we're experiencing pain, we are experiencing, first of all, an illusion—if you're feeling pain, you're feeling pain. Even if there's some kind of weird hallucination that is making you think that is causing you pain or is convincing you that you're in a scenario where you're feeling pain, it's veridical. It's basic, it's direct.
- 5.92** Think of phantom limb syndrome. It's this horrible idea that you can, people can still feel some itch, for example, on a missing limb. That person, I would argue, is feeling pain, is in a state of pain. There can be no—the thing about feeling pain is that it's neither true nor false. It just is what it is. Even if it's completely direct and it's completely immediate and it's completely qualitatively experiential, it's not something—you could try to put it into words. It's like this, or it's like that.
- 5.93** But no complete description of what's going on when you're feeling that pain can make somebody else have that pain. It is not possible to feel your pain, ever, because it's yours, not anybody else's. In that scenario, it's a matter of fact whether or not somebody has pinched you, whether or not you've got numbing cream, or so on. It's a further fact whether or not you have felt the pain. It could be that nobody's pinched

you, but you're convinced that somebody did, and you can even feel the pain from the imaginary pinching. It's perfectly imaginable.

- 5.94 Indeed, you've got people with all kinds of psychiatric conditions who insist and clearly believe that somebody's out to get them and that somebody caused them pain last night or whatever. That pain is that pain. It's real, whether or not it was falsely induced or induced through hallucination, even if there's no physical contact at all, as in the case of the phantom limb syndrome.
- 5.95 That's why I think pain is a good example because it doesn't involve thoughts, it doesn't involve beliefs, it doesn't involve propositions, but it involves a qualitative state of experience that is real, can't be denied. You might be able to be a Super-Spartan and just grin and bear it, stiff upper lip; nobody can tell that you're in pain. But the behaviorists are wrong that you're not in pain, just because you can behave as if you're not in pain. Plainly, it doesn't make any sense at all. So yeah, it's a good question. Thank you.

Lecture 6: Mind Beyond Matter

At a glance — Mind beyond matter — challenges to reduction and non-physical accounts.

- 6.1** Welcome to lecture six in Introduction to Philosophy of Mind. In the last two lectures, we were examining ingenious attempts to reduce mind to world, mind to matter, mental states to brain states, the first person to the third person. What I noticed and what I drew attention to, as we were canvassing those different options, those different strategies, is that none of them have really managed to win, achieve any consensus within, among philosophers of mind.
- 6.2** There is a drive to naturalizing mind, to try to make it something that is comprehensible within the terms of physics and the sciences. But each of those attempts to do that has met with real difficulties. It's almost as if the more determined these strategies are, the harder it is to avoid the conclusion that the mind and consciousness can't be completely eradicated, that there's something stubborn about this commitment.
- 6.3** It's something very, very difficult; it seems very philosophically challenging to say that there's simply no question, no debate to be had here, that science is the answer to absolutely everything, and in particular, to questions about consciousness, because consciousness isn't, in fact, like something else that we happen to do. It's not like digestion. It's not like sweating. It is something which is absolutely central to what it is to be me or to be you.
- 6.4** It's that without which there can be nothing else. There can be no real internal life, no understanding, full understanding, of what it is to be a person. To deny consciousness is to deny that through which we understand anything at all. It's our consciousness, it's our inner lives, our rational processes, which allow us to navigate the world, to entertain it.
- 6.5** You might say that we could pull off something called a Moorean shift in this debate. The Moorean shift refers to a famous argument advanced by G. E. Moore, who we've come across already. The argument is an argument to do with, a response to people who are skeptical about the existence of an external world. This is Moore's problem, and we talked about it briefly in relation to Wittgenstein a while back.
- 6.6** Moore's response to the person who says, "We might be a skeptic, we might be brains in a vat. For all we know, we do not, in fact, have access to the world as we think we do," is to say this. Let's see, the argument that goes like this. Premise one: Here is my hand. Premise two: Here is my other hand. Conclusion: The external world exists. It's real. What's going on there?
- 6.7** Moore's point is not, "Hey, I've come up with an argument that is going to decisively refute the person who's skeptical that the external world is real." It's not going to

decisively refute the skeptic who thinks that these might not be my hands. The point is rather to shift the burden of proof.

- 6.8** The point is rather to say, "I believe that these are my hands. I declare that they are my hands. I also declare that I believe these hands to be my hands and nobody else's hands and to actually be hands, more firmly than I believe the premises of any clever skeptical argument to the contrary." It doesn't matter how good the argument is. I'm simply—you're never going to convince me, however brilliant the argument might be, you're never going to convince me that these are not my hands.
- 6.9** I know it more fundamentally, and I'm basically immune to being argued out of it. It doesn't mean I don't like philosophy; it doesn't mean I'm not open to argument in other contexts, but there are certain postures and alignments to reality that I hold that I simply can't surrender without everything disintegrating.
- 6.10** Another example here might be a Moorean shift around the freedom debates, freedom versus determinism: Are we simply determined to do everything that we do, because of our heredity and our genes and our environment? Or is it the case that, yes, those might be factors, but in the end, there's an I who can choose freely to, as it were, conform to the patterns that I've inherited or to break them or to revise them, but I can impose myself on the world? And it's me doing it, and I'm free to do it. I'm free to do otherwise.
- 6.11** That means, by the way, that I can be held responsible for the outcome of my actions. I can be praised, I can be blamed, in a way that is coherent. The way would not be coherent if I was just determined to act however I did act. Here, again, often in these debates between people who are committed to free will and people committed to the idea that free will, the existence of free will, would undermine science, and we can't have undermining science, therefore, everything's got to be explicable in scientific terms, including when we're acting, when we think we're free.
- 6.12** But here you might just say again, "I believe that I'm free more firmly than I believe any skeptical argument that says that I'm not, that says that I'm just a robot that's programmed by Darwinian processes. Even if I haven't got an answer to your arguments, life's too short; you're not going to persuade me. You're never going to persuade me of this, because this is just too fundamental."
- 6.13** I sometimes think consciousness is a little bit like this, this idea that we really do have an inner life, that there really is something that it is like for me to feel pain, to be in a state of pain, and that if I behave in a somehow slightly different way, that doesn't just get rid of it. Or if I identify it to some clever neurological entity that I'm told exists, this fires up when I'm feeling pain in my brain. Again, I don't care.
- 6.14** I know more fundamentally that I'm in pain than I know anything about what's going on inside my actual brain or anything about neuroscience, et cetera. It seems as if that Moorean shift is tempting, especially when the philosophical arguments turn out to be

either not that good or too different from each other, different positions, different ways of trying to reduce mind to matter. Simply, there's too many different theories.

- 6.15** Often, in science, when you get a proliferation of lots of different theories about how to explain something, although it's often confused for scientific success and progress, normally it means the theory is in trouble. Normally it means the whole paradigm is about to come apart, is about to blow up. I'm sometimes tempted to think that that's what's going on within the research project to show that mind can be reduced down to matter. Lots and lots of different theories, and that's mistaken for signs of progress.
- 6.16** So they get more grant money, and more people are hired with those views, and so on and so forth. But the more that that's gone on, the more that, without delivering any convincing consensus or explanation of how to reduce mind to matter, the more it's tempting to think that this is the whole paradigm, the whole animating assumption, namely that all truths are scientific truths, everything's got to be understood in material terms, including mind, including mental states, is in trouble. It's faltering.
- 6.17** What is it that makes something conscious? What does it mean? What are we talking about when we say that something might be conscious? What are some scenarios we might consider? Well, first of all, I'd say, you right now are conscious. The fact that you are listening to these words, you're watching me speak, you're understanding at least those parts of it where I'm being clear, you're understanding those bits— you are conscious. Whoever's listening to this and can understand what I'm saying is conscious.
- 6.18** Is a smartphone conscious? That's more problematic. I'd say, obviously not, but there might be. If you're a functionalist, you might say that yes, there's a way in which we can say that a smartphone has mental states. It has certain inputs, it has certain outputs. After all, on the functionalist model of the human mind, if the model is the computer, and then we say, well, that's the way to understand the mind, then if we then turn back to computers, we can say, oh, well, they're just like minds. That's a fairly straightforward thing to do.
- 6.19** Then there are more difficult scenarios. The patient under anesthesia, the person who's sleepwalking, are they conscious? The person who is in a persistent vegetative state might not have any memories, might not have any reasoning or any imagination, but the person is alive, and one wants to say, somehow, perhaps, there's some level of consciousness there, deep down. And so, the question is: How do we make sense of these differences and these distinctions?
- 6.20** Well, we're going to come on to revisit David Chalmers's hard problem shortly. But it's worth putting on the table a distinction that I found quite helpful between what's called access consciousness and phenomenal consciousness, A consciousness and P consciousness. Access consciousness is, think of it as like the CEO of your mind. It's information that gets elevated up to executive control, and there's a functional aspect to this.

- 6.21** So you could say that access consciousness is what we have, what we need for reasoning and decision-making, what we can use to guide behavior. We can access our memories, perhaps. And that's to be distinguished from a much harder problem, a much more difficult kind of consciousness, and that's phenomenal consciousness, or P consciousness. This is the more subjective, qualitative: What is it like to be me?
- 6.22** What is it like to be a bat? To draw on the famous title of an essay by Thomas Nagel, who argues that there is this qualitative perspective on the world that even a bat has, but that we could never possibly inhabit and vice versa. This experiential aspect of consciousness, of P consciousness, phenomenal consciousness, is that Mary sees the redness of the red. She's not just detecting some wavelength, the correct wavelength, that light reaches the retina after it's been refracted off an object that now looks red to us.
- 6.23** No, that's not what we're seeing. We might understand that, but we see the redness. What we feel when we feel the sharp sting of pain, or of a needle, is not just signals to our body because of tissue damage. No, that's not what we're thinking. We think, "Ouch, there's a sharp object here." Or the taste of something, the taste of coffee. Can you imagine the taste of coffee or vanilla ice cream?
- 6.24** Yes, no doubt there is a chemical composition to coffee. There is a chemical composition to vanilla ice cream. There's all kinds of chemicals and sensors that can be analyzed in the human tongue. Again, we could have a complete scientific printout of everything that's going on when we're having a sip of coffee or a scoop of vanilla ice cream.
- 6.25** But the claim is that phenomenal consciousness is not reducible to that. It might illuminate it, it might correlate with it, but it's still something that is distinct. What it's like to taste a cup of coffee, what it's like to taste vanilla ice cream, is something that is distinct. It cannot be conveyed through any scientific description, to the point where you're in a functionally equivalent situation to a person who is sipping the coffee and tasting the ice cream.
- 6.26** These are the two ways of thinking about consciousness. As I mentioned in the previous lecture, a great leap forward happened in contemporary philosophy of mind in the mid-1990s, with a book by David Chalmers, *The Conscious Mind*, where he tracks this distinction and says that when it comes to access consciousness, guides for behavior, reasoning, decision-making, access to memory, and so on and so forth, these are easy problems.
- 6.27** They're not easy in the sense that they are straightforward or simple. They definitely aren't. But more because we know what a solution would look like. We can conceive of what a solution would look like. For example, Chalmers talks about how information could become available to different brain systems, or how conscious states guide voluntary action, or how, for example, we verbally describe our mental states.

- 6.28** Now, these are not straightforward, but we can imagine solving them, perhaps with enough computation, maybe understanding neural mechanisms better. But those questions are to do with function and behavior. It's conceivable that these are questions that we can answer. The question that we really cannot answer, says Chalmers, or at least for now, it just does seem intractably hard to resolve, is the hard problem of consciousness, that is to say, the problem of phenomenal consciousness, the problem of why there is any subjective experience at all.
- 6.29** That's really the tough, that's really the one that there has been no progress on, claims Chalmers. Even if we could solve all of these easy problems—we could build a robot that integrates information perfectly, reports its states accurately, controls behavior properly, and so on and so forth—the hard problem asks: Would there be something it is like to be that robot? Would there be a qualitative experience that the robot undergoes in the way that we do when we go about those tasks?
- 6.30** If there is something that it is like to be that robot, why? Why couldn't all that processing just happen, as it were, in the dark? Why would it need— why couldn't you just have a robot that was functionally identical, like the zombies that we met earlier in a previous lecture, but with no inner experience at all, no what it is like to experience X or Y?
- 6.31** This is the issue that there has been no obvious progress on at all in the last 100 years, or at least the progress has been—possible claims about progress, but they've either unraveled or they've been challenged by another theory trying to achieve the same thing. We're still confronted with Joseph Levine's explanatory gap. Do you remember Levine? I think I said in a previous lecture that Levine is willing to grant almost everything to the physicalist.
- 6.32** He's willing to grant that the neuroscientists have discovered this neural pattern, we call it X, which always correlates with experiencing the color, seeing the color red. We found it. Eureka, the eureka moment. We found exactly the patterns that correspond perfectly every time a human being sees the color red.
- 6.33** What that would mean is—I can't believe this would happen, but let's just suppose it does—what that would mean is that we can predict, when X fires, we can see X firing in the brain on the scan, then we know that the subject will report seeing red. If the subject doesn't report seeing red, we know that the subject is lying. We've got it. Suppose we've got it. We can predict it. We can also manipulate it. We can actually manipulate the brain into being X, pattern X, and then we can trigger somebody seeing the color red. Whether or not they're seeing it, whether or not they're actually seeing the color red, it's interesting. OK, let's grant all that.
- 6.34** Levine's point, remember, is that we still don't understand what's going on here. It still seems like magic. Because the question you can then ask is: Why does that pattern, why does pattern X feel like anything? Or why doesn't pattern X generate the

experience of seeing the color blue? So, even on its own terms, the physicalist theory that says that there's either an identity relation between brain and mind, or that there is this close collaborative relationship between brain and mind, it's still a mystery. It's still magic. It feels like magic.

- 6.35** It certainly doesn't feel like a scientific explanation. What's the science in the link? Is there a law of nature? If so, what law of nature? Are there laws of neurophysiology? And so on and so forth. There's still no explanation as to why that particular configuration of neurons will bring about that particular feeling, that particular sensation, that particular experience, that particular thought or proposition.
- 6.36** Even if, and it's a huge if, one day the neuroscientist will convincingly tell us that there is this perfect—there is a link between particular brain states and particular phenomenal or mental states. So these problems have reasserted themselves and led to some new positions within, or ever ancient, ever new. As Augustine says at one point, there's a rebirth of thinking about very old ways of thinking about consciousness, but new ways of arguing for the reality of mind.
- 6.37** Some philosophers have just put their hands up in the air and have said, "We're not ever going to solve this problem, and we should just learn to live with that." This is a famous philosopher called Colin McGinn, Irishman, moved to America many years ago. He worked down in Florida somewhere, I think. What's his book called? Something like *The Mysterious Flame*. He's started this little school within the philosophy of mind. It seems to be a school of one, I think, but it's still an influential one.
- 6.38** Mysterianists, mysterianism, simply say, "We're never going to solve the problem of the relationship between mind and body, and we shouldn't be surprised at that. It's not something that we should expect ourselves to be equipped to understanding." Dogs can't understand quantum mechanics, not because quantum mechanics is false, but because of cognitive limitations.
- 6.39** I actually say—that's his example, I mean, human beings can't understand quantum mechanics, so at least not to the degree where they can even reach any agreement as to what it is or how to approach the different problems. It could be that our brains are, that our minds are cognitively closed in some way to understanding what consciousness is.
- 6.40** We can imagine there are areas of mathematics that are simply too complex for human minds to grasp. We already know there are plenty of problems in mathematics where there's an emerging consensus that they can't possibly be solved, particularly when you get into mathematics involving infinite series.
- 6.41** That's fine, says McGinn; one should just accept that there are limits to what can be understood. We should focus on what we can understand, rather than on the impossible. Even if the hard problem isn't impossible in principle to solve, it is impossible for a mind like ours to solve, for minds like ours to solve.

- 6.42 What to make of this? The main problem, I guess— certainly, the good thing about mysterianism is that it does acknowledge that attempts to reduce mind to matter over the last 100 years, 150 years, 200 years, have been a failure. Colin, again, would be somebody who would be very happy with a naturalistic or physicalistic answer to the problem of mind and how all can reduce it to matter.
- 6.43 But the very fact that he says, "Look, we can't know," shows that they failed. There's still this mystery. They've not got rid of the mystery. They've not banished the mystery. It's still there. And so, as it were, that's a kind of back-handed compliment to those who have resisted physicalist reductions of mind and consciousness to matter.
- 6.44 But the main problem is—I guess it's more of a meta-philosophical one. Philosophers, I can't think of any—it's very hard to think of a point at which it's appropriate for a philosopher, a professional philosopher, who is paid to do philosophy, paid to sit around and read dusty books that nobody's ever read in order to write books that will gather dust because nobody's going to read them, which is basically the life of an academic philosopher, it does seem we've got one job.
- 6.45 And that is effectively to refuse to say, when somebody says, "Oh, this is too difficult to think about; we're going to stop thinking about this problem. Plato couldn't crack it; we're not going to crack it," it's just a strange professional defeatism. It should be a puzzle or a mystery in philosophy. It should be an incentive to further thought and an incentive, a motivator, for further action and further disputes, and more books and conferences and taxpayer money that we can lavish on doing away weekends and fancy retreats and so on.
- 6.46 Just to put up your hands and say, "This is too difficult. It's too difficult for us philosophers. We're going to leave it for now," seems to give up too easily. It's a way of limiting understanding. I think, in ways that, as we'll see in our last two lectures, could have implications for how we go about thinking about consciousness and reason and intelligence in public policy, which is becoming increasingly urgent in two areas that I can think, at least two areas I can think of.
- 6.47 One is artificial intelligence, and two is the field of so-called mental health, though I think it'll be clear already, and I've mentioned already, why the phrase mental health is a phrase that gives hostages to fortune, because it thinks of the mind in terms of something that is healthy in roughly the way that a physical body is healthy, like a heart is healthy or an arm is healthy. And that, again, is to imply, that's to accept the materialist view.
- 6.48 That's to accept that the mind can be reduced to matter and that you can inspect it, you can do science on it, on the mind, on a suffering mind, in the same way that you can do science on a suffering arm or body or tooth. And that's to assume that the mind just is the same kind of thing as the body. And that, again, maybe that's true, but it's not obviously true. Those two areas, artificial intelligence and psychological well-being,

depend on a lot of the important decisions that are being made; they depend on a clear philosophical understanding, at least of the debate, at least of the issues, around the nature of mind. That's McGinn's approach. That's McGinn's position.

6.49 Others that are worth touching on, one especially interesting one that has emerged a lot, I'd say, in the last 10 years, is a position called panpsychism. Panpsychism. From the Greek "pan," meaning everything, and psychism simply means mind or soul everywhere. So soul everywhere or mind everywhere. And what is this particular, what is this position?

6.50 In a way, it, first of all, begins with a recognition or concession that physicalists, those who try to reduce mind to physics, have not succeeded. It seems to be something that is too stubborn to explain away or to reduce to physics. So, what the panpsychists do, rather than accept that minds subsist in human persons, because that would have all kinds of awkward implications, and would give rise to certain philosophical problems in the view of the panpsychist, the claim is that, actually, consciousness is everywhere. It's a feature of fundamental reality.

6.51 The planets and rocks and trees and flamingos and human beings are made up of the same stuff on which consciousness supervenes. On this view, consciousness is a bit like mass or velocity, something like that. It's a property of fundamental reality. The argument for it goes roughly like this. Consciousness, we accept, can't just pop out of purely physical processes. It can't be that purely physical processes can give rise to non-physical processes.

6.52 And yet consciousness exists. Consciousness is real. You can't get rid of that. Also, it does seem to be connected in some ways to physical processes. If you damage somebody's brain, then different behaviors can flow from it. It can affect your language use, for example. So that's true. Now, I think there are ways around that. I mean, ways around worrying about whether or not getting a knock on the head can completely change a person's moral behavior or how they think and so on and so forth.

6.53 That's only a problem if you, again, if you think that the brain and the mind are basically the same thing. If I damage my radio or if it gets wet in the shower, I'm not going to be able to hear what's going on, or it might get all fuzzy and hissy. But that doesn't mean that the quality of the wavelengths or the content of the radio program is affected in any way. What's transmitting it has been damaged.

6.54 But there's nothing in dualism that says—of course, the dualist rejects that the brain is the mind. It doesn't say that the brain is not a tool that you need, certainly you need in our embodied world; you need the brain as a tool for your mind to work. That doesn't mean that the mind is the tool. Just as you can say, you might say that the mind relates to the body in the way that the pianist relates to the piano. The pianist needs the piano. We, minded beings, need the brain.

- 6.55** That doesn't mean that the pianist is the piano. It doesn't mean that the piano could just play itself. The two do go together. It's the same, I think, for dualists as they think about the relationship between mind and brain, mind and person. It's not that the brain is irrelevant to how the mind can be engaged and implemented and what impact it can have on the world. It could be affected by the brain in different ways, too, just in the way that the tools that we have affect the jobs that we can do. It doesn't mean that we know what a good job we would do if we had—it doesn't mean that we don't know what we would do if we had better tools to do the job.
- 6.56** The panpsychist says there is consciousness. It clearly exists. It's somehow connected to physical processes. It can't be the case that it's just popped out of physical processes. And so, somehow it's got to be upstream of everything, perhaps alongside physics. Mind, psyche, psychism, and it is woven into matter.
- 6.57** What the argument then goes on to say is that what's happening when we're talking about human consciousness is that we're talking about a process that has emerged from combinations of simple, simple, conscious entities. The idea is that through thousands of millions of millions of millions of millions of conscious states that are out there in the world, they've combined and configured themselves in such a way that they've achieved a macro-consciousness that we understand ourselves to have.
- 6.58** I think this is probably where the position is at its weakest, because, again, we come back to the point that, to be conscious, it seems to have a completely unified and simple perspective on the world. By simple, I mean non-composite. It's not made up of multiple parts, so that when I hit a particular level of complexity, boom, suddenly I'm conscious. Consciousness doesn't seem to be that kind of thing. It's much more binary than that. You're either conscious, or you're not.
- 6.59** Remember what conscious states are. They are qualitative, subjective perspectives. Again, the question is, either these simple panpsychist conscious entities in the world are themselves subjects, in which case, the question is, with the China brain problem, how could millions and millions or more than one subject come together to form a single subject? That seems puzzling.
- 6.60** Or we say that, yes, they're conscious, but they're not yet subjectively conscious in the way that we get to be. Once all these different entities have configured themselves in a sufficiently complex way, boom, we get from an aggregate of objective states of consciousness, boom, to a single subject of conscious experience. That boom moment is a mystery. How? How do you get from the objective to the subjective? It simply doesn't make any sense; there's an explanatory gap there. It doesn't make sense.
- 6.61** In some ways, other theorists have tried to develop something like this theory, not the panpsychist one, but if you think of somebody like John Searle, a famous philosopher at the University of Berkeley, he comes up with this idea of biological naturalism. The idea

here is that what consciousness is is a macro property of a system, as opposed to a micro property.

- 6.62** He says that there are micro properties, macro properties, and macro properties only emerge once you reach a certain level of sophistication, a certain level of organizational complexity. He says that just as it takes—we can say that the property of sweating or digesting is the macro property of a human organism overall, there comes a—
- 6.63** Below that, when we're talking about arms, or we're talking about lungs, or we're talking about any other smaller component of the system that makes up the human organism, we can't say that it's not necessarily the arm that is sweating, it's not the cells that are, but they are part of a system which, when it's sufficiently complex, we can say, "Yeah, that is an organism that digests. That's an organism that sweats."
- 6.64** And so, this is the idea that consciousness is something that supervenes upon, that comes into being once certain parts prior to that are in place. But still, panpsychism is a very, very tall order in terms of plausibility. If the panpsychists are right, then it turns out that what we thought we were talking about when we were talking about consciousness is actually something radically different.
- 6.65** Because the intuition is that we've got to explain something that is radically distinct and unique from the rest of the world. When we're thinking about what it is to be conscious, for example, we think about what it is to be alive, for example. We say that, at least to be conscious is not to be dead, is not to be completely cut off from the world.
- 6.66** When Aristotle develops his three-tiered version of understanding of what ensoulment looks like, he, at least, doesn't even consider that rocks, or inanimate objects or planets might be conscious. For him, the soul is intimately connected with the explanation of what it is for something to be alive. And that's why he's happy to say, he starts by saying that plants have a soul in a very primitive sense, that the sunflower will turn towards the sun seeking nutrition.
- 6.67** For Aristotle, that's a kind of psyche, something that a rock couldn't even begin to do, that sets a sunflower apart from a rock or a piece of gold or a chair or whatever. There is a sense in which we can say, there's an organizing principle here, driving this forth, animating it, giving it life, and so on and so forth. Remember, up to perceptions that the animal kingdom has, and finally, a reason that only we, within the animal kingdom, have. Three levels of ensoulment.
- 6.68** But this is not what the panpsychists are saying. The panpsychists say everything is conscious. The trouble with, in definitional terms, if everything is X, nothing is X. The whole point of defining something or distinguishing something is to "de fine," literally in the Latin; you're putting in the end, you're putting in the boundary markers.

- 6.69 But if your definition of something is that it's everything, then it doesn't mean anything. Is it any definition at all? There comes a point in philosophy and in reasoning, more generally, where you can cast the net so wide in what something comes to mean that it becomes functionally useless, sometimes called concept creep. That's a whole other lecture.
- 6.70 Panpsychism has got its followers. It's probably got a lot more followers than mysterianism. But my sense is that it's a very radical position, panpsychism. I find it difficult to take seriously myself. But what it shows, what it is, what it represents is a back-handed compliment to those who are committed to the persistence of consciousness as something that is real and can't simply be eliminated or explained away.
- 6.71 Philosophers are willing to produce a view that, to most people, would seem outlandish, even crazy. Everything has got consciousness. All matter in the universe has got consciousness of some kind. In order to save a solution to the problem of mind and body that doesn't take us back to the more classical ways of understanding human persons as ensouled, having souls, not least because there are religious implications that flow from that, which are not popular within contemporary Anglo-American philosophy faculties.
- 6.72 It's worth moving on now to discuss what dualism looks like, as it were, what the revenge of substance dualism looks like, how it's managed to come back. I don't want to overstate the comeback. It's still very much a minority position in lots of ways.
- 6.73 But there have been philosophers out there who've been willing to defend what is effectively a Cartesian position, where it's not just that mental and physical states are, say, just properties of a person, but that they are actual substances, that there is a non-physical substance that is you, and then a physical substance that the you is either attached to, or that you can be identified with.
- 6.74 One philosopher who's probably, I suppose, one of the leading substance dualists—there aren't many—is one who I've been fortunate to know, get to know over the years, and that's Richard Swinburne. He's now in his early nineties. He's still going strong. He's developed some very powerful arguments.
- 6.75 I'm trying to think of his recent book. I think he's done two books on substance dualism and philosophy of mind issues in the last 10, 15 years. One is *Mind, Brain, and Free Will*, I think it was. *Mind, Brain, and [Free Will]*, 2013, and *The Evolution of the Soul*, which I think was around about 1985, 1986. These are very, very powerful arguments that he advances.
- 6.76 The basic argument is that if physicalism were true, then all of our mental events would be what's known as epiphenomenal. It would be epiphenomenal. They'd be floating above us, but they would have no impact on the world. Swinburne's point is that

this conflicts with everything that we know most deeply about our place in the world and our agency in the world.

- 6.77** He says, "You can't get away from this intuition and this commitment that our thoughts and our decisions genuinely do influence our actions." His view is that, or the way he develops his position, is that yes, Kim is right. Every physical event must have a sufficient physical cause. But I am right, and our intuitions are right, when we say that it's our thoughts and our actions that genuinely cause—our thoughts and our decisions genuinely cause our actions.
- 6.78** It's true also, Kim is right, that there can be no over-determination, or there shouldn't be. Events typically don't have multiple sufficient causes. What Swinburne derives from this is that, therefore, mental events must be caused by something non-physical. Otherwise, you really would have a causal redundancy. It's obvious that our thoughts and actions bring about causes, bring about effects in the world. There's no physical account that makes sense of that.
- 6.79** In addition, we wouldn't want a physical account to make sense of that, when we can already make sense of it in terms of our own thoughts and decisions, that is to say, in non-physical terms. What Swinburne encourages us to think about is not so much that we need to explain X. We've got a candidate explanation Y and a candidate explanation Z, or Z, as you say in American. Philosophers will typically say, "You've got to pick one. There's no point in having two. We keep things lean and keep things parsimonious."
- 6.80** That's effectively the setup. You can't have these two layers; you can't have two causal factors competing with each other. Swinburne accepts this, but he also adds that, from the point of view of explanation, it's totally acceptable for us and totally normal for us to give two explanations for a particular pattern of events which are not redundant, where one is not redundant relative to the other.
- 6.81** There's simply two different ways of understanding why those events have occurred. So imagine a friend comes around, and I decide to make him a cup of tea, and I go and put on the kettle. That's this gadget that we have in kitchens in England, where you can just put water in, heat it up, and it's there by magic: you've got three or four minutes, and you've got boiling hot water. I don't know what they do in America for tea-drinking, but there we go.
- 6.82** I put the kettle on and boil it and I make the cup of tea and I bring it back to my friend and I put it down in front of him. Now, I could give—and no doubt the neuroscientist could give me, the physicist could give me—a perfect account, a scientifically complete account, of everything happening in my brain and my body and my muscles and in the kettle and in the water and in the tea leaves. We give them everything. Give them every—all scientifically true facts about that whole process are transparent, are known to us.

- 6.83** Swinburne asks, "Would that explain why I went and made a cup of tea for my friend?" Well, no, it really wouldn't. It would explain everything internal to that process. There's nothing that's not known about the process, except why there was the process at all, why it started, why it ended the way it did, and why there was this first-person agency.
- 6.84** Swinburne says that you can have a complete scientific explanation that is not wrong. There's nothing wrong about it. There's nothing even limited about it. It is complete in its own terms. And yet, Swinburne says that it doesn't really tell you anything. It doesn't give you the—there's a personal explanation that appeals to personal causes, reasons for action, reasons for motivation, that initiated that whole causal sequence and is the reason the causal sequence took the form that it did, took the pattern that it did.
- 6.85** These are not competing explanations. It's not as if, in my account of why it is that I got up and put the kettle on and made a cup of tea for my friend, that anything I could say in that could contradict anything that the scientist said. If it did contradict something the scientist said, then the scientist would be right. I mean, I'd cheerfully say, "OK, you're the scientist. Yeah, you're right. I've strayed onto some scientific explanation here. OK, fine."
- 6.86** But there's nothing you, the scientist, can tell me about why it is that I have initiated this process that you can now tell me I'm right or wrong about when it comes to the details. That level of personal explanation, again, is so obvious to us that we don't even think about it. No doubt, we're always aware, when we turn on a computer, when we do all kinds of things in the world, that there are complex scientific facts and theories that are making it all possible.
- 6.87** We just assume that somebody somewhere knows what those are, but we don't lose sleep over it. It doesn't really matter. What matters is that we understand the world as a world populated with persons who are conscious, who are free, who have agency, who are not just being programmed and determined by little things in the brain or their genes or their heredity or their environment.
- 6.88** Another point that Swinburne makes, before we leave Swinburne and draw the lecture to a close to move on to some more dualist arguments tomorrow, is this question of personal identity—personal identity and personal continuity. It's an old problem in the history of philosophy.
- 6.89** If you took a photo of you when you were five, and you look at it and you say, "Well, that's a very interesting configuration of brain states and physical particles, almost none of which has any physical overlap with me now. And so I must conclude that people tell me that that was me, but it's not me. There's no continuity. There's no physical connection between me now and that little boy, who had a photo taken of him when he was five."
- 6.90** Now, on the physicalist conception, that's not a problem because there are various arguments as to how, although I might not be connected now to the five-year-old,

there's a chain of continuity, and there are different intermediary states where I was in a state of physical overlap with the five-year-old and so on and so forth. Anyway, you could develop an argument along those lines.

- 6.91** But Swinburne's point is that if you're a substance dualist, there's no problem at all. That five-year-old is me, is identical to me in all different respects. I don't need to work out—in all relevant respects, I don't need to work out some sort of chain of me's that goes all the way back. It's just me. Yes, my body is different. That doesn't matter, because I am not my body. I am I. I'm in the body, but I might not be. I can conceive of myself as not being in a body. The body, I am not I, or my body is not I.
- 6.92** I remember about, gosh, 12 years ago, I was at university in Texas for a conference, and I got to know this guy, a wonderful American philosopher, who was a substance dualist, who took the Swinburne view and took a neo-Cartesian view. I said to him, "Well, that's a brave position to hold on to these days, Kenny, because it's not that popular. It must be quite a struggle in the seminars."
- 6.93** And he said, "Yeah, I'm not too bothered about that. I know all the arguments. You know my real problem, though?" I said, "What's that, Kenny?" He looks me in the eyes and he says, "I am never going to see my kids. I'm never going to meet my kids." I said, "Kenny, what do you mean?" "Well, because my position in the philosophy of mind commits me to the immateriality of persons, so that all I'm seeing when I think I see my kids are their bodies. I don't actually see that—I don't see them."
- 6.94** I said, "Kenny, I think it's time you come up with a new theory in philosophy of mind. If I could persuade you that maybe there's a way of tweaking this, I could introduce you to your children." Anyway, he laughed about it. Now, he took it deadly seriously. He was clearly, you know, grieving this idea, this consequence of his position. It's a tough one. The solution, the idea is that personhood is something that is—it's a seat of consciousness. It's a seat of subjectivity. It can't be composite. It can't be made up of parts, for reasons I tried to touch on earlier.
- 6.95** It's got to be something that's unified, that's stable, that can't be understood in physical terms. If it's not physical, if the mind is not physical, how could you see it? You can't see non-physical things. Kenny's worry was a plausible one. It's, I'm non-physical, and every person is non-physical, so nobody's ever seen another person. Nobody's ever seen—no person has ever seen another person. This is a troubling implication of this.
- 6.96** Now, look, you can say, I said to him at the time, I said, "Look, nobody's ever seen a dollar. Nobody's seen a dollar." You got dollar notes. Do you still have dollar notes? Are they coins or something? I don't know what they are in America. You say, "Oh, I've got it now. Look at it. Here's the note. This is a dollar." No, it's not. It's a token of a dollar. It's what we used to get you, a dollar's worth of gold before 1971. It would get you, you take it to the bank, but there'd be a little lump of gold. The gold's not a dollar. Gold's gold. It's worth a dollar, and so on and so forth.

- 6.97** So, there are many things in the world that we don't question. We're not worried by their non-physicality. We can still say, "That costs a dollar. You still owe me a dollar." Don't give me this stuff about dollars don't exist, therefore I don't owe you any money back. The whole world would collapse. Similarly, the fact that we can't, that I can't, visually see the person. All I can see is the vehicle for the person's soul, and it's a distinct substance, and so on and so forth.
- 6.98** You can simply say that we don't need to worry about that. These are not worries that should really affect the position. There we are. There's a little glimpse at the return, renewal of a very robust kind of substance dualism, in response to some of the physicalist strategies that we looked at in the previous two lectures. In the next lecture, we'll draw that side of things to a close, on dualism.
- 6.99** We'll look at different alternatives to dualism, some more thinkers in addition to Swinburne, and some contemporary dualist responses to standard objections. That will set us up in the eighth and final lecture to look at some contemporary real-world applications of these questions to public policy and, in particular, artificial intelligence, and questions to do with psychological well-being. Thank you for listening.

Lecture 7: Mind Reconsidered

At a glance — Mind reconsidered — drawing the threads toward a view.

- 7.1 Welcome to lecture seven in Introduction to Philosophy of Mind. We're nearly in the home straits. In this lecture, we're just going to wrap up some of those different options on dualism, that is to say, remember the claim that there is a distinction between mind and brain, between soul and body, between mind and world.
- 7.2 We're going to canvass some of those options, the contemporary versions of dualism, that are the counterattack, the response, to this dominant orthodoxy throughout the 20th century, that the only way to understand mind, our consciousness, our beliefs, our feelings, our desires, our whole inner life, our whole inner world, is through physics and physics alone, collapsing everything down to neurochemicals and synaptic fizz in the gray goo, the yogurty gray goo that is our brain and the seat of our consciousness, according to these theories.
- 7.3 So that reductionism, that reductionist project, of trying to explain the mind in terms of matter, in terms of nothing but physics, has met with some serious responses from these dualist accounts. We'll run through some of those, and that will set us up conveniently for the final lecture, to look at the way these different options of understanding the relationship between mind and body, between mind and brain, how to understand personal identity, how to make sense of beliefs and desires and dispositions and so on, that will help us then apply these questions to big issues in the public square today, and I'll say more about that in due course.
- 7.4 In the previous lecture, I touched on Richard Swinburne's recent arguments for substance dualism. Swinburne, a philosopher in Oxford, just turned 90 recently. He's still going strong. He's developed a number of thought experiments that he thought would be an intuition pump for us, to realize how odd it would be to think of the soul or to think of the self, think of the I, as somehow divisible and explicable in terms of purely physical processes.
- 7.5 Here's one of them. It's a famous thought experiment of Swinburne. He says, imagine this scenario. You find yourself in a terrible accident. You're rushed to the hospital. Both of the hemispheres of your brain are intact, but your body is dying. The surgeons successfully separate your hemispheres and then transplant the left hemisphere into one body and the right hemisphere into another body. Swinburne is clear that science cannot achieve this at the moment, but it's possible, it's perfectly conceivable, that such a situation may indeed happen.
- 7.6 Here's the question: Which one of those two beings is you? Swinburne argues that the dualist has an answer to this, that the physicalist doesn't. For the physicalist, there are either two I's, which is hard to make sense of. There are two I's, there are two me's. Or we say, the I has been annihilated, and two new I's have popped up. The trouble there

is that it's taken for granted that all the memories, all the intuitions, everything that I've learned, is in these two people.

- 7.7** Swinburne says, on physicalism, that it should be possible. If all we are is just our brains, just our bodies, everything that physics can say about us, then why can't you be split into two? If the science can—if the technology can cope with it: you can split into two, split into three, split into four hemispheres, and so on and so on, the hemispheres are cut into hemispheres. And do we get multiple I's? The physicalist seems constrained to conclude that.
- 7.8** Swinburne's view is that this is a *reductio ad absurdum*. This just highlights the weirdness, the absurdity, of the physicalist position. The proper answer, in his view, that the dualist can make, is to say that the I is either that one or it's that one. It can't be both. I'm not committed, as the dualist, to believing that there's both, because I don't believe that the soul and the self and the I can be divided, that no scientific technology ever will be able to split a person, because what a person is, is a simple subjective unity.
- 7.9** You might kill the person when you're trying out the various experiments to carve him up, but you're not going to split the person. You can't split a person. It belongs to the meaning of the word "person" that you can't split it. You're a subject, not an object. That's one of Swinburne's arguments.
- 7.10** Another one, the other major argument that he advances, is similar. It's to do also with the unity of consciousness. When we experience the world, when we encounter the world, we apprehend it. We apprehend it as a unity. If we stop for a moment to think about all of the different things that our mind and our brain has to do to make up this apprehension, it's extraordinary.
- 7.11** You can imagine some parts of the brain feeding in color, other parts of the brain feeding in sound, other parts of the brain feeding in shape and texture. Whatever it is the neuroscientists are telling us about what the different parts of our brain do, the point is, I don't see it as a collage or like some weird mosaic. I see the world in a single flash of unity. And adding me, adding the I to everything that my brain is doing and everything that my mind is doing, suddenly pixelates all of that into a clear, single picture that I apprehend, that is the world.
- 7.12** In other words, the I is a binding agent. It binds together all of the different sensory inputs, without which we couldn't make sense of the world, but which require filtering and ordering. We do that without thinking. It's an extraordinary feature of consciousness. We don't even need to think. It's just there. And so, Swinburne argues that unified center of subjectivity can't itself be composite. It's what binds everything else. So it's what binds all of conscious experience together into one.
- 7.13** And whatever can do that, whatever is capable of doing that can't be a physical process. It can't be a physical process. It can't be some physical process within the brain that is

coordinating everything together and then flipping from the objective into the subjective. That's not going—the binding agent can't be a physical agent, not least because what it's binding together are thoughts and beliefs and feelings, things that are very plausibly not reducible to neurochemistry.

- 7.14** Swinburne says, if you ask the question, "Where is the unified I holding together this experience, making it a unified, integrated, intelligible experience?," and if the physicalist says it's the brain as a whole, it's the brain taken together with all of the different activities that it contributes to conscious experience, Swinburne's response is that the brain is just a whole number of neurons, billions and billions and billions of neurons, arranged in a certain way.
- 7.15** How is it that a bundle of these things suddenly throws up one experience, one single unified experience? It feels like bootstrapping. These are just physical things connected through causal interactions, not rational inferences or anything like that. And yet, it's just as mysterious as to how a bundle of such things could suddenly throw up a unified perspective, as it is for two or three of them, or indeed one of them. So that's some of Swinburne's arguments.
- 7.16** Let's move on now to the arguments of another slightly less well-known philosopher, but a genius in his own way. He sadly died in 2014. I corresponded with him briefly before he died. A wonderful man, Jonathan Lowe, E.J. Lowe, L-O-W-E. He taught for many years as a professor of metaphysics at the University of Durham in England. He was a shy dualist. He didn't make it central to his life's work, but he wrote on so much that I think, for the sake of completeness, he decided to do a book on the philosophy of mind. It's a very, very good book indeed.
- 7.17** It outed him as a dualist, which is not exactly maybe a controversial position, but it's certainly a minority view in philosophy of mind across Western universities at the moment. Lowe was actually very critical of the materialist paradigm that wants to reduce mind and pretty much everything else to matter and to purely scientific principles.
- 7.18** He advanced an argument which, in many ways, resembles one of the arguments that we looked at in a very early lecture, the lecture on Plato's, where I discussed Plato's *Phaedo*, and this moving dialogue where Socrates is on his deathbed. He's drinking the hemlock, as instructed by the court, and slowly his life slips away over the course of the dialogue. To comfort his friends, he develops these arguments as to why, although his body is going to die, he's going to undergo biological death, his soul is eternal and is going to persist beyond it.
- 7.19** One of the arguments that he makes, probably the best of the three, is the so-called affinity argument. What Socrates argues is that, for, it's certain eternal truths, Plato has the forms in mind, but any eternal truths, like $2 + 2 = 4$, for example, that's an eternal truth. It never began to be true. It will never cease to be true. It's true no matter what.

It's true in every possible world. It's true whether there was a Big Bang or no Big Bang. It's true whether there was a Big Crunch, going to be a Big Crunch or no Big Crunch.

- 7.20** And Socrates says that the knower must somehow fit what is possibly known, what can be known. If there are these knowers that, through their mind, have access to this transcendent mathematical domain that's outside space and outside time, what an extraordinary thing for a mind to be able to do, it can't be the case that such a mind is entirely physical.
- 7.21** It can't be the case that a mind that is purely spatiotemporal, purely constrained by the laws of physics, can somehow have this magical access to everything that lies beyond the world of physics, beyond space-time, that knows not just one truth that's outside space and time and that's non-physical and transcendent—the $2 + 2 = 4$ truth—but infinitely many truths, infinitely many more truths than there are scientific truths.
- 7.22** Because if $2 + 2 = 4$, $2 + 3 = 5$, and then it would be very surprising if that principle worked, but up into the trillions, things got a bit tricky, and if you added 1, or added 2 or didn't add 1 at all. No, no, no, no. Infinity is much simpler than finitude. Infinity is much simpler. We have infinitely many truths that we have access to. Socrates says, so it must be the case that the knower is shaped in some way, is attuned in some way, to what transcends the sciences, not just physics, but also biology, including my biology or Socrates's biology.
- 7.23** Jonathan Lowe develops an argument that I think resembles this one, the so-called affinity argument, very nicely, between knower and known. What he says is that the way minds make things happen in the world is of a different category of the processes and the causal processes by which ordinary physical things cause events in the world, knock into other things in the world. There's mental causation, and then there's physical causation.
- 7.24** Physical causation—how does that work? Well, it's a big debate in philosophy, but the scientists are clear; it's basically mass energy transfer. That's what it is, when there's motion or some physical causal impact. You have an exchange of mass and energy between two objects. It's about as far as my high school physics goes. But it's true. The mass energy exchange is when we have a causal event, a physical causal event.
- 7.25** There will be spatial contact, where you'll be able to describe it in terms of, with a GPS, or in terms of an interactive field of causal connections. There'll be laws of nature involved, either deterministic ones or weirder quantum probabilistic ones. It doesn't matter. Still laws of some sort. This is how causation works. This is how science causation works. This is how physical cause-and-effect causation works.
- 7.26** Then Lowe says, what's going on with mental causation? When I decide to pour myself a glass of water, I decide, and then all the processes are put in place, but this is agent causation, not so much object or event causation. How does that work? Well, is there mass energy exchange in my decision and deliberation to pour myself a glass of water?

Maybe there's some mind-energy exchange correlate in my brain when I'm thinking certain things, but is that what's doing it? Is that what's bringing the change about?

- 7.27** Lowe says no, because what I'm thinking, when it comes to mental causation, me deciding to pour myself a glass of water, there are all kinds of reasons that I'm doing it. There are rational connections between different beliefs that I have about being thirsty, knowing what to do when I have this sensation—that is, getting some water, getting the glass out, making sure the water is running cold—all these different decisions that I make, that rely upon not causal connections, not mass and energy transfers, but inferences between beliefs.
- 7.28** Lowe says those are two totally different things that have got nothing to do with each other. A reason is not a cause. It's a reason for action. It's me wanting, recognizing that this is a good thing to do or something that I want to do or believe to be true or whatever it might be. I'm not being determined by physical, mass energy transfers. There's an I that is forming reasons and forming rational connections, making logical inferences, understanding words, understanding meaning.
- 7.29** This is not something that—physical processes can't understand anything. We'll come on to that more when we talk about AI in the next lecture. Also, I act for goals. I do things for a reason. Science can't—a purely physical analysis can't offer up reasons, can't inspect the world and say, "Well, we can see from this behavior, and we can see from the workings inside the brain, that what he wanted to do was this." That's not possible. The physical sciences haven't got access to what my reasons are, what my beliefs are. You can't read those under a microscope.
- 7.30** As I mentioned yesterday, and this is something Swinburne stresses as well, as well as Lowe, there are at least two ways of understanding human behavior. The one level is the completely comprehensive and exhaustive scientific account. So, everything that's going on inside my body, everything that's going on inside my brain, everything that's going on with the water and the glass and the tap, you could give that a complete scientific description. Total, every single truth, every single scientific truth involved in correctly comprehensively describing that process, let's say, is granted.
- 7.31** But the claim is that that's not ever going to be a sufficient explanation because the total physics describing everything that happens, from me moving towards the glass and drinking it, does not explain itself. It doesn't explain what started that whole process, started it off, and what ended it. For that, you need to go up a level to personal explanation. There's a scientific explanation, and then there's a personal explanation. The personal explanation is irreducible to the scientific one.
- 7.32** Physicalists want to say that personal explanation is what the person told himself after these causal processes determined him to pour that glass of water. But that's not; it's the other way around. The only reason there's anything for the physicist to describe, in terms of the processes in my body and the glass of water and so on and that, the only

way to understand, the only reason that it's there to be described, is because, upstream of that, is a personal decision taken by a free-minded conscious being with desires and thirsts and beliefs and ideas and propositions and reasons for action that are not causes. They're just reasons.

- 7.33** What Lowe argues is that these are just two totally legitimate tiers of explanation. They don't compete with one another. They are adequate in their own domain to explain what's going on, except that the personal explanation is far more complete. It can give an account of itself. It can explain why this process was initiated, why it was feeling thirsty, etc. It can provide a context that the purely physical description of what was happening when I was doing that could not possibly give.
- 7.34** So, there are reasons. Reasons are real. Reasons for action are real. Reasons depend upon inference, on deliberation, on thought, not mass energy transfers. That's a completely different category for things happening in the world. What other positions are worth looking at here? I think you could see, just to go back to the Phaedo connection, to the affinity argument, it's worth remembering that that is also a radically different explanation, because you're dealing there, whether it's with mathematics or geometric forms or arithmetic or whatever it might be, it's a domain of knowledge that is well, well beyond the scientific one.
- 7.35** So at least with a personal scientific explanation, they're complementary. When it comes to mathematics, certainly pure mathematics, that's much more of a struggle. And so, if you've got an account, as the dualist does, of there being a soul that has, in principle, contact to some domain that transcends space and time, then you've got a much more plausible account of how such knowledge is possible. That's something Lowe presses a great deal.
- 7.36** The argument, as you might put it out, develop it, would be that if it were the case that minds were purely physical, all our mental states would be physical states. But physical states, they're unlike these necessary truths. They're contingent. They are in time. They might not have existed. They're spatial. They're material. That's all that a physically stated mind, as it were, a mind that was only configured in physical brain states, that's all that could plausibly be grasped. And yet, it's clear that we can grasp infinitely many things more than that, that are not contingent, are not in time, are not in space.
- 7.37** We haven't talked a great deal about free will, but I'm going to put it on the table because it will be relevant for when we come to think about AI and neural enhancement and pharmacology and a few other issues in the applied issues lecture. To the extent that one is committed to the idea that there is such a thing as free will, physicalism is going to be a very difficult option.
- 7.38** Certainly, if minds are purely physical, and the physicalist is right, then, yeah, all of our thoughts, all of our beliefs, are determined by prior physical states, plus some laws, like the cumulative weight of all the antecedent physical causes and effects that lead up to

me deciding to go and pour myself a glass of water. And yet, that's a very high cost, a very high price to pay, to ditch free will entirely, at least if the reasons are to save physicalism.

- 7.39 And by the way, some people have said that maybe physics can make sense of us behaving under the laws of quantum randomness—this is the idea from quantum mechanics. Maybe that's a way of having a non-deterministic account of how we act, and we're not required by all the physical causes and effects before our decision.
- 7.40 Randomness, though, doesn't help. I mean, if you say you're not free to do anything you want, but what you do actually do will be completely predictable by the scientists or not predictable by the scientists, just random, I'm not going to feel any better. I'm still going to feel like I've got no control over my life, that my deepest intuitions about my engagement with reality are just completely mistaken and completely misguided.
- 7.41 So, whether my behavior is random or whether it's determined, I don't like either, really, because both abolish the free agency that human beings have. Very powerful intuition is genuinely embedded in what it is to be a human being. Here's the point. Agents, as opposed to just causes, have a fundamentally different way of bringing things about in the world. It's a different causation. Agents are the sources of their actions, whereas causes are just chains; they're just links in the chain of actions. No purely physical cause can spontaneously bring something in to make something happen.
- 7.42 Human beings can. We can do stuff. We can do things for no reason, and we can do things for brilliant reasons. We can do things for stupid reasons. And those reasons are completely opaque to the scientist inspecting our brain under a microscope. Different kind of thing. This is the argument.
- 7.43 Getting rid of free will, you pay a high price. It generates all kinds of headaches when you're thinking about moral philosophy. How can we praise somebody if they were always going to—praise somebody for doing something when they were always going to do it? How could you blame somebody for something when they were always going to do it? They had no choice, no real choice. And so that has difficult knock-on effects.
- 7.44 So one or two other more unusual theories of dualism. Now we're going back to, we've just touched on ways of bringing Plato back to life in some ways, or bringing Plato's psychology and his philosophy of mind and soul back to life with new arguments. But there are also some, increasingly, over the last 10, 15 years, some Aristotelian philosophers of mind who are trying to resurrect Aristotle. They do this through the metaphysical framework of hylomorphism.
- 7.45 Remember in lecture, in the early lectures, I described "hylē"—hyle is matter in Greek — "morphē" is shape. And so, hylomorphism is an account of lots of different things, but when it comes to the mind, an account of the relationship between mind and body in terms of form to matter, form and matter. So that my mind is the form of my body in

the same way that the form of Michelangelo's David informs and animates that lump of Carrara marble that would just be a lump otherwise, and the two are fused together.

- 7.46** If you ask, "What's the relationship between this image of David that Michelangelo had in mind when he made the statue and the marble that it's made of, what's the relationship between the two?" The answer is, for the hylomorphist, "There isn't. They are completely fused." The statue of David would not be the statue of David without the lump of marble, obviously. But nor would it be the statue of David if that lump of marble had not had Michelangelo's created blueprint for it imprinted on it.
- 7.47** And so the two are completely fused in a way that is a bit more attractive than on the dualist model, where you've got mind and world, you've got mental states, brain states, and the question is: How's traffic between these two possible? Because the mental and the consciousness is a completely different thing from physics and science and stuff on the bottom level.
- 7.48** So there can't be laws of nature between the two, because we're saying that there's this mental world. We're saying there's something outside nature. So you can't have a law that governs nature, that moves from nature into non-nature, the non-natural. So you'd need special laws; what would those laws be? If there were laws, would that not constrain freedom? All of these questions.
- 7.49** Whereas on the hylomorphic model, it's just form and matter. No matter, there's no person, there's no minded person, there's no conscious being. But if there's no form, then it's just matter. It's some other stuff. So, the idea is, the body is what constitutes us as a person, but it's not what we're identical with, which is what the physicalists or many physicalists want to say. Mind and brain are completely identical.
- 7.50** That has certain advantages over the Cartesian dualist problem. It solves the interaction problem, you might say, because form and matter are not separate. They're not separate substances. They're two, let's say, principles that explain a single substance. Yes, I mean, it's also quite attractive in the sense that it has this view of the Aristotelian picture of the human person as an embodied soul or an ensouled body, not a body with a soul.
- 7.51** Not a body with this meat machine with angelic mind dropped into it, which is Plato's view. Then the angelic mind just pops off when the body dies, and the body is completely irrelevant. On the Aristotelian picture, it takes our embodiment and the fact that we are animals, we are creatures, natural creatures at one level, he takes that very seriously. There's something quite attractive about that. It makes sense of how we understand the significance of bodies, even dead bodies.
- 7.52** So that is one way of thinking about hylomorphism today. Dean Zimmerman has done a lot of very good work on this. It's worth reflecting, too, on another kind of dualism that has emerged in, let's say, the last 25 years, and that's called emergence, or emergentism. What's the idea here? One key problem is, if you are committed to the

idea that there are minds and that we're conscious, how did a purely physical process, namely the theory of evolution, throw up beings that had a capacity to interact with infinitely many non-physical truths, in mathematics, for a start?

- 7.53** It's not obvious. I mean, if you've got a completely physical process, then how could some non-physical dimension, namely, producing hominids that are capable of maths and cosmology and all kinds of extraordinary things, is this what you would predict from a purely physical process in the amoebic swamp, way back whenever it was, 14 billion years ago?
- 7.54** It's extremely surprising, extremely surprising on that view, on a purely physicalist view, that non-physical souls and minds with conscious beliefs and feelings and experience and capacity to interact and reflect upon a transcendent world. This is not what you would predict. It is what you would predict on theism, by the way, or it's considerably more likely on theism that you would have the kind of world that would end up 14 billion years later in the world that we actually do exist in, than it is likely or probable if there were just a purely unguided random development, in my view.
- 7.55** Emergence, therefore, is a way of trying to give an account of how it is that consciousness does emerge. They're quite clever arguments. I don't buy any of them, but they are well-developed as arguments. The basic thought is that consciousness can emerge once you get to a sufficiently complex organization of physical properties or physical states. The idea is that the soul is real, it's distinct, but it emerges from complex brain organization.
- 7.56** But once it has emerged, it's distinct. And crucially, it has causal powers. It can influence the world in some way. There is mental causation. That distinguishes it from epiphenomenalism, which says that the mind also does emerge or sits on top of brain states. It's distinct, but it can't cause anything. Everything still has to be explained in terms of physical cause and effect.
- 7.57** So Hasker asks us to think of how water emerges from H₂O molecules. Water has properties that hydrogen and oxygen don't have; the individual molecules on their own don't have. Water is wet, it's got surface tension, etc. But it's distinct. It has distinct properties. When sufficiently many H₂O molecules are together, then you have new properties come into being, wetness and surface tension, etc., and drinkability, which does not exist at the individual molecular level, as it were, of water. It is not true of the individual molecules, but taken together, you have these new emergent properties, and that's how we should think about consciousness.
- 7.58** I think I mentioned already John Searle's idea that this distinction between micro properties and macro properties, so properties of micro level, lower levels of a system in the functional hierarchy of a system, and macro properties that, he says, emerge after a sufficient degree of complexity has reached.

- 7.59 An example might be that individual limbs or human cells don't sweat, but human beings sweat, and they digest. These are functions that can only exist—these are properties that emerge once there is a sufficiently complex, complexly organized human being. We're to think about consciousness in that way, too. We hit a certain degree of complexity in terms of our brain organization, and then boom, consciousness emerges.
- 7.60 What are we to make of this? It still feels to me like magic, still. Because the question is still, it's not—you can understand digestion, you can understand sweating, you can understand the wetness of water, the surface tension of water. You can still understand that in purely scientific terms. But that is not the same.
- 7.61 That is to say that we can understand certain physical properties emerging beyond a certain degree of organizational complexity. But that's trying to smuggle in the idea that what the soul is, what the I is, what consciousness is, what sets of beliefs and feelings and desires are, is equivalent to digestion, sweating, wetness, surface tension.
- 7.62 But that's exactly what the whole mind-body problem is about. It's, wait a minute, we don't think that consciousness is like any of those things. Now you're coming up with some clever thought experiment that shows how these complex physical properties emerge after a certain degree of organizational complexity. That's just loading the dice against us, us dualists, because we say that whatever it is, that what's emerging is not like those things. It's not a problem for wetness or digestion. It's not a problem for the scientist.
- 7.63 Oh, yeah, OK, right. It only happens at this point. Fine. It's not— the problem with consciousness and the appearance of freedom and agent causation, mental causation, the problem there is precisely that the suspicion is that it's not like any of those things, or at least that's the argument. Is it or is it not like those things? So, a thought experiment that subtly lures us into thinking that what emerges is like those things is begging the question. It's begging the question. That is to say, it's folding into the premises of the argument, the thought experiment, what should be in the conclusions.
- 7.64 So that is one puzzle. But you can see in the attempt to make emergence right, there is this—what's driving it is an attempt to make sense, to find a place for mind in world, without abandoning the total stress on scientific analysis. That's the worry. Can we come up with a theory of how there are conscious beings in the world that is consistent with evolutionary theory, consistent with physics, and maybe this is the best way we can do it?
- 7.65 These are recent arguments. What it shows is, although I think it's a failed theory, it is striking that these attempts are being made after this enormous decades-long dominance of physicalism, of mind-to-matter reductionism as the dominant dogma. Emergentism feels a little bit like simply relabeling the problem.

- 7.66 The question is: How do minds and conscious selves emerge from the primordial goo? The emergentist says, "They emerge. And this philosophy is called emergentism. I've got all these arguments as to how it emerges. Once there was the goo, and now there's Gary. That's it. Gary emerged." There's this feeling that that's just labeling the problem, because the question is, how is that possible in a way either that doesn't require you to abandon physicalism or requires you to make sense of it in dualist or some other terms?
- 7.67 We've looked at various arguments in the course of this lecture so far that would reinforce the dualist intuitions. I think we've spent a couple of lectures looking at what drives the physicalist intuitions and arguments. We see there are more powerful arguments for dualism than you would think, given the minority of dualists in philosophy departments. It's still definitely a minority view.
- 7.68 But arguments from personal identity, conscious unity, rational insight, the affinity argument, that is to say, the more natural account of our epistemic connections to abstract objects, for example, mathematical objects, would suggest that our cognition is not entirely physical and not entirely to be understood in causal processes. With Zimmerman's hylomorphism and emergentism, people like William Hasker, we see an attempt to preserve some of the intuitions of dualism. We still want to keep mind on the scene somehow.
- 7.69 But their view, the hylomorphism, the form-matter view, and the emergentism view, tries to get around the interaction problem. How does mind interact with the world if they're two such completely different things? If they're not such two completely different things, but they are two aspects of one thing, as with David and the statue and Michelangelo's blueprint, then it seems you can get away from the interaction problem.
- 7.70 Similarly on emergentism, it's a little bit more complicated, but in principle, if you've got some account of how consciousness comes in as some macro property after hitting a certain threshold, then you can see that, on that view, consciousness is much more tightly bound to the person, to the biological organism, than any Cartesian or Platonic account of mind and body doing a complicated tango.
- 7.71 These are no longer fringe positions. I mean, it's still, as I said, not a dominant orthodoxy. It's not the most influential account yet, but what is striking about dualism's opponents, though they are, I think, far greater in number, is that the different theories that physicalists are advancing suggest fragmentation, and I think it feels like a failure mode within the research program of trying to explain how mind and consciousness is to be understood purely in physical terms.
- 7.72 I think there's fragmentation across physicalism, and the epicycles and epicycles of increasingly complex attempts to shore up different positions within the physicalist camp suggests that, even if it's not exactly losing the battle overall, it certainly hasn't

got the cast-iron allegiance that was typical of philosophy of mind in, certainly, the second half of the 20th century, shall we say. The last 25 years have definitely seen a reconfigured landscape in this contentious area of philosophy.

- 7.73** As we look ahead to the next lecture and the final lecture, some of the questions that we've looked at in this long argument between physicalism and dualism will help us, I hope, think about these more contemporary questions. For example, we're going to be looking at artificial intelligence in the next lecture, and there, a key question is: Is Lowe right? Or was Socrates right? Or is he wrong? Or are they both wrong?
- 7.74** That is to say, if computers can be perfect substitutes for brains and for minds, then Lowe must be wrong. Socrates is wrong. Because what Lowe and Socrates are saying is that a mind is configured in a particular way, a non-physical mind, and it must be a non-physical mind in order to be able to apprehend rational inferences and rational insight and to be able to understand the world. Whereas all that computers do is compute. That's what they do. That's why they're called computers, because they compute.
- 7.75** Now, human beings compute, but that's not all we do. That's one tiny aspect of the whole rational life that human beings have, are. For Lowe, it would be, immediately, I mean, I don't think he wrote much on AI before he died, but what the person who thinks that AI can become completely equivalent and effectively identical to a human mind is effectively saying that ordinary physical processes are perfectly capable of engaging in rational, non-causal, non-physical processes of inference and reasoning and so on and so forth.
- 7.76** That reasons are causes, reasons are mass energy transfers. Computers compute using mass energy transfers, lots of them, but not through logic or through understanding or through reasoning or through feeling or through desiring anything, because that's not what computers do. Computers compute. Thinking and understanding and desiring and willing and believing and being conscious do not involve computation.
- 7.77** We'll also look at psychological well-being and all the debates around: What is it to flourish as a person? Psychology—is this a purely scientific enterprise? Well, if it is a purely scientific enterprise, then congratulations, psychologists. You've solved the mind-body problem. Would you mind sharing the answer with us? Why you think that persons, when it comes to their psychology, are to be treated or understood, medicated, in roughly the way that they would be if they had a sore arm or if they were suffering from flu?
- 7.78** You can see that how you answer the mind-body problem will completely determine and shape what sense you make of psychology and therapy, or which different schools of therapy and psychology would be more consistent with what you think is true about the relationship between mind and body. You could imagine, if you really thought you were a physicalist, and this mind thing was just this elaborate folk story that we tell ourselves, then you might be more inclined towards more clinical solutions in

psychology. If you cultivate the life of the mind, you believe you have a soul, etc., you'll probably be inclined to different ways and different theories that purport to address your psychological distress.

- 7.79** Thirdly, this question of enhancement, really neuro-enhancement, companies like Neuralink and many, many others, and ethical debates there about, at what point does personal identity begin to be eroded when you are either being genetically enhanced or whether you are being enhanced in some other way, maybe through drugs that help you run better or study better or whatever it might be? How are we to think of those?
- 7.80** Is this transhumanism or is it superhumanism? In some ways, we've been using technology to enhance ourselves for centuries. A pacemaker is a fantastic piece of technology, for example, that we're grateful for, that prolongs lives, that improves human lives, and it doesn't change a person. We're not worried about the person becoming a different person because they've got this. We're grateful that we'll see more of them.
- 7.81** Then there are other things looking down the track in terms of technology enhancement, technologies that are quite a lot more concerning. We'll look at some of those in the final lecture. Then, finally, we'll be looking at how these lectures have helped us think about: What is it to be me? What is it to have an identity, a personal perspective on the world, and how does that help us think about meaning? What does that help us have to say to the so-called meaning crisis, which Jordan Peterson and John Vervaeke and Jonathan Pageau have addressed so many times in such illuminating ways over the years?
- 7.82** A lot of the way you're going to, the direction you take in answering that question—What is meaning? How can I live a meaningful life?—is going to be downstream of the conclusions that you reach from the debates that we've touched on in this course. Whether there is an I, whether it is the subject, the possessor of conscious experience that is not reducible to science, that is mine and mine alone, that I alone have private, privileged access to, and so on and so forth. It's what makes me me. I can't be divided, I can't be copied, I can't be substituted, etc. This is the dualist claim.
- 7.83** Just to come into land, we've now looked, spent a second lecture, really, canvassing dualist options, and that is going to give you, I hope, a stereoscopic perspective on the mind-body problem as we go into the issues that I gave you a trailer for just now, for the next lecture. But hopefully, whether you find these arguments or not, you will at least be forced to think harder and harder about what the relationship is between purely physical processes and the conscious experience that makes it possible for me to be me. Thanks for listening.

Lecture 8: Mind in Machine?

At a glance — Mind in machine? — artificial intelligence and whether machines could think.

- 8.1** Welcome to lecture eight in Introduction to Philosophy of Mind. In this lecture, we're going to have a lot of fun. We're going to be bringing together a lot of the more technical, abstract, theoretical ideas that we've been touching on in the first seven lectures, and we're going to try and apply them, or try to understand a range of contemporary issues in public policy and in culture through the lens of our newly enhanced understanding of the puzzle of mind and of consciousness.
- 8.2** We'll start by looking at AI and artificial intelligence and questions as to whether machines or robots could ever be conscious, could therefore ever be free and minded, and so on and so forth. How do we understand what LLMs are, or what AI-driven robots might be? How do we analyze them? Could they ever be persons?
- 8.3** Secondly, we'll be looking at the questions around psychology and psychoanalysis. I touched on this in the previous lecture, the way in which we answer—the position that we take on the relationship between mind and body is going to shape how we understand how to relieve suffering in the mind or mind as brain, if that's what it's believed to be.
- 8.4** Third, we'll look at this question of neuro-enhancement or bodily enhancement, what that does. Does that affect who we are as people? Does it undermine our personal identity? Can we make sense of the extended mind hypothesis? We'll touch on that, the way in which there are some philosophers who think that the iPhone in your pocket is somehow, actually, an extension of your mind, an extension of your mental powers, that the mind can spread itself out upon the world.
- 8.5** Finally, we'll look at this question of meaning and the way in which having a stable understanding of what personhood and identity consist in is going to have a huge impact downstream on how you tackle questions of meaning, whether you think that life does have a meaning, and if so, what it might be. These are not just theoretical puzzles. There are four examples of questions that matter in real life, matter in the real world, beyond the philosophy lecture room.
- 8.6** Let's start with this question of artificial intelligence. In many ways, this is a dream that human beings have had for a very long time, but it really only starts to become a reality in the course of, actually, in the course of the Second World War, as a number of very brilliant mathematicians and crossword specialists and classicists were brought into a place called Bletchley Park, just between Oxford and Cambridge, in England. And this became a hub of cryptography, an extremely brilliant cryptography, over the course of two or three years.

- 8.7** Very early on, a brilliant young man called Alan Turing developed a machine that was able to reduce the time that it took to crack the supposedly impenetrable German Abwehr Enigma codes that were thought to be completely uncrackable, simply because the codes changed at every 24-hour intervals, and simply the time that it would take human beings to go through all the different possibilities in getting the code, rendering the code into the original German, was beyond anything that the world population at the time could have done in that time.
- 8.8** What Turing does is to produce, effectively, a machine that allows them to effectively crack the codes, crack messages within 5 to 6 hours of the new settings coming through. It's an extraordinary achievement. Turing writes quite a lot about computing and the philosophy of how to understand what's going on with computing. There's a famous article he writes in 1950 called Computing Machinery and Intelligence.
- 8.9** He develops this idea that becomes known as the Turing Test, or sometimes called the imitation game. The idea is that, if you're a human being, you should be able to, basically, you can converse by text with a human, or you could do it with a machine, even back then. And Turing's point is that a computer shows intelligence, as it were, as soon as he can fool the human judge into thinking that he's an intelligent human. That's it. If you can succeed in the imitation game, then a computer is basically a person, to all intents and purposes. This is the idea.
- 8.10** It's quite a strange test. You can probably tell, if you think back to our lecture on behaviorism, the idea that all that mind is, it's not some interior theater in our brains; everything is as you see it. Our mind is just expressed through our behavior. That's all that matters. We can infer people's beliefs, whether somebody's in pain, etc, etc, simply from analyzing their behavior.
- 8.11** Turing basically adopts a behaviorist approach here. He just says, "If the behavior of this machine is sufficiently believable, or can fool you into thinking that it's the behavior of a human being, then that's all that matters." It doesn't matter that there's no—one might be a zombie, the other might be a human being. It makes no difference. All that matters is the behavior.
- 8.12** In a way, that does sidestep the whole problem of consciousness. It just says there isn't any. There aren't any. But isn't the problem with the comparison that computers aren't conscious and they haven't got souls and minds? The Turing answer is, "No, that's just what human beings are anyway. Human beings don't have any of that. They think they do, but actually, it's just an illusion."
- 8.13** We've come a long way, however, with contemporary AI, from anything that Turing could really have imagined to be possible. The question is: Is this increasing quantitative complexity in artificial intelligence— larger and larger, large language models that this software is processing—is consciousness something that pops out at a certain level of complexity?

- 8.14** There comes a point where the LLM is so big or so tightly and effectively organized that, boom, it becomes like us? It becomes an I. It becomes a conscious, aware subject. Well, we've looked at some problems with that view. Remember when we were talking about John Searle and emergentism, and this sense that there's a moment of magic that has to happen once you get past that magic threshold of complexity and then, boom, suddenly you're conscious? That seems a little bit odd.
- 8.15** Or you remember Ned Block's objection to functionalism, where he says that it can't be the case that the human mind is just a question of a functionally organized system. What if every citizen in China was coordinated in such a way to produce a single overriding function? The next sunlit uplands in industry or whatever it might be—you can imagine the whole population of China being coordinated in this incredibly organized functional way. Would we say that China has a mind? That block of people, suddenly, there emerges this subjective consciousness from it? That seems very, very odd.
- 8.16** There are other, more famous objections to the computational way of thinking about the mind. That is to say, the mind is very complex. We don't understand consciousness, but computers are probably the most sophisticated thing that we've ever come up with. So whatever's going on in the mind, it's got to somehow resemble the computer in some ways.
- 8.17** This is the science envy. It's technophilia. I've got it, whatever the science says, we've got it. Our ideas have to mesh with the science. Our ideas in philosophy have to mesh with science. There's definitely that mood, the climate, in many philosophy departments.
- 8.18** I was actually reading a history of the mind-body problem a few years ago by a brilliant scholar, a historian called Margaret Boden. She makes the point that at one point in the 19th century, a feature of human psychology was explained—the relationship between the psychology and the body, between the software and the hardware, was explained in terms of the technology that had just been invented for the telegram.
- 8.19** Imagine the invention of the telegram was probably more astonishing than the invention of, certainly, the internet and possibly even AI. Imagine that the time that it takes for you to get a message from London to Delhi, like three weeks, and in the space of a month or so, with the arrival of this technology, it goes from three weeks to five minutes. Just astonishing. All of a sudden, the world—talk about globalization and interconnectedness. I mean, what an extraordinary moment to live through.
- 8.20** And so, philosophers of mind at the time were wondering, what is this mysterious—what is the mind? What is consciousness? How do we understand it? And the response of some was, "Well, we're not quite sure what it is, but the telegram technology, it must be something like that. It's an incredibly complex phenomenon. How do we understand consciousness? We don't know how to do it. It's incredibly complicated.

- 8.21** What is the other incredibly complicated, difficult, sophisticated thing that we know of? The most complicated and sophisticated, impressive? Telegram technology. And so the mind must be something like, not completely like, but something like the telegram, in what it's achieving." I think something like this is happening in the late 1960s, 1970s, in philosophy, with the emergence of the computer, these astonishing breakthroughs in computational science, not really any other science, sadly.
- 8.22** But in computational science, you have these big leaps forward from the late '70s onwards. I think there was also that temptation to say, "Well, software and hardware, this must be the correct way, analogy, to understand mind and body. You've got the hardware, and then there's this slightly magic digital, non-material stuff that makes the hardware work, which is mind and consciousness."
- 8.23** One of the philosophers growing up—working in Silicon Valley, is John Searle, who died just very recently, actually, in a care home in Florida. Searle, in the early 1980s, resisted this and developed some very interesting arguments, probably the most famous of which is an argument drawn from a thought experiment. Thought experiments are philosophers' ways to tease out our intuitions about a particular situation.
- 8.24** The thought experiment is known as the Chinese room. It's the Chinese room argument or the Chinese room thought experiment. What he asks us to imagine is this. You're in a cube in the middle of a room. There's lots of stacks of books around. There's, around you, these codebooks, these rulebooks. Then there's an in-tray and then an out-tray.
- 8.25** You're told that the only way you can get out of this room is if you take the instructions from the in-tray, which will be contained various symbols. Then there's a rulebook for how to turn those symbols into a different set of symbols. You write them out, according to the rulebook. Then you put it in the out-tray, and then boom, you're done. You have to do that for a whole day.
- 8.26** With a closer look at what's in the in-tray, it's clear that these are, effectively, Chinese symbols. I then have to go and consult all these different books that are not dictionaries. They're not Chinese-to-English dictionaries. They're just symbols with rules telling me how to turn one symbol into another symbol, and I do it all correctly.
- 8.27** Once I followed all the rules and completed the exercise, I put it in the out-tray, and somebody takes it away. I don't understand Chinese. At no point in this process do I have any idea what those symbols mean. I don't understand them at all. However, I want to get out of the room. So, I am being very careful about how I apply all the different rules, making sure I'm doing exactly what I'm told at each moment.
- 8.28** What's the point of the thought experiment? The point of the thought experiment is that, for Searle, the Chinese room perfectly replicates what computers do. It perfectly illuminates, by contrast, what computers do, but which human beings can also do, but can do something completely different. It's the difference between processing and understanding. At no point do I have any idea what those symbols mean, from the in-

tray to the out-tray. What I do have is a rulebook that helps me to show how to arrange the symbols and manipulate the symbols in particular ways.

8.29 The distinction there in the philosophy of language is between semantics—what a word means—and syntax—the arrangement of words, the arrangement of sentences. So, man bites dog. I know what a man means, I know what a dog means, I know what biting means. That's the semantics. But the syntax is, man bites dog; can't be dog bites man or bites dog man. Those are two different exercises. You can do the syntax without knowing anything about the semantics, if you've got the rules.

8.30 Searle's claim is that that's all the computers can do. All they have are rulebooks. They don't understand anything. Computers compute. They can manipulate symbols. They can process symbols according to certain programs, but they don't understand anything. It's just ones and zeros. They don't understand anything. In the same way that I, in the room, would not understand what the message was saying in Chinese, nor the message that I received was saying in Chinese, nor the message that I turned into something else was saying for the out-tray.

8.31 This is what computers do, Searle insists. They manipulate symbols without understanding meaning. What that means is that any process like that, any computational process like that, is not going to yield any understanding or consciousness. Therefore, since we do have understanding, we can understand words, we can do semantics, it's not just rule-following, there is a radical difference between a computer, what's going on in a computer, and what's going on in our minds.

8.32 Therefore, strong AI, that is to say, the difference between strong AI and weak AI, is that strong AI is that computers will literally be able, can or will be able, literally to think and be conscious and be intelligent and be presumably free, to have free will and therefore be morally responsible, therefore to maybe have some robot dignity, perhaps to have rights and so on and so forth. That's a strong AI.

8.33 Weak AI is really all the other different things that the AI is going to be able to do, which is broadly functionally equivalent to all of the computational-style capacities, computational capacities of the human being, and a great deal better than that. But the implications of the Chinese room argument from Searle is that there will never be strong AI. This is a complete fantasy. It's not going to happen because computers cannot and will not ever be able to think.

8.34 It's not some limitation in the technology that is the reason why computers are never going to be able to think. Computers are not capable of thinking. Persons are capable of thinking. Conscious agents, conscious subjects, are capable of thinking. That is to say, non-physical beings are capable of non-physical activities. But a computer is always a physical being, and therefore is not capable of entertaining things in a non-physical way, or having any real contact with abstract objects in that way.

- 8.35** What else is there to be said about AI? I mean, another puzzle, of course, is a question of— it's an epistemic one, so it's a question to do with our confidence, our epistemic confidence, the confidence of our beliefs in determining whether or not a robot ever is conscious and free and minded. How would that conversation go?
- 8.36** The top AI company unveils, at a big, glamorous conference in Silicon Valley, this robot that claimed to be free and conscious and with a mind and able to experience the world in the way that human beings are. The question would be: How do we know? Do you sit down with a robot and say, "Robbie, tell me the truth. Do you really experience the world in a conscious way, just like I do? Do you really have the beliefs and desires and feelings that human beings do?"
- 8.37** What does a convincing answer from Robbie look like? "Of course, I see the world in exactly the way that you do. I have a mind, I'm free. Look, I'm pushing you now, freely." What do we say? Do I believe Robbie? Well, I believe human beings, I think that they're being trustworthy, and I've got no obvious reason to think that they have been drinking or that they've got something against me.
- 8.38** But with Robbie, it's—I don't know. Is he malfunctioning? We might say: Is he functioning or is he malfunctioning? But no, he's just a machine. He's just a machine. He's telling me, but he's telling me he's conscious, and he's telling me that he's not lying and he's being honest, and he'll make my life so much easier if I believe him, and so on and so forth. How do we respond? What I want to say is that there will always be a total gap between any human person and any robot, however impressive. It will never be possible.
- 8.39** Now, you might say that that's true of ordinary human beings. You can never be sure with other human beings. But on the whole, it is rational for us to trust other human beings, unless we've got a very, very strong reason not to do so. With robots, what are you trusting? I mean, how can you trust a thing? You can rely on something. You can rely on a walking stick or a pacemaker. You might be able to rely on Robbie. He never lets you down. You might talk in the way that you might talk about a dog or something.
- 8.40** But do I trust Robbie never to let me down? Is he the kind of person who doesn't let his friends down? He's not that kind of guy. He's not that kind of robot. I don't want to say in that, you can hear in that way of framing it, that this is a confusion here. It's a confusion in how we're understanding what a robot could be. Maybe that's only a confusion if you do cling to this idea that there is something that it's like to be me that is not purely physical.
- 8.41** Maybe there'll be some Silicon Valley tech bros who just say, "What's the problem? We're all computers, anyway. It's all about external behavior. And Robbie is as much a person as you are, bigot." You can imagine all kinds of fights breaking out, new culture wars, new fronts in the culture wars.

- 8.42** But I think the claims for strong AI are wildly implausible, and we're nowhere closer now to being convinced that the mind is like a computer than, really, we were in the late 1970s. It's not really a view that has really established itself convincingly, at least within philosophy. Though, of course, the development of AI technology has led a lot of people to think that that is the right way to understand the mind and conscious behavior.
- 8.43** The second theme I want to look at, the second applied theme, is this question of psychology, and I've mentioned it before in the lectures. In particular, this puzzle around—the philosophical problems are distilled very nicely into this phrase "mental health." Mental health. It seems like a phrase that we've heard a million times. We know what it is. We talk about it. We might talk about our own mental health or somebody else's mental health.
- 8.44** Of course, one of the problems here, when we've been through a whole course in the philosophy of mind and trying to think about what the mental is, and whether it's a physical thing, just another physical thing, whether it's something completely distinct from a physical thing, immediately that phrase is going to start to raise some questions. Because the whole mind-body problem just is the problem of whether or not we can talk about the mind as if it were some scientific object or some object of the medical sciences.
- 8.45** You've broken your arm, you get a doctor to go and look at your arm, inspect your arm, do an X-ray; and then you've got a broken mind, and you go to the doctor, and you ask the doctor to inspect your broken mind and to prescribe something like—he fixed your arm, why can't he fix your mind? And it's simple. Immediately, we start to see, well, hold on. The mind is not—if it is a physical thing, it's a very different physical thing from—if it's just that gooey gray yogurt in the skull, it's not the same stuff as the stuff in my arm.
- 8.46** Even if it is stuff, there's something kind of magic about this stuff. But what is it to—I could X-ray a broken arm, get a plaster cast, some painkillers, done. If you're suffering from some traumatic disorder, psychiatric disorder, what do you do to the yogurt? Do you just twirl it around a bit? It immediately becomes a very, very difficult idea, once we start, as it were, medicalizing the mind, or thinking of our psychology, our conscious life, as the same as our bodily life, same as what's going on, when I think that what's going on in our brains is what's going on in our arms.
- 8.47** Now, if you're a physicalist, this is how philosophy of mind affects the position; if you're a physicalist, then yeah, that's completely appropriate. Mental health just is physical health. Mental health is a division of physical health because the mind is physical. The mind is the brain, and that's all it is.
- 8.48** And so, OK, maybe our medical technology and our pharmaceutical or pharmacological advances mean that it's a lot easier for us to fix a broken arm than it is for us to fix a

broken mind, broken brain. But that's where we are right now. Just give us time and money, and over the years, we'll work out how to manipulate the gray goo to make sure everyone's always happy. It's just a matter of time. It's just a bit more complicated. A lot more complicated, but we'll get there one day. That's the physicalist view.

- 8.49** On the dualist view, that's nonsense. It's to completely confuse the kind of thing that a person is, that a subject is, that consciousness is, that beliefs are, that desires and feelings are, with, i. e., is completely to confuse non-physical reality with gray yogurt, with stuff. There's no problem at all for the dualist in thinking in terms of psychological suffering, subjective suffering, subjectivelyfelt psychological pain.
- 8.50** All the dualist is going to say is that that's a completely different suffering from physical suffering. There may be some correlation between the two. Obviously, if you've got a headache, that's going to affect your mood, it's going to affect your conscious experience. Similarly, conscious experience, like grief, will have physical manifestations, crying. That's not the problem here.
- 8.51** What the dualist is going to say is that these are completely distinct experiences. Non-physical psychological grief or suffering is a completely different thing, even if psychological suffering can have physical manifestations, and even if physical suffering can have obviously psychological manifestations.
- 8.52** But as soon as you start to think of the mind as an object of medical science, and something that a cottage industry of doctors and pharmaceutical companies can somehow manipulate and fix, in roughly the way that one could manipulate and fix a broken arm, then one starts thinking of thought, everything within the conscious mind—consciousness, thoughts, intentions, emotions, behaviors—as somehow problems to be treated or diseases to be treated.
- 8.53** This pathologizes—it's a different reduction, scientific reduction, of the mental to the material. This is more of a, you might call a nosological, so it's done in terms of disease, so that any unwanted mental states are thought of as part of an illness, symptoms of an illness. If you can just get rid of those, boom, as it were, you've cured the mind.
- 8.54** What's the problem with this? Well, the problem with this is that even if you think of psychological suffering as a disease—and you shouldn't, you should really think of it as a metaphor, it's like it's similar to, you might say that psychological suffering is to the mind what actual diseases are to the body. The reason you need to make that distinction is that the distinction between a disease and a disorder is that—well, there are many— but mental disorders don't have the biological markers that any disease has.
- 8.55** For a disorder to be conveyed, you need the subject to tell you true things about his or her inner life. With a disease, you get any competent doctor to examine the patient, and then, without consulting with each other, most of the doctors will come and tell you, "This is the disease, this is the problem." Not even the brilliant, the most brilliant

psychiatrists and psychologists in the world or neuroscientists in the world, can do a physical medical experiment on a patient and find out why he's so down. It's not going to happen.

- 8.56** It's not because they're brilliant doctors—not brilliant doctors. They're fundamentally different things. We think about and diagnose mental disorders not through any physical test, but through self-reported feelings, depression, anxiety, whatever it might be, or possibly behavioral criteria. There are all good reasons why we should resist an attempt to turn psychology into a perfect form of medical science.
- 8.57** One of the other differences between disorders and diseases: consciousness can't be measured. There's no measurement for it. There's no way to quantify it, like temperature or mass or something like that. Subjective experiences can't be quantified. If neuroscientists tell us that when you're feeling this way, there's some underlying configuration of brain states that can be affected by this pharmaceutical, whatever it might be, then again, there's confusion as to what's causing what.
- 8.58** There could be a correlation between brain states and mental states. Maybe brain states do light up on a scan when I'm thinking about ice cream. But that doesn't mean that it's the brain states that are making me think about ice cream. It just means that when I think about ice cream, there is a correlate in the brain. There's a neural correlate, correlate in the brain. That's not a problem for dualists.
- 8.59** There may be a problem for dualists explaining how the connection between those two is possible. But that's distinct from the worry that those scans show that the causal traffic only flows in one direction. There's no reason for the dualist to accept that. Again, I think I used the analogy in an earlier lecture of the radio. You could have a broken radio, a radio that's not picking up the signal properly, but the content of the radio program is what it is. I mean, that's clear and coherent.
- 8.60** But it may be that the means that we have for broadcasting our rationality, broadcasting our intelligence, are our brains. On that analogy, you think of the brain as the radio, but our mind and our thoughts and our intentions are the radio program that are conveyed through the radio. The radio may be, if you've had brain damage, just as if you smash up your radio, it's going to broadcast the program less perfectly than if it was intact.
- 8.61** Other problems with, or other implications of philosophy of mind to this issue of psychological suffering and mental health and so on, yes, it's the philosophical error that I've been stressing, that you can't reduce mental phenomena to neurochemical, neurophysiological processes.
- 8.62** And nor could questions of meaning and significance and identity, all of those complex themes that will always be woven into anybody's autobiography, whether those could ever be replicated or captured simply through brain scans or simply through some particular set of principles or protocols developed by this or that school of psychology. I

think, as I mentioned before, psychology's had—got to be careful; I'm hoping Jordan Peterson is not listening to this, but my view, and I've told him this before, in fact—psychology is an avenue of human inquiry that's had well over 120 years to prove itself to the world as a science.

- 8.63** If it was correct that the psychē in psychology is genuinely soul and not just brain matter, then you would expect what has happened to psychology in the last 100 years to happen as it did, as it did happen—namely, a fragmentation of the discipline into lots of different schools, most of which are conflicting with each other and don't agree with each other, and so on and so forth.
- 8.64** What would we say about physics or biology if, after 120 years, you had five or six major schools, all of which disagreed with each other? We'd probably say, "That discipline is in trouble. Something fundamental has gone wrong here." I want to suggest that the fundamental thing that went wrong was thinking that the soul and the mind and consciousness was basically like any other scientific object of inquiry, like any other physical object.
- 8.65** The reason it basically, I think, failed as a science, failed to have the track record of success that other sciences have, even after 125, 130 years, is because it's picked something that is not, in fact, a scientific object, that is not, in fact, legible by science. That's what you would expect to see, if it were the case that minds were real, there's something irreducible, that there's something non-physical, non-scientific, non-medical about our inner lives.
- 8.66** Moving on now to the third area that I wanted to talk about in terms of the application of philosophy of mind, and that's neurotechnology and technological enhancements, tech humanists, transhumanists, modifications and enhancements. There's the most extraordinary technology being developed out there. We've got neural prosthetics, obviously, for paralyzed patients. Nobody's ever been too worried about that.
- 8.67** Then we get to things like brain stimulation or deep brain stimulation that seems to alter personalities in some ways. There are memory enhancement drugs and experiments and technologies available now. This throws up a whole load of questions about the human mind and the human person, and how would these technological developments affect us, affect our understanding of what it is to be human?
- 8.68** I've mentioned the extended mind thesis already. This is David Chalmers and Andy Clark and others have developed this thought. This is the idea that, effectively, if what you think of the mind as doing is just providing you with this very effective tool for navigating the world, if our inner cognitive processes are basically a little bit like instruments or tools, then, argue Chalmers and Clark, you can talk about having an extended mind by having other tools that help you navigate the world, like an iPhone or a laptop or some other technology.

- 8.69** It's a way of mapping ourselves onto the world. The only difference is that one process is happening inside the skull and another process is happening outside the skull. Is there any philosophically interesting difference between being inside a skull and outside a skull? No. It's got a bit of gray yogurt, and then I've got an iPhone, and they're very two different things, but they help me do X. They are mental activities; they're not physical activities in the normal sense. They're just functions.
- 8.70** On this view, the iPhone is literally part of my mind. My mind is extended into it, and I use it as an extension of my mind, in which case tech enhancement started a long time ago, on that view. There's this interesting question as to how we should understand these differences, what precisely is an acceptable use of these technologies and which isn't. One way to think about this would be to think in terms of what it is to be human. Of course, there's going to be huge differences in how that's understood.
- 8.71** If you're a physicalist, there's nothing that it is like to be a human. To be a human is to be an animal that's configured in certain ways, that has popped out at the end of a long evolutionary process. There's no real essence to what it is to be a human being. There's no real dignity or moral value inherent in being a human being, beyond that which is conferred on human beings by international law courts or rights-based regimes or whatever it might be.
- 8.72** The question is: Should that view be accepted, or should we take a more dualist or hylomorphist perspective, which says, "No, there is a reality to the human person. It's not something we can simply ignore or reduce without remainder to purely natural physical processes"? Here, an interesting distinction on the enhancement debate is one made by Aristotle.
- 8.73** Aristotle is very clear to distinguish between substances, natural substances, that is to say, substances that have got internal principles of change and direction and goal-seeking, like the acorn has with respect to the oak tree. You can see that the acorn is internally organized and directed towards one day becoming an oak tree; he hopes, dreaming of it. That, for Aristotle, is a natural substance.
- 8.74** Then there are artifacts where the external purpose is imposed upon the object, like a wheel or a pen or a knife. The only way to understand what a knife is for is not to examine it and to put it in the soil and water it and feed it. It's to ask: What is the externally imposed purpose on this object? Which, if decomposed, would decompose into natural substances like the acorn. But Aristotle absolutely says that we've got to draw a distinction here. The two are completely different things.
- 8.75** The acorn has an internal purposiveness, as a natural form that defines it to be what it is, that fixes its destiny. It means that it will never become a willow tree. However much it dreams of it, it's always going to be an oak tree. It's got an organic unity and a hierarchical organization, which is totally different from a pen or a knife. There, the purpose is put on from the outside. Its form is artificial. It's got no particular essence

that defines it as what it is. The only direction it has toward slicing bread or writing a letter is the ones that the knifemaker and the penmaker have added to it.

- 8.76** We can then think about this in terms of human enhancement. One obvious objection might be that we are natural beings. We are, first and foremost, we belong to the natural world, not to the artifactual world. Human beings are not artifacts. We're definitely on the acorn end of the spectrum, rather than the knife and pen end of the spectrum, quite plausibly. That seems as an intuitively plausible distinction.
- 8.77** For many people, certainly for Aristotle, human beings also have their, like the acorn, their internal intrinsic purposes and directions towards a life of flourishing and fulfillment, which Aristotle sets out very well in Book 1 of the Nicomachean Ethics, his great work on ethics. We're oriented towards certain goals and horizons. There now might be theological versions of this. We're oriented towards the beatific vision or eternal union with God. But there might be completely secular versions of it, too.
- 8.78** We're oriented towards a life of relatively pain-free prosperity and flourishing in relationship with others and at peace with those around us or something like that — "eudaimonia," in Aristotle's word, a state of flourishing, and we're not always going to achieve that, but that's the end towards which human beings are directed internally.
- 8.79** Again, when we think about tech enhancement and transhumanism, it's pretty obvious that enhancements can very easily treat human beings as natural substances, in fact, as artifacts that can be fixed and mended and so on. You have problems here with transplants. OK, maybe if a liver has been donated to you, because your liver is packed in, OK, you've got somebody else's liver, but you're still you, aren't you? Well, maybe mostly.
- 8.80** I would say, your kidneys pack in. Somebody generously donates their kidneys to you, then your pancreas, and then— and so, we get to the point here where, how much of me, my embodied self, can I surrender without ceasing to be me? On the physicalist view, well, you've literally just lost 6% of yourself and then 5%, that's what you are. You're just a physical entity. That's all you are. Take a third of you away, there's two-thirds of you left, or there's some story along those lines.
- 8.81** On dualism, remember the brain split, Swinburne's brain split, from the previous lecture, the fission between two brain hemispheres? Swinburne's point is that there's not that there's two I's, that the I has been split into two, and there's I and I moving off into two new lives. No, it's either the I is extinguished at the point of the split, or it's gone in one direction or the other. It can't be both.
- 8.82** And so, those are the questions that might affect how we understand the ethics of tech enhancement. When it comes to questions of the brain with Neuralink and so on, that gets even more interesting because here, the dualist can simply say that whatever's being uploaded by Neuralink into the mind, into the brain, is having an impact on our

neuroscientific, neurophysiological processes; and somehow it's generating something that's conscious or is correlated with something that's conscious.

- 8.83** It's changing the way we're thinking in some way, which is presumably the claim, presumably the point, of Neuralink. Is that a puzzle? Is it a problem? I mean, on either view, certainly on the dualist view, well, there's nothing in dualism that denies that external objects can make us think a different way or change our conscious experience. If somebody smacks me on the head with a baseball bat, then in a much more primitive, crude way, that is also a case of some physical object affecting how I'm feeling about life, affecting my conscious experience.
- 8.84** Now, we hope that the Neuralink upload is going to be very, very different, much more pleasant experience than that. But the point is that it's not philosophically different. There's nothing that—the dualist is not going to say, "Oh my goodness, it turns out that the physical can impact the non-physical. It turns out that what happens in the physical world can actually affect my mind and my thoughts and so on." That is not a problem the dualist is worried about. Of course, that's true.
- 8.85** All the dualist says is that the traffic goes in both directions. My mind can make me do things. It can have an impact on the physical world. Yeah, of course, the physical world is going to throw all kinds of things back at me, which I might feel happy about or miserable about, or I'll certainly have views about. It's not a problem.
- 8.86** The question is probably more the ethical one. To what extent does this somehow erode my sense of personal identity? Oddly, I think, for the dualist, it's probably not much of a problem. Again, to go back to the brain hemisphere fission example, just as it's not possible to carve me up, the I up, this center of subjectivity up into, say, a 30% I and a 40% I, and then a 30% I of two, three, four different I's. Similarly, you can't divide, but also you can't multiply, or you can't expand.
- 8.87** What is it to expand something that is simply unified, unique, and completely simple, not composite, not divisible? You can't divide it, because it's a one-off, nor can you copy it. You can't have duplicates of it. It's not the kind of thing that can be duplicated or expanded or enhanced. Probably from the dualist point of view, tech enhancements and future of technological interaction with the human body, may be concerning in some ways. But the idea that it will erase the self, or somehow create a hybrid, a cyborg, a half-human, half-robot, or a minded robot in some way, seems wildly implausible. There will still be a self there.
- 8.88** It might be that these processes will kill you. They might get rid of the I. There'll be no more I. But it's not going to divide you, and it's not going to double you. It's not going to multiply you. The people who think that way don't understand what it is to be a unique, irreplaceable person. That is you, you and I, in a way that, obviously, physical things and robots can be multiplied and divided in all different ways.

- 8.89** We've had a brief reflection on this. Just to wrap up this third topic, what are the limits of enhancement? What are the limits of tech enhancement in particular? What can't technology extend? What can't it ever extend? Just as a matter of principle, regardless of how much money the scientists have got, how many labs, whatever it might be, how many geniuses, how many Nobel Prize winners, it will always be impossible to enhance rational agency, because reason is not something that the scientists can generate in the world from physical things, from computational processes.
- 8.90** You might say wisdom, human wisdom, is something that robots will never replicate, will never successfully have. They might be good at imitating wise people, but a robot can't be wise. Wisdom is something that comes from the experience of a lived human life. Authentic relationships—a robot will never be able to have an authentic relationship with a human being. It will always be—it might be able to imitate it. As we know, human beings will be fooled into thinking that there's a relationship happening, but there isn't.
- 8.91** There isn't in a way that there's a relationship between a man and his dog, and certainly not between—and other members of the animal kingdom—and certainly not between humans. It will never be—there could never be love between a robot and a human person or a friendship or any community. Why? Because human relationships require interdependence, vulnerability, mindedness, consciousness, and robots are simply not capable of that.
- 8.92** They're not free, they're not minded, they're not conscious. They don't have beliefs, they don't have desires, they don't want anything, and are not satisfied by anything, are not made happy by anything, will not grieve your loss, so on. Even though it'll be able to imitate, maybe it will be able to win the imitation game, there's nothing going on there. So on and so forth, other points that could be made in relation to this. But I think that gives you a sense of how we can apply philosophy of mind to neuro-enhancement, as well as to questions around mental health, and of course, the first topic, questions of artificial intelligence.
- 8.93** Coming in to land now, not just for this lecture, but for the whole series, we've reached the end of a very long journey, starting 2,500 years ago, hurtling through Plato, hurtling through Aristotle, hurtling through late antiquity and the Middle Ages, then into the early modern period. We looked at Descartes, the development of the early modern dualism.
- 8.94** We then moved into the modern world and looked at a great plethora of theories, from the physicalists trying to undermine the Cartesian dualist picture of the world, right deep into the 20th century, the rise of mind-brain identity theory, the rise of functionalism, the rise of behaviorism. Then in the penultimate two lectures, the return, the resurgence of dualism, in all sorts of interesting and sophisticated contemporary forms.

- 8.95** Then in this last lecture, we brought to bear everything we've learned about physicalism, everything we've learned about dualism, and the problems with each position. We brought it to bear on three classic problems in the modern world, in the contemporary context—AI, questions of mental health, mental suffering, and neuro-enhancement. I hope that what you've learned over the course of these lectures is just what a thrilling and complex area of philosophy this is.
- 8.96** In order to think about the mind and its relationship to the body, we've had to explore so many different areas of philosophy. We've had to explore the nature of language, the nature of knowledge, moral obligation, how we understand abstract objects and mathematics, how we make sense of our personal identity, how we invest our lives with meaning, the meaning that conscious experience seems to give it, if we're supposed to think of the conscious experience as nothing but the firings of our neurophysiology and our synaptic connections.
- 8.97** We've also seen how these dinner parties with the dead—whether it's Plato or Aristotle, Augustine, Aquinas—these are always fertile sources to help us think about these deep questions in a way that are not shrouded in the assumptions and the starting points that affect many, many philosophers working today. By going right back to the past, we can start to see patterns emerging in the history of human thought, history of Western philosophy, as to how best to understand and grapple with this deepest of philosophical mystery: What am I? What is it to be conscious?
- 8.98** Maybe the deepest lesson in philosophy of mind is that understanding consciousness and understanding what it is to be an embodied self requires both science and philosophy. The two are not in conflict with each other. Both can illuminate a great deal about their respective domains. The problem comes when one of those domains gets collapsed into the other.
- 8.99** The idealists collapse the scientific into, you might say, the personal or the conscious. Materialists like to collapse the mental or the conscious into the material. They like to collapse mind into world. The idealists like to collapse world into mind. The challenge has been how to maintain those two in place, without them trespassing on each other's territories.
- 8.100** We've come to the end of the series, and I hope that you feel that you've come to grasp the complexities involved in understanding what it is to reason, to believe, to have feelings, to be a self, to be a conscious self. I hope you'll come away from these lectures with a renewed appreciation of the power of philosophy to illuminate some of those most intractable questions. Thank you for listening.